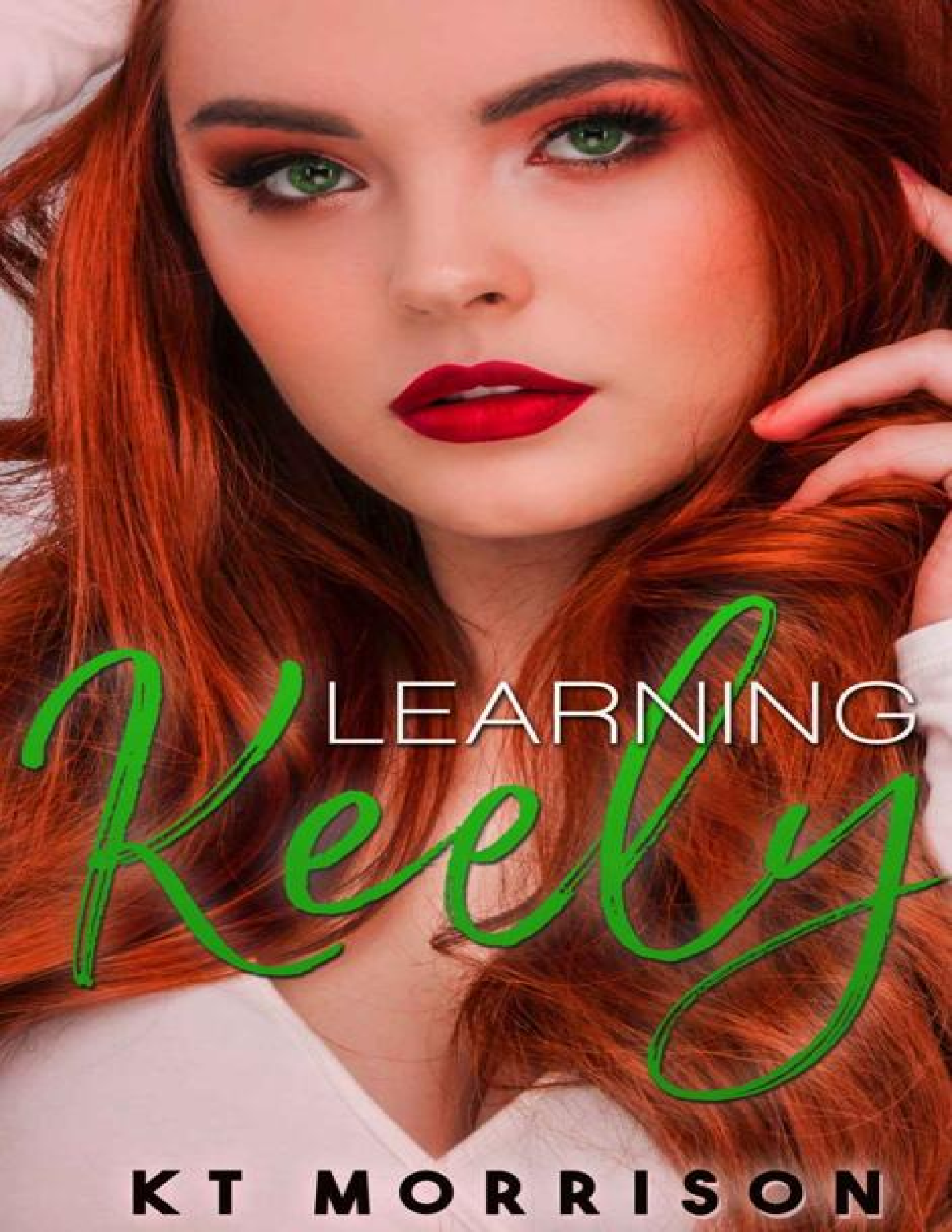




LEARNING
Reeky

KT MORRISON

LEARNING KEELY

KT MORRISON

Contents

About the Author

Also by KT Morrison

I. Duo // 2

1. Pinball & Peppers
2. Breakups 2 Makeups
3. Old Wounds
4. Big Girls, Big Boys
5. Confessions
6. Open Windows

II. Duo // 3

7. Nocturnal Emissions
8. Hiatus

III. Trio

9. Downtown Marriott
10. Rockwell Court
11. American Dream
12. Growing
13. Suite
14. Together
15. Dots
16. Confessional
17. Patch
18. Family

Afterword

About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

Visit My Website!

ktmorrison.com

Also by KT Morrison

SERIES

Landlord

Obsessed

The Cayman Proxy

Separate Schools

Keely

Six Weeks In Winter

EPIC NOVELS

Cherry Blossoms

Maggie

Learning Lessons

Happy Endings

NOVELS

Going A Little Too Far

Pool Party

Après Ski

NOVELLAS

Watching Natalie Cheat

Watching Natalie Again

Inconceivable

Mary's Pledge

ANTHOLOGIES

The Taken Anthology

This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

LEARNING KEELY

A **KEELY** book

56,500 words

First Edition. March 21, 2019.

Copyright © 2019 KT Morrison

Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

PART 1

Duo // 2

FEBRUARY 14 - FEBRUARY 15

Pinball & Peppers

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN DONE a few weeks ago at the latest. The longer she put it off the easier it was to withhold because it should already have been done. A self-perpetuating cycle of avoidance; the compulsive denier's heat-engine drinking bird.

"Step back again," Max said, "Let me look at you."

"You're ridiculous," she told him, but did what he asked without a second thought, rolling her eyes up to the ceiling and looking away while her new boyfriend checked out her body she'd squeezed into the beautiful dress he'd bought her. Two weeks ago, he'd taken her to a boutique when she'd visited NYC to spend the weekend with him. She'd tried on a few dresses, but he would only let her select Oscar de la Renta. Idiot. The dress was almost two-grand. But God, was it beautiful. And they'd had the best time picking it out. She'd had a sort-of-boyfriend in Abu Dhabi who'd bought her a dress for five-grand but he was no fun; in the end her mother shit her bed when she found out her daughter had been given such a gift. *You know what he'll want, Keely? Jaysus, mum, I've already given it to him, the dress was a thank you, believe you me.* But with Max it wasn't anywhere the same. With Max they were a couple, a two-person unit, and he wasn't out to show her his wealth (he didn't really have it, just a good job), and the whole day's punch line was that he would buy her an Oscar de la Renta dress because it was a name she liked to pronounce. She pushed back because of the expense but he was insistent, so she let him.

A blue so deep the dress looked black, but in the right light it came out in indigo, and it was incredible against her hair. Up the front bodice and

down the skirt were bright primary embroidered botanicals in a Swiss milkmaid sort of design. She wore high heels in silver and toted a silver handbag.

“Keely,” he told her, meeting her eyes so she knew it was for real, “you look so incredible I can’t stand it.”

She bopped his head with her handbag, kissed his lips. “You’re such a sap, Max.”

“Yeah, so what?” he said.

She agreed, letting him hug her, looking in his eyes and saying, “Yeah, so what.”

They were in Manhattan, in the East Village, standing in the vestibule at Miss Connie’s—a Jamaican restaurant kitty corner from Tompkins Square Park. Max and she’d had the whole day off, and they’d spent the morning in bed where Max did amazing things to her with his tongue, and they fucked like horny little bunnies, then they walked the village, came back, got dressed for dinner, went to Miss Connie’s 7A and ate a whack of Japanese peppers and lemon, played a lot of pinball, and drank way too much rum. Now they were in the vestibule that looked like a beach shack, waiting for their dinner companions to arrive.

And, fuck, she already should have told him and it would be weird to have dinner if she didn’t.

Tonight was a big night. For both of them.

Their dinner companions this ‘*evening of Valentine’s romance*’ were the esteemed former members of Max’s love trifecta. One Maggie Becker, who was lovely enough to introduce her to her magnificent beau; and the other, of course, Maggie’s own handsome beau, Cole. The one with whom she herself had had sex with. And therein lay the problem.

Tonight was a patching over, a troweling of fine clay sediment to make smooth something with crinkling cracks. Max’s dear friends, longtime friends, ones who he claimed he needed in his life wanted back in, and he *wanted* them back in. Wanted his new girlfriend to be part of his past, too. And why not?—wasn’t she once a good friend of Maggie’s...?

Her haunting thoughts gathered in the nooks and crannies of her expression, tightening it and giving her away. Max was studying her. He said, “You’ve got something on your mind, Keely, I can see it.”

“It’s all right,” she said, but it wasn’t. Maggie and Cole would be out front in a few minutes according to their texts.

He smiled, tracing hair off her face and giving her a warm look, thinking it was just she was anxious about seeing Maggie again after their rift.

“It’s weird for you, I know. But you’re friends. I’m friends. We need to get past this...”

“I’m not arguing about that, Max,” she said, turning away and running her hand through her hair. She turned back, showed him a happy face. He was lounging against the red-painted wall, a cork-board behind him festooned with promos for upcoming Caribbean bands. He was gorgeous; dark and deep, black eyes, black hair slicked back from his face. He wore a black suit and a navy button down, dark green knit tie; a peacoat, too, and held her parka over one arm. She fell against him and kissed his lips again.

When she backed away, he knew there was something behind her stalling; he was an intuitive man. He smiled, held her hand to stop her escape. It was just the two of them alone in the glass walled space. Patrons drank and dined behind them, pedestrians passed by in steady streams ahead.

“Is there more?” he asked her, but she could tell from the sweet smile he gave her, a patient one, that he thought it might be more girl trouble between her and Maggie; something he thought he could deal with.

It shouldn’t have taken her this long to tell him, but now she had no more time left for stalling.

She left his grasp, turned, looked inward to the restaurant where they’d just been, sitting at the bar laughing and enjoying tropical island drinks. She said, “Before we do any of this, before I sit down and have dinner with them again, and if you and I want to continue talking to each other, I have to be honest about something. It’s my own business, but I see it now: it’s important... I should have already told you...”

She turned to face him. The light was nice in here, maybe this *was* the right place. Quiet, intimate, but people nearby if things got ugly; and near to a hospital if Max fainted...

“What is it?” he said, placid expression, thinking he could handle this.

Out with it. She inhaled, held it, let it out. She said, “A long time ago, I *slept* with Cole.”

She’d never seen such an instant reaction. Max sidestepped then took a step back putting his hand out behind him to support himself before he fell. He thumped down heavily in a metal stool made of a tractor seat and

painted red, and put his back against the wall. He looked like a drunken sailor, or maybe, given his attire, a drunken luxury boat passenger after the ship had hit an iceberg. The ground had shifted under his feet and his face instantly took the greenish tinge of seasickness.

She wanted to rush to him, soothe him, make her revelation okay, but he was the one who needed to do that. She waited for him. He breathed heavily enough his cheeks puffed, and he looked with a dead stare across at the flashing lights of the pinball machine on the other side of the glass. Now his hand was at his neck, tugging at his tie and unbuttoning the top button of his shirt.

She said, "Are you going to be okay?"

"When?" he said, his voice a thin croak.

"At Farmingham."

"At Farmingham," he repeated, eyes rolled up, thinking about it. He said, "When was this?"

"My first year. I think I'd been there a month."

"What year was he in?"

"Senior."

Max looked around again, then rubbed at his cheeks. He said, "Yeah, okay. So you slept with him."

"I just have to be honest, Max."

"I appreciate it," he said but still couldn't meet her eyes.

She said, "Hey, would you look at me, please...?"

"Sorry," he said, shook his head and rubbed his palms on his thighs. He wriggled his mouth around, stretching his jaw—then looked in her eyes.

"I can't help the past, Max."

With a watery smile, he said, "You could've braced me a bit."

"Like a Band-Aid, Max."

At least it got him laughing. He said, "I guess you're right. It's done now."

"I'm sorry, maybe I could have braced you."

"You know what...? It's totally all right. Did you date him?"

"A couple nights, that was it."

"Okay," he said, rolling his head around on his neck. "Okay. That's good."

"Like I said, I can't change what I've already done."

"I don't expect you to. There's nothing wrong, I'm totally fine. I'm surprised he never told me."

"He never told you because..." She dropped it. *Cole didn't tell you because he and your former girlfriend needed it to work out between their buddy and Cole's red-headed hand-me-down; he didn't want to wreck it.*

Max nodded; neither of them acknowledging it, but Max wasn't stupid. Naive sometimes, but not stupid.

She said, "Can I give you a hug?"

He laughed. "Get over here," he said putting his arms out. She went to him, let him embrace her.

"It's not going to be a problem?" she whispered.

"It won't be."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be. There's nothing to be sorry about."

"I wish I told you sooner. I didn't know how mad you'd be."

"I'm not mad. A little freaked..."

"It's such a strange coincidence."

"Not really," he said, holding her and squeezing his arms around her waist, her downy parka between them. She leaned on him so hard his back pressed against the wall. "Beautiful girl went to Farm between '14 and '18, good chance she slept with Cole."

"It's not like that, Max," she said, feeling a little hurt by his callousness.

"I didn't mean it bad."

She rocked against him. "I'm just sorry it's the truth. It would be a lot easier for all of us if it wasn't."

"Don't worry, Keely. It really is okay. It caught me off guard, but I'm... better than you're probably thinking..."

He let it hang with obvious innuendo. Of course, she'd already thought of it: he was in a long-term relationship with a girl he really loved and had shared her with Cole. The worry was maybe for once Max saw Keely as something he could have for himself. What if that was the most exciting aspect? What if he lay in bed at night thinking about her, saying *She's all mine this one, all mine...*

She had only a moment to realize his hands held on her waist were trembling; before she acknowledged it, a car slowed to a stop outside the restaurant. She cradled his head, whispering, "I think they're here now, Max."

“Yup,” he said, and patted her bottom. Then when they parted, and she looked in his eyes, he asked her: “Does Maggie know?”

“Why, are you going to bring it up?” It got a light laugh, but he still waited. She said, “I never told her, but I swear she knows—Cole and I had an awkward moment when she introduced us...”

“She’s smart. And she knows Cole.”

“Would she hate me?”

“For that? No. She can be jealous sometimes, but other times let it go. I bet she knows. I bet she knows, and since she still wants to be friends, I’d say you two are going to be okay.”

“She’s not jealous of me with you?” It was an interesting point, she thought.

“I thought we agreed she set us up?”

Didn’t he see what that meant? “She did.”

“Don’t worry, Keely. All four of us are going to be just fine.” He gave her bottom another firm pat, and she frowned.

She said, “Max, honey, baby... Do you have a chubby?” She pumped her hips against him.

“I thought your jacket hid it well.”

“Oh, I feel it,” she laughed, tossing her hair back so the people in her periphery getting out of the limo would see what fun she and Max were having. She said, “Boy, you must *really* want us all to be friends.”

“It’s you who gets me hard,” he said near her ear.

“Let’s go,” she said now, standing up and pulling him with her by his hands. Eyes cast down between his legs, she said, “Would you be a dear and carry my parka?”

He smirked. “If you insist...”

“Thank you, Max. Now let’s go and get this over with. The sooner it’s done, the sooner we can be in bed together—where your problem isn’t a problem at all...”

Breakups 2 Makeups

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

THE FOUR OF them came together on the sidewalk out front of Miss Connie's 7A. Cole helped Maggie out of the black town car they'd hired for the night. Max's ex was stunning in a double-breasted camel-hair coat, a billowing cashmere scarf cozying up to her fine jawline. Her hair was pulled back; she wore gold earrings and a bare touch of makeup.

Max helped get her parka on, trusting his black suit would hide his arousal. Cole was all smiles; Maggie looked tentative.

The bros had the easiest greeting, Cole and Max embracing without hesitation or weirdness, patting each other's back and hugging, grunting *Hey, buddies* while Keely met Maggie's eyes. She nodded and Maggie did as well, giving her a hopeful smile.

Keely made the first move, stepping around Max's back, and Maggie came around as well, smile widening. There was a measure of uncertainty in her eyes though.

"It's good to see you," Keely said when they were close, and Maggie came in to kiss her cheek. She gave her an awkward one in return, one where her lips never touched Maggie's cheek but her lips still made a kissing sound to make up for it.

As they parted Maggie took her wrists and held them. "Thank you for calling me," she said, eyes betraying a glumness. Was it guilt? It should be guilt...

Cole caught her now, seeing the two girls not saying anything. He said, "Keely, get the fuck over here and give me a hug, Max is terrible at them."

She chuckled, saw Max with a happy gleam in his eye, assembled with his friends once again, despite the harm they'd caused him.

Cole was aggressive with his embrace, lifting her feet right off the sidewalk. Close to her ear he said, "It makes me so fucking happy to see you two together like this, I mean it."

When he set her down, she patted at his sides, stepped back. Now it was Max and Maggie eyeballing each other. Prickly heat washed up her shoulders and made the hair at the nape of her neck bristle. She and Max had spent about two hours playing Ghostbusters pinball and drinking tropical coconut cocktails, and the rum did a gastric jumping jack right now seeing her boyfriend lock eyes with the love of his life. Acid heat gurgled in her diaphragm.

Maggie said to Max: "I missed you."

Max said, "You look beautiful."

Maggie's eyes did a little jitter: one woman to another, she knew that look, knew Maggie figured the sting that would shoot Keely.

Both of them said no more, but their eyes stayed connected and a slow-moving smile crept both their faces. Maggie brushed an invisible tear from her lid, then whatever tension was between them seemed to dissipate and they came together in an embrace. It was a genuine, longing hold; she couldn't see Max's face, but Maggie's was sweet and happy, eyes blissfully closed feeling her ex-fiancee's arms around her. They squeezed and rocked, and Maggie had to brush at an eye again.

Cole joined them—just to remind her again how she was the outsider here, how she was the fourth wheel in a world where three wheels made sense—and he clapped Max's back, his hand moving then to give Maggie's wrist a squeeze. The three lovers united.

It was a sudden nauseous wash that came up her insides bringing a lot of the images she'd pushed away over the last two months. Max was a keeper, a hot prospect for her, and she was on her best behavior. That entailed curtailing all her hungrier questions. *How does a three-way relationship work, Maxy-poo? Would you tell us?... Tell us all the gory details...*

And seeing the mutual tenderness now between the three of them blasted her with images of them all in bed together. Her sweet Max a part of something so strange and frankly lurid. Were they all naked, did they all get in bed together? These were the givens. *Of course that's what happened,*

Keely. But what else? How dirty did the three of them get? These were things she'd avoided, and maybe ultimately didn't ever want to know, but standing now on a wintry sidewalk on Valentine's Day three feet distant while her new boyfriend was getting lovey with his ex-lovers those thoughts shot through her like a stake in a sleeping vampire's heart.

It was Maggie that caught on, looking over Max's shoulder with bleary eyes, smiling warmly at her in a strikingly honest way and then extending a hand.

All the O'Mearáin girls were the kind who enjoyed their *moods* (as her mother called them, like she was somehow exempt); red-headed girls that liked the feeling of being mad, liked to amplify the tiniest social detail to make things worse and in need of repair and this was one of those times. She could feel it in her. One look at Maggie's thin hand extended her way—with its probably *calfskin* glove that cost a grand, and knowing the effect she had on the man she was beginning to have real feelings for—and every bit of her tingled. In this situation, at the age of seventeen, she would make this scene *ugly*. Blow it up until she got what she wanted: Max to come running to her and apologizing, proving his feelings for her and her heart would pound at that wonderful feeling when you made a boy crumble, made him beg, and even though you knew you shouldn't you got a real thrill when he'd dig his beak in your palm eager for the scrap of seeds you were offering. Today, at twenty-one and not *that* far removed from the petulant bitch she knew she'd often been, she instead walked the three steps and though she didn't smile, she took Maggie's hand. Maggie pulled her into the group, all four of them touching at least one other in some way. The hurt in her heart was real, but maybe a new adult part of her wanted more from Max than the bliss of appeasement.

Cole said, "Enough of this weak shit, who's fucking hungry for Chinese?"

They laughed together, and the group came apart. She took Max's hand, and he gripped her tight, smiling.

CHINESE FOOD, as Cole had called it, was an Asian-American infusion restaurant a block south of Miss Connie's; an NYT darling run by a chef

who immigrated from China and worked his way up, starting at Eleven Madison Park and a few others before doing his own thing. It was a quiet, narrow space, decorated in mostly black and bare brick but spotted with fresh-cut flowers. The entrance was street-side shabby in a boring old shop-front with pullover security gates.

They had a table at the back and she sat with Max on her left, Maggie on her right, and Cole across the table. Appetizers were braised duck on brioche and fluke with a sesame vinaigrette, but now they were on their entrees, her with a fork in her spicy Berkshire pork and twirling peanut noodles. Maggie was eyeballing her again from the side while she watched Max and Cole talking.

Things had been polite between them; cordial. But Maggie was working hard to ingratiate herself, practically fawning over her at times, asking about school and saying how beautiful her dress was. She didn't tell her Max bought it; then it began to work at her, tighten her neck—Maggie would know Max had bought it—where would she get the money for such a beautiful piece of cloth? Then she started to feel like maybe Maggie would think she was using Max because he had a good job, then got mad at herself because maybe Maggie *didn't* think that—that's the way *your* mind works, Keely, not everyone else's. One thing you wouldn't do: pass off to another girl a lover you were bored with.

Right, you wouldn't...

It had been a celebratory week at work for Max. He was on the 37th floor of the International Paper Building, working technology buy-side analysis for Stonebridge Associates. He'd scored some sort of career victory this week; a 'peach tree,' as he called it, was bearing fruit. He'd banked on a small start-up for the portfolio and it had picked up a defense contract. Now he was easing himself away from the table and setting the scene to begin the story for Cole. Maggie watched him with a smile, her cheek in her palm and an elbow on the table. She watched her ex-lover wistfully. But as Keely studied her, Maggie's eyes flitted her way and saw that she was caught. Instead of looking embarrassed, Maggie smiled even broader, eased herself close and rested her hand on Keely's wrist. Her skin was warm, her hand light and feminine. She said, "I'm so happy."

"I am too," she said, the promptness of her answer giving away that competitive streak she sometimes had. Like she was happier with Max than Maggie ever was.

Maggie was unfazed—or maybe didn't detect the manner in her tone—and leaned even closer. She said, "You're staying in the city for the weekend?"

She nodded. "I am. Where are you guys? You got a room at The Langham?"

Maggie nodded now, persisted with knowing Keely's plans. "You're staying at Max's?"

"Yeah, I am."

"That's good. That's really good." She rubbed the back of Keely's hand with her thumb, and her eyes drifted to watch Max again, explaining to Cole with his hands how the fund worked.

Keely said, "Max had a good week."

Maggie said, "He told me."

"When?"

"When we arranged the plans for tonight," she said, looking at her. All of a sudden Maggie had picked up on some of Keely's uncomfortableness.

"Oh, right."

Maggie watched her a moment, said, "I hope sometime you can forgive me."

"I told you I did."

"I know you *told* me..."

"I do. I forgive you."

Maggie was smiling again, looking in her eyes. She said, "When I got out of the car and I saw you two in the doorway of the restaurant..." She tented her fingers over her chest.

Keely said, "Would you mind?" She took her wrist from Maggie, saw a measure of hurt pass across her former friend's face. She said, "I just have to go to the loo real quick before the dessert comes..."

"Sure, okay," Maggie said and adjusted herself to sit back more upright in her seat.

While Max had Cole engaged in his story of successful business analysis, she rose from the table unnoticed, even Maggie turning sideways to her now and giving her 'boys' her attention.

Keely walked between tables, found the hall leading to the washrooms, rocked her head from side to side, the muscles getting tight, her jaw aching. Her shoulders were like bunched balls of hard stone. She rubbed them with her fingers as she bumped the ladies room door with her arm and went

inside closing herself in one of the stalls. She didn't really even need to pee, but she managed to push out a few spritzes. Toilet flushed, she went to stand at the sink and wash her hands; liking the feel of the cold on her skin.

She looked at her reflection, wishing the unease she felt wasn't there. Wishing she could let it all go. She pushed away thoughts of Maggie, pushed away thoughts of Cole, and how Max related to them all. The thought of the three of them together was weighing on her. It wasn't just that she was an outsider to them, it was that she was beginning to have real feelings for Max Milton and parts of his past *bothered* her. She'd always thought she'd be the kind who could let this run off her shoulders—she didn't care what anyone's past was, didn't care about anyone's sexual proclivities.

She had no problem with Max being in a three-person relationship. But then again, she *did* have a problem with him being in a three-person relationship. She couldn't put her finger on it. It was hard to think of Max that way because everything else about him was so straight and square and put away. But then again: it wasn't. And that's what she liked about him. He was smart and disciplined, calm and kind. But she could see it in his eyes that first night he walked into the brewpub in Harvard Square: a darkness. In those deep black eyes there was something swirling. There was hurt, and over the hurt a certain wizened, hardened armor. It was in his cynicism, and it was in his smile; that uneven half-smirk on those pouting cherry lips.

Maybe that's what it was... Was it that he hurt? It was Maggie that hurt him and she knew it.

She washed her hands, dried them under the vent and shook her head, chasing those thoughts away. But when she emerged in the hallway to return to her table she was confronted by her pestering thoughts again. Maggie was waiting for her. Max's pretty ex-girlfriend—sorry, *ex-fiancé*—leaning against the wall with her hands behind her back and that all-knowing, understanding smile. She had her head cocked, looking thin and graceful in her expensive clothes. Her black evening dress that hung on the fine points of her slender frame and draped beautifully. The yoke of the dress was a thin sheer with a design of metallic flowers, the neckline a modest bateau; elbow-length fluttering sleeves showed the grace of her fine arms and her delicate gold jewelry around her wrists. The skirt ended above her knee, her tanned legs shone, her dainty feet pointed in low sensible

heels made sexy by thin leather straps at the ankle closed with tiny gold buckles. Maggie was rich and beautiful and graceful and smart.

And she'd hurt Max.

Old Wounds

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

ALL THROUGH DINNER he'd watched Cole's hands. So familiar to him; big, masculine, but graceful and well-groomed. They'd been on Keely and he couldn't shake the thought. Flashes of those hands on her pale flesh, coddling those large creamy breasts, her pretty mouth curled in passion as he drove that big cock inside her. Young Keely, eighteen-year-old Keely, one he ached to know—the thought that she was so near to him in Vermont and they never met sent him into lamentation on nights when he missed her. Now it had a new coppery patina, one he didn't like.

Keely had been with Cole.

But so what of it? Part of Keely's allure had always been her self-assuredness, and with that came her sexual history. *Think she hadn't been with men like Cole, Max?* Come on. She'd been with plenty of guys like him. Why couldn't he just accept it?

Because it was Cole.

Sure, Keely had a past. That was actually exciting. He wanted to know about it—was looking forward to discovering it.

For three years he'd been a slave to Cole's impalement in his love life. He'd grown around it like a tree planted too close to a fence; his love for Maggie healed around the foreign object, incorporating it into his structure. Life finds a way to survive.

Fuck, he even loved Cole. It would be crazy to think he was nothing but a splinter. There were times when they were three that he would cherish forever and never want to give up. Things they had done and shared you could never do as two. And his relationship with Cole was honest now, pure

and repaired from the devastation at The Twilight Motel. But this? Tonight? This felt like a brand new betrayal.

With the girls gone to the washroom, he looked around the restaurant. Servers swished between tables with elegant, stone-faced ease; a woman at a table for four had too much to drink and was retelling a story with comic fervor that was endearing despite her besotted manner; a finely tailored black dude in the corner, one Cole swore was some guy he said played for the Knicks in the 2000s, gave their table a head nod—some sort of acknowledgment, he figured, for the attractiveness of their dates and their obvious style; Cole nodded back, gave him a narrow-eyed devilish grin. Their plates hadn't been cleared yet, but he and Cole were enjoying two fingers of Laphroaig.

Did he fuck Keely in his dorm room? The same one he probably fucked Maggie?

"Hey, were you going to tell me?"

Cole frowned, set his bourbon down. He licked his lips. "Tell you what, Max?"

"What do you think?"

Cole's eyes went up and to the right and his mouth hung open, doing a good job of portraying the visage of the bewildered. But he knew. "I don't know, Max," he said, feigning ignorance but his tired, enervated tone showing that he knew exactly what was coming.

"Why wouldn't you tell me?"

Cole looked pained, and he sat away from the table, drummed his fingers on the lip. "What are we talking about here?"

"Keely," he whispered hoarsely, brow lowered.

That pained look stayed on his face, and he looked down in his lap, his mouth going slim. "Maggie said I shouldn't."

"Maggie knows?"

"Oh God," Cole chuckled, running a hand through his hair, shaking his head in a way that showed Maggie knew and definitely didn't like it. "Yeah, she knows."

"Why wouldn't she want you to tell me?"

"She said it's Keely's business."

"Keely's my business. You're my business, and you're my friend."

"Talk to Maggie," he said, flashing his palms up, then immediately realizing how deferential that sounded. He leaned forward, laced his fingers

together, pushed his plate deeper into the center of the table. “Max, I’m sorry. Maggie said it was Keely’s business and that sounded good to me because I could not picture any way that I could come to you and tell you that. I let Maggie make the decision because I wasn’t looking forward to telling you.”

“You were never going to tell me?”

“No, no, Max. Maggie would talk to Keely, I think. I guess, I don’t know... I would have told you, it was just a matter of timing. I pictured coming to you to tell you a few weeks ago, and I worried it would ruin how you feel about her. I mean look at you now, look how mad you are...”

“I’m not mad, Cole. I’m just...” He clutched a handful of shirt and tie over his heart, saying, “I feel like I’m burning up, like I want to just fucking tear my skin off.”

“Jesus, Max, don’t do this, I’m sorry, really...”

“I’m not mad at you...”

“I really am sorry I didn’t tell you already, I mean it, dude.”

“If you set us up, why wouldn’t you tell me before we even met?”

“You and Keely? It’s not a matter of treachery, dude, it’s not like we thought that would ruin it so we kept it to ourselves. She and I don’t talk about the fact that... well, that me and Keely have a past—a *minor* past, Max, I fucking swear, so minor—it’s unsaid, she knows, but it’s...” He zipped a hand across his pursed lips.

“A minor thing,” he repeated.

“It was nothing, I swear. What did she tell you?”

“We hardly talked about it. I don’t want to act like a psycho in front of her. I have to be cool while I’m fucking dying inside.”

“You’re not dying, Max...”

He shook his head and rolled his eyes. *Like you’d know...*

Cole said, “It was a long time ago, and she was nobody.”

He scoffed. “Nobody?”

“Jesus, Max, I don’t mean *nobody*—I meant to us she was a nobody, an unknown. Don’t put words in my mouth. The last thing I want is to fucking drive a wedge in between you and her.”

“It won’t hurt us. It’ll just hurt me.”

“Why? Why does it have to be like that?”

He squashed his molars down till they squeaked, then lubricated his mouth with another splash of single malt.

“You’re right, Max,” Cole said, gripped his arm above his wrist. “Be cool. Don’t let this shit change how you are with her. She’s a fucking angel, man, serious, you are so lucky—and don’t fucking give me that look, I don’t mean like that, not everything is about sex for fuck sake. I mean it. Tell me she’s not amazing...”

“She’s amazing,” he grumbled.

“The whole thing is wild. The way it happened. I mean, Keely was the last girl I was with before Maggie. She shows up here at Harvard, Maggie befriends her, next thing I know she’s introducing me to her friend, and, can you believe it, she went to Farm, and I walk into my kitchen and it’s Keely.”

“You didn’t remember her name?”

Cole made a pained expression. *No, he didn’t.*

“You’re a savage,” he said, to let him off the hook.

Cole let his arm go, eyes drifting off to the table again. There was more. He said, “You want another shot of truth?”

He sighed and groaned real pain. *What now?*

“Uhh,” Cole dragged it out, not making eye contact and trying to consider how he’d approach it. “Well, Maggie... she had a crush on her.”

“On Keely?”

Cole said, “Tell me she’s not fucking charming.”

“What are you saying?”

“She charmed Maggie. You should have seen her, coming home from school saying Keely says this, Keely says that... You know Maggie, she doesn’t make friends easy, at least not good ones. After a while I see Maggie has a crush on Keely. At first we even considered... you know...”

“What?”

Cole got closer and said quietly: “Maggie said there were some things she didn’t try in college. Remember that thing we always used to talk about?”

“Oh no...”

“Yeah. We didn’t. But we kind of talked about it.”

“Maggie and Keely?”

He shrugged.

“And you?”

He shrugged bigger, eyes wider now and looking around in disbelief like the wrongly accused. “I don’t know. It wasn’t the most well-thought

out idea, it was...”

“You’d leave me out of it?”

Cole grimaced and rubbed his chin. “We didn’t *intend* to...”

“Yeah, you did...”

“Whoah, Max, no. Not like that. We didn’t even get close. It could be hard work to get a girl in bed with me and Maggie, but then try me and Maggie *and* another guy...” He put his hands up to let Max consider how intimidating a prospect that would be.

“You think Keely’s that kind of girl?”

Cole’s features compressed as he was reluctant to say what he thought. It was true though; Keely might have been that kind of girl...

Cole said, “It doesn’t matter, anyway. It was a brief time where we kind of toyed with the idea but then we found out I had a past with her, and anyway Maggie started in on the *Don’t you think Max would love her?* thing.”

Right, the beginning of Max’s end in their relationship.

Cole realized the dead-end alley he’d dragged their conversation down. He said, “You know, Max, I already told you, but it’s true: I didn’t ask for this. I didn’t ask Maggie to make a decision. I didn’t see it coming.”

“Yeah, you did. I did. We *all* did.”

“I was happy before.”

He didn’t want to talk about it at all. Tonight was about rekindling. He said, “So once you thought I might like Keely...?”

“Well, we didn’t want to wreck anything. And, seriously, Maggie loves Keely. Both of us want you two to be in our lives. Like...” He looked troubled now, brow lowered, mouth working around. It gave him the impression he was about to divulge something Maggie had instructed him not to. “Maggie cries about it.”

“About Keely?”

“They had kind of a fight and Keely is, she can be pretty mean, I guess.”

“She felt used.”

“More than that, too. Like tricked or something. She told Maggie she thought Maggie lied about seeing her ex-boyfriend out with another girl. You know, to get them to break up so...”

“I know, I know,” he said, rushed. “I don’t want to talk about her stupid fucking ex-boyfriend.”

Cole made a grimace like he didn't see that, and just realized *of course* Max wouldn't want to hear about it. "Sorry," he said.

Against better judgment, he succumbed to the inner gremlins, asked: "What was that guy like?"

"A fucking dick, dude."

He looked up from the table, waited for Cole to make eye contact. "*Did* Maggie lie?"

MAGGIE SMILED AGAIN, showing that understanding, looking like there was more going on here and poor Keely didn't understand it yet. She nodded her head to the right, deeper down the hall. At the end, there was a small square waiting lounge with a table, a grand bouquet of bright primary flowers sitting atop, and two leather armchairs astride. Maggie led the way and Keely followed, watching her legs work. They each sat in a chair, and Maggie folded herself into the edge closest to Keely, putting an elbow on the arm. There was a lamp hanging above the table and its shade cast a shadow over Maggie's face, but lit her slick-looking lips.

"Keely, I know you think what I did was terrible no matter how many times I tell you I had the best intentions for the both of you."

"I'm not mad about that," she said, folding her fingers together between her knees.

"But you're mad."

"I don't know," she said, and she didn't. There was discomfort like an ill-fitting sweater, an all-over feel of wrongness rather than one pin-pointed item.

"Ask me anything, Keely. I want us to be friends again. I will answer anything honestly."

Right off her tongue, the truth came: "Do you still love him?" There was her truth; it was just waiting for the right time to show its ugliness.

Maggie didn't even need to consider. She nodded, looked at her earnestly. "I do. I love him very much. I can't not love him. I can't stop."

"Okay," she said quietly, looking down the hall at the restaurant seeming so far away now. It was the wrong answer and yet it didn't hurt. At least not sharply, but there was an ache in her stomach...

Maggie said, “I want Max in my life. I told you in November I have to move on. I’m going to want a family, a house... I want to marry Cole. I wanted you to meet Max *because* I love Max.”

She shrugged.

“When you said I was scraping him off my shoe I just about died. I’ve cried about that. I cried about it just a few days ago again. It’s not true. I care about you. I did before you ever met Max. I introduced you two because I want you both in my life. I love Max and I can’t lose him. I don’t want to lose you, either.”

She decided to be honest. She said, “I don’t know what’s wrong with me. I’m mad. I can tell you that I don’t *want* to be mad...”

“But something is wrong.”

“I guess so,” she said. “But I don’t know why.”

“I’m not out to get you.”

Is that what it was? Did she feel like Maggie was against her? Or maybe she felt like she should be the one against Maggie now. Ex-girlfriend to the guy you like, ex-fiance, and a manipulator who dumped him using clueless Keely as her foil, a tool in her toolbox...? Or *was* Maggie kind and considerate? They’d been friends first, and she’d liked the girl a lot. Maybe too much. She’d wanted to *be* her—and maybe meeting Max had been driven by an unheard internal motor that wanted to take her places where she could have the things Maggie had. There was a lot to be unsure of. “I didn’t say you were.”

“You don’t believe I was telling you the truth about Derek.”

“I don’t want to talk about Derek.”

Maggie nodded, went silent.

Keely waited but Maggie said nothing. “Were you?”

“I wouldn’t lie to you.”

Aye, she probably didn’t. Problem was what Maggie’d told her she’d seen—Derek was out for a drink with a blonde-haired girl—wasn’t enough to break it off with a fella. But prior, she’d divulged to Maggie her particular feelings on fidelity, her vulnerability to it, her worries of Derek... Maggie could have presented the benign knowing the necessary damage would be done in Keely’s head. But, fuck, so what?—it was a matter of time before she was done with Derek because he *was* the kind to cheat. The problem was so elliptical, and perfect at shunting aside blame for the woman who’d instigated it. Casual or malicious or supportive, the act of

telling Keely had left her blameless because she hadn't really told her anything of value now, had she? "I didn't think you lied."

"Then why won't you talk to me anymore? Just because of Max? I swear I didn't think what I was doing was bad. I *am* sorry..."

"I'm sorry too," she said.

"You are?"

"Sure. I'm probably being a bitch for no reason. I know it sometimes and I can't help it."

"That's okay," Maggie said, a hopeful tone in her voice as she shifted closer in her seat. "I'm not innocent by any means, but I didn't do anything to be mean or to manipulate..."

"It's okay." They'd gone over this before. It was easier to dismiss it in email or on the phone, but face to face was uncomfortable. Maggie was at once compelling with her shining, expressive eyes and pleading brows, and also simultaneously intimidating with her stature, her expensive clothes and fine features. There was a cold edge to her sometimes, too, even though she had exuded such bubbling warmth. With her sharp intelligence you worried there was cunning beneath all the charm; that she was sharp and uncaring as a knife and knew the ways to lure you to an embrace where she could stick you with it.

Maggie smiled, and it seemed so honest she hated she would doubt it. She said, "I got your birthday card."

"I know."

"I was so happy, because, you know... you don't hate me."

"I don't hate you."

Maggie made a funny face, a playful sort of expression showing that, hey, maybe not everything was so terrible. "I like you a lot, you know. I liked you before Max was ever around."

"Me too," she said.

Maggie said, "But I really do like you with Max."

Keely shrugged, feeling the first glimmer of light through some dark clouds. She said, "I do too."

"I can tell it's going well," Maggie said, running the pad of her thumb over the metal tabs of her expensive purse.

That bothered her. That was an indication that Maggie knew Max so well that she knew what was happening between the two of them. But the two of them, Max and Keely, should be only *their* business.

Maybe Maggie could see her discomfort at that because now she said, “I hope he makes you happy, and I hope you make him happy, too.”

Keely said, “That’s what I want.”

“I guess you guys have been intimate?” Maggie held her breath after asking, knowing it was something she shouldn’t have done. It felt so quiet you could hear a pin drop. She was twofold on her reaction: she could slap her knees and say, *You can’t ask me that!* She could stomp to the table and tell Max to take her home. *She also wanted to tell the truth.* She fell somewhere between. With trepidation, she met Maggie’s eyes and said, “Yes, we have.”

Maggie nodded, and couldn’t hide her feelings from her expression.

And she liked that. She liked the fact that she’d felt all she would ever be doing was falling back on her heels, throwing up defenses against this beautiful older woman who her boyfriend loved—but seeing that wincing, minuscule head-shake showed that she had power too. Showed that she could give it back if she wanted.

She advanced.

“We have. We have for quite a while now. A lot.” *A little juvenile.* She ran her thumbs around in circles, suppressing a smirk. Maggie shifted in her seat. Keely watched her squirm. Now Keely imagined saying, *You know we did it in your bed? I felt funny about it at first but boy Max really wanted to. In the end we shagged a few times in my dorm room but we just couldn’t not have sex in your bed, you know what I mean? So the next morning we made sure we dirtied up all your sheets. But don’t worry, we gave them a wash in the morning...*

...though given our enthusiasm they could’ve gone through another cycle...

Maggie said, “Why are you smiling?”

“Am I smiling?” she said, and couldn’t help laughing, feeling so embarrassed she’d been caught.

Maggie said, “You’re enjoying this, aren’t you?”

Now she felt instantly guilty. “Am I that obvious?”

It was Maggie advancing this time—reaching across the distance between them and grabbing Keely’s wrist. She said, “You got me pretty good. I hope you’re proud of yourself...”

“I’m so embarrassed,” she said and put her hands over her face, Maggie still holding her wrist. “I’m sorry,” she laughed into her hands.

Maggie say, "I'm a big girl. A big girl and I really do care about you. Care about Max and I care about you. And that all the stuff about scraping my shoe... I didn't want you to be with Max so I could have him gone, I wanted him with you because I wanted him to be happier than he would be with me."

Big Girls, Big Boys

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

IT WAS ALL TOO much to bear—all coming at him far too quick. One minute he's got her in his arms and they're having the best weekend he could remember in years, then she's telling him she slept with his best friend. Was it no big deal to her? And now that the seal had been broken, the bubbling contents wanted to foam out and ruin everything. The details wouldn't leave him alone... That dorm room Cole had back in '17-'18. He could picture it. Knew exactly the bed on which he'd fucked Keely. His roommate back then was Satinder. They played Xbox, there was an Einstein poster, he had fucked Maggie in that bed too. That had been bad enough but at least those truths were long buried and smoothed over with the back of the shovel.

"I gotta get outta here," he said.

"She said she saw them..."

"It's not that..."

When he rose from the table, Cole stopped him by grabbing a fistful of his sleeve. "Max, come on, don't do that."

"It's nothing, Cole."

"Don't be mad at me."

"I'm not, I told you I'm not. You don't even know what it's like, I feel like I'm boiling over," he said, and clutched his tie, taking his sleeve out of Cole's grasp.

Cole said, "I'm coming with you," and readied to stand.

"Stay here," he said. "I just need some fresh air..."

"Max..."

“Please, just stay here, just sit here and don’t say anything. All right? I’m trying to keep the lid on this simmering pot. If you start freaking out, I’m going to start freaking out worse. Just let me chill.”

Cole looked up at him, and he could see the concern in his friend’s eyes. Yeah, he was mad at him. Mad at him for something that wasn’t even his fault. And Cole just kept getting away with everything like nothing was his fault. And here it was happening again. This time robbing him without even knowing about it, let alone even trying.

“Just please let me be,” he said, and nodded; they held each other’s gaze a moment longer.

“You keep it together,” Cole said. Pretty bold, coming from him, but he was right. This was the kind of thing that if you didn’t have good grip on the reins, the horses could have you seesawing through the city streets knocking over apple carts and running innocent people over.

“Yeah,” he said, “fresh air...”

“Just get some fresh air, then get back in here,” Cole said, and for whatever reason his friend’s serious and stern expression strengthened him.

He passed through the restaurant, out the vestibule and onto the city street—Valentine’s Day and busy; bumper-to-bumper traffic, and the village was lively with strolling couples and groups. He made his way to the curb, standing next to a fire hydrant and staring out at the lit up storefront signs across the street.

How would he get over this? Just when he thought everything was perfect, someone took his monopoly car and moved it back to Go without collecting his two-hundred bucks. Back to square one.

It was like this moment of blissful time with Keely had been transported, and he was standing in 2018 in the middle of a hazy love triangle, riding on choppy waves, a misty visage of his beautiful girl hard to decipher—a girl he’d loved and cherished who grew distant, their bonds becoming weak and amorphous.

“But it’s crazy to think that,” he said to the night air, breathing deep and further loosening his tie and undoing the top button of his shirt. Hands through his hair, he took deep and slow breaths. Keely wasn’t Maggie. Keely slept with Cole ages ago. It was over.

Don’t you like that she already did it, Max?

“I do,” he mumbled. Part of her appeal was that she had no sexual curiosity. “All right,” he said now, slowing his breathing. His heart still

pounded in his eardrums at a fast rate.

What he had to do was chase away those images of Keely with her pale, slender legs wrapped around Cole's waist as he fucked her. Because he knew that's what happened.

Why do you want to picture it?

Were they on top of the sheets, the way he saw it in his mind? Cole on top of her, Keely letting out those shrieks and cries as Cole showed her all the things she wanted to know. Because he was sure now that Keely was the one who'd been curious. Sure, he could see it; Cole didn't chase after freshmen girls. First years went after him. Keely probably cornered him somewhere, put the moves on him, and the two of them ended up in a dorm room bed.

Now his breath came quicker again, and he was grimacing. Yeah, Keely definitely started it. Keely wanted Cole. Eighteen-year-old horny ass girlfriend of his wanted to get fucked by the campus stud. Now his hands were forming fists, but if he started beating them against his legs like he wanted to, someone would probably call the authorities. Or maybe not—he was on the east side.

"All right," he said, "so just stop thinking about it."

Easier said than done. Just a couple nights. A couple nights of what? What did she do with him? Max knew a lot of Cole's tricks—which ones had he unleashed on poor ginger-haired Irish girl fresh off the boat and nestled hidden in the Green Mountains of Vermont?

Now something else came to him, and it just popped up like a bubble at the surface...

A redhead.

The screamer.

"Oh no, no, no, no," he said, shaking his head. "You can't let this get a hold of you, Max. Don't dwell on it..."

Could it have been her? It had to be...

He could see the pictures she'd sent Cole on her phone.

That wasn't her, was it? A stupid question. You know it was.

All right, it was Keely. That's who she is. That's who you're with. And dammit, get your shit together because that's what you like about her.

"I do, I do," he said softly.

Right. So get your shit together and get back to that table. Of course she wanted to fuck Cole. She wasn't the only one. You ought to be used to it by

now.

“I am.”

So what do you want to do?... Ruin everything you’ve built with her in the last two months just because you can’t get over a simple fact of life? She didn’t even cheat on you as much as it pricked up those same old feelings...

In fact, even standing out here on the curb and railing over this imaginary problem, now he couldn’t deny he was enjoying it in some dark and sinister way, too. Sure, Keely had her knees up in Cole’s armpits and he’d fucked her with that wrist-thick cock.

Admit you like it. Just admit it and move on. But whatever you do, don’t drag her into your darkness.

But she brought it right to my doorstep...

He took a deep breath, squinted his eyes shut until he saw phosphorescent bulbs burning behind the lids. He did up his shirt button, tightened his tie and went back into the restaurant.

BETWEEN THE TWO LEATHER CHAIRS, she came together with Maggie and they embraced. A truce, a treaty, an armistice—though that was probably hyperbolic. What it amounted to was: Maggie said she was sorry if she was misinterpreted, and Keely said she was mad and didn’t really know why. Two girls who were supposed to be smart and yet somehow tangled up in an emotional affair they couldn’t logic their way out of, embraced awkwardly at the end of a long hall to the loo in a fancy restaurant.

For Max she would do her best. And frankly, before there was a Max, she had to recognize that Maggie had been becoming a good friend. Time for the fire that would sometimes ravage her frontal lobe and blot out rationality to be quelled in whatever way she could; berm it, control-burn the perimeters, run backfires... All the ire she’d bunched up around the name ‘Maggie Becker’ needed to be tamed, set to simmer until newer verdicts were made.

When they released each other, Maggie said, “Would you come by the house this week? Study, watch some TV?”

“I could do that.”

There was a genuine look of soft satisfaction in Maggie’s narrow eyes. “Come on,” she said, smiling, smelling of sweet citrus perfume and reaching to take her hand. “Let’s go out before they think something’s happened, or they go out to the show without us.”

Together and holding hands they returned to the table. Max sat close to Cole, both of them with refreshed single malts. She liked Max when he drank. He was a strong man, but vulnerable, and when he was loosened by spirit, he veered from the cynic to the bold. The night she’d first been intimate with him had been wild; her dark and mysterious boyfriend seducing her along a path she was unsure of. It’s not that she was old (and she wasn’t a virgin at twenty-one, not by a long shot), but being with Max reminded her of her first times when she was ever sexually active. Eager but naïve; like there were things that Max would teach her, things she might even be interested in. Like, look at him, she thought, sitting there with that roguish charm, that sharp and intelligent gaze, the hint of vulnerability to the way he held his brow and mouth; he sat confident with Cole, arm over the back of Cole’s chair, happy to see her (she could see that sparkle in his eye when their gaze met). Earlier this evening she’d let this man she cared about know she’d fucked his best mate. Look at him now, look at that confidence and cool.

If he could be a big man about her and Cole, she could be a big girl about him and Maggie...

Confessions

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

KEELY WAS on him the minute they got back to the apartment. He closed the door, turned around to find his redheaded girlfriend eager as ever to get between the sheets. She fell against him and his back whomped against the door, but he wrapped his arms around her and they kissed.

After dinner, they'd gone to a cocktail lounge so they could listen to Genevieve Chow play piano. That was for Maggie, obviously, but it was classy and romantic and perfect for Valentine's. After that, Maggie and Cole and them went on their separate ways, dropping the two of them off at his apartment on the way.

She said, "I've been dying for you all night."

"You hid it well," he said around kisses.

She said, "You still have that hard on?" grabbing him roughly between his legs and provoking a dull ache in one testicle.

"Off and on," he laughed, hands going down her waist and grabbing butt cheeks. He lifted her, and she raised up on toes, putting one knee up against his hip and pressing her crotch against his thigh.

She said, "We made it."

"That wasn't so bad, was it?"

"It was hard at first, but I'm okay."

"So glad you're okay," he joked. "I need it to work out."

With dramatic flair, she proclaimed: "I'll do it for you..."

"Come on, Keely," he laughed, then bit at her neck. "You liked them before."

“I *still* like them, Max,” she said and kissed his mouth. Her finger slipped between their lips and she pulled her kiss away but the finger pressed to keep his mouth closed—he imagined it as pre-emptive, stopping him before he tried to keep talking to her about Maggie. It wasn’t Maggie on his mind now, but she was expressing to him her feelings and he had to respect it. She wouldn’t want to talk about Maggie right now, nor Cole.

In each other’s arms, they stumbled across his foyer and tumbled onto the couch, her going to her back, him getting over her and between her legs. She put her knees up because she liked when he humped his hardness against her. So he did.

Now she caressed his cheeks, looked in his eyes. She said, “I’m going to try, Max.”

“Try what?”

“With Maggie,” she whispered.

Her eyes flicked over his and it crushed him; there was a deep connection there, a strange understanding. Also a trusting. They’d grown so close so fast and it was astounding. In her eyes he could see a trepidation, a desire to please, and also a stalwart duty. All in the flicker of her emerald eyes as they trembled wet before him. And that whole time he read her, he realized she was reading him, too; her eyes going over his, measuring his darkness she’d sometimes joke, and seeking to comprehend how her words registered with him.

He gave her lower lip a soft nibble and sighed. “That’s all I could want, Keely.”

She combed her nails through his hair. “I’ll go by the house this week, hang out. I want to do that...”

Kind words, ones he should want to hear, but his demons lit onto it immediately, sinking their little fangs into its succulent flesh. Cole would be there. A man she’d fucked. A man he knew very well and knew his abilities between the sheets.

And this sweet, dreamy redhead writhing under him, the one he was so pleased was learning to understand him, picked up right away on his discomfort. She stiffened under him, her hands stroked over his arms and his sides like a paramedic assessing a patient. There were things he couldn’t hide from her as hard as he tried—she might not know his innermost darkness, but she was clever enough to know that he hid it.

“It is what you want, isn’t it?”

“It is,” he said, his words heavier than he’d intended. He ground the humped belly of his erection into the split of her mound, her Oscar de la Renta skirt riding up on her hips, exposing a flash of bare, pale tummy and the embroidered swath of expensive lingerie she’d worn for their Valentine’s date. He was so fucking lucky to have her.

“That’s a devilish smile, Mr. Milton,” she laughed. “Thinking of what you want to do to me?”

Weight pressing on her again, getting close, dry-humping, he said, “You are so fucking sexy, Keely.”

They kissed and sucked mouths, humped and rolled hips, but he couldn’t camouflage that pervasive thought worming through him. It stiffened her, too, and their kissing slowed.

“Tell me, Max,” she whispered.

Well, here it fucking was. The thing you didn’t want to mention, the thing you were proud to resist (resisting it for Keely’s sake!) and now here she was curious, and despite the strength you’d conjured, you can’t wait to divulge it to her. Part of him sought solace; get the dark some light, laugh about it. A shade darker, happy in the black and seeking blacker: trick her into telling you all about how Cole fucked her.

He raised over her, said, “What you told me at Ms. Connie’s.”

“Oh,” she said, forcing herself to keep his gaze, the effort making her frown. “You know what? I think this is good news: I totally forgot about that.”

He chuckled at her lie. “That’s good news? It hit me hard and then you forget about it?”

“It doesn’t mean a thing to me. What’s the point now?” Her arms circled his neck and tried to pull him in for another kiss.

He said, “It’s a little more than nothing to me.”

“Why? You said it was okay.”

“It is, it is okay. But it’s not something I’m going to forget.”

She pursed her lips, looked in his eyes. Her hands went to his cheeks, and she caressed his jawline with her thumbs. “I’m sorry.”

“You don’t have to be sorry. It’s not something to be sorry about at all.”

“Would it help you, Max, if I told you right now the last thing I want to do is talk about boring old dumb things from the past? What if I told you that I’m as horny as I’ve ever been...”

“That’s good,” he said.

“Just good?”

“Well, it’s more than good...” he said, but easing away from her further and looking out across the room. She watched him, and he showed her good humor by smirking. This wasn’t her problem, it was his. Her hand slipped inside his suit jacket and rubbed over his chest. He put his hand over hers. He said, “I have a lot of hangups.”

She laughed, and the sound of her light voice made him smile, got him laughing too. She said, “Who doesn’t have hangups, Max?”

“I know,” he said. “I know we all have them. But I only really care about mine. And the people that I care about...”

“Who said I have hang ups?”

“Who doesn’t, Keely?” He pushed his hardness against her and laughed. She humped back, said, “I’m glad you can laugh.”

“You make me laugh.”

She said, “Tell me your hangups.”

“Seriously? I don’t think so...”

“If they weigh on you, Max, and you trust me...”

“I trust you.”

“Do or don’t, Max, no pressure, but, yeah, I’m encouraging you...”

“To tell you my hangups...”

“Only if you want to, Max. I care about them...”

It wasn’t something he’d wanted to get into, and the support she was showing seemed like a trick—not from Keely, but from the Fates. “Nah, it’s nothing.”

She studied his face, mouth pouted cheekily like there was a smile proving difficult for her to contain. She gave his cheek a soft but sharp slap. “Good, so can we fuck now?”

It got her laughing once more, and she rubbed his chest; he put his hand over hers again.

She said, “Seriously, can we?”

“That’s what you want?”

“God, unless you want to bore me with your hangups,” she said, tossing her head back theatrically and rolling her eyes in an exaggerated circle. He laughed again, and now he was over top of her, holding her neck and caressing her. He pressed his hardness between her legs.

“That’s better,” she said and put her hips against him eagerly, showing him she felt the same way.

Her hand slipped between them, grabbed his erection over his pants and squeezed him hard. “So tell me about these hangups...”

MAX WAFFLED, but she knew she’d almost got him coaxed. “C’mon, gi’ us something for Valentine’s.”

“We’re good in bed together.”

“Aye.”

“I do it for you...”

“You’re the best, Max.”

“Aw, don’t joke, I’m serious.”

“You’re the best man I’m with right now.”

His brow lowered, and he watched her eyes. That hurt she could sometimes see in him flickered there, and she started to smile. *Didn’t he know that was a joke?*

“Are you seeing someone else?”

“Pssh, Max, come on,” she sighed, caressed the curl of his lower lip with her thumb. “Just you. One at a time’s me motto.” She gave him her cutest smile.

“It’s okay if you are, I just want to know.”

“Hey, we talked about this already.”

“I know.”

“Let me joke if I want, we’re supposed to have fun.” Now she could see his hangup starting to take form before her and he hadn’t even tried. “Go on,” she urged, liking this but not wanting it to turn down Morose Avenue. Hangups were only ever good when you could have a laugh at them.

“You don’t ever want more?”

She struggled to comprehend, held his face further back so she could focus better on his eyes. “Sorry, Max—more what?”

“More. Can I be better for you?”

Wow. Full-service-Max, sending out a survey looking for feedback—How can we please you better?... “Max, that’s considerate. I feel like I can tell you whatever I want.”

“That’s good. Is there anything I’m not doing?”

Now she giggled and couldn’t help it.

“What’s funny about that?”

“Do I get a free rim job if I fill out your questionnaire?”

And now the reaction she was hoping for: Max’s face burst away from that dark throbbing hurt into his happy expression, laughing, taking her hands and lacing their fingers. He kissed her neck in a way that made her nipples sting and she squeezed him with her thighs. They were both chuckling.

“‘Cause I’ll fill it out,” she whispered.

He breathed her in, and they both got writhing together again. “Was that it?—that your hangup? Wanting to know how I score ye? You’re a high scorer, Max...”

“Good,” he said near her ear, his mouth sucking on her neck. “What about my dick?”

“This dick?” she gasped, tugged her hand from his grip and squeezed his cock through his pants. He was so fucking rock hard right now.

“Do you like it?”

“I need it...”

“What do you think of it?”

“It’s big...”

“Be serious...”

“What do you want me to say...?”

He got up again, hovering over her. “What do you think of it?”

“I love it, Max, I love everything about it.” She caressed her palm over its aching hump.

He sighed as though disappointed. “That’s just what girls say...”

“Oh, like I want to hear about all the girls who said your dick’s big...” She removed her hand from him.

“Hey, no... I mean, that’s what *all* girls say to *all* guys.”

She took a deep breath, closed her eyes, stilled her mind—let him see her patience, hoping he knew his luck because she didn’t offer it up often. She opened her eyes and smiled. “Get to the point then.”

His face went serious, his mouth firm. But his eyes twinkled. “You don’t think it could be better in any way?”

“Your dick, you mean?”

“Yes, Keely, my dick.”

“No. Why would I think that?”

“What’s your opinion?”

“Oh, my God, Max. Of your dick? You think it’s small?”

“I want to know what you think.”

It was hard not to laugh. “I’ve been with guys with small dicks, and I don’t count you amongst them.”

“You’re being nice.”

She gripped his cock underhanded, rolled her eyes up and measured him with her hand.

“Yes,” she said at last as if making a verdict, “I suppose I am.”

“Are you?... Being nice?...”

“I didn’t want to say, but it’s true. You’re right.”

“Are you being serious now?”

“Yeah, sure. That your thing?”

“What thing?”

“Your get-off spot. Your mental clit.”

He chuckled until it became a groan. “My mental clit?”

Now she hooked her ankles around the small of his back, hugged him, feeling strangely intimate. Their faces were close, eyes inches apart. “Want me to tell you you’ve got a little one?”

Nothing registered on his expression, but his mouth worked around slowly and he studied her with narrowed eyes. “I don’t know. Maybe.”

“I will, but... I... You’ve got a good dick on yeh, Max. A real good one. I don’t think you know how many little dicks there are out there, and how small they can be.”

“I don’t think I have a little dick.”

She snapped her fingers behind his head and bit her lower lip; looked at him with glee. “I got it. You just worry I’ve seen some whoppers.”

His face scrunched up, and she knew she’d landed her dart near the bull.

His smile came, but he said, “I don’t want to know.”

“Good, ‘cause it’s me business. You want to shag me, though, and I’ll whisper in your ear you’ve got a thumb-cock?”

He chuckled, stared at her with affection she could feel. He said, “Why do you always taunt me?”

“Because you amuse me.” She fiddled with his earlobe.

“Mm-hmm,” he said humping a little of that hardness against where she liked it.

“Your weird little brain is fascinating.”

“Oh, yeah? What’s *your* get-off spot?”

She lost her smile, said, "What's that?"

"Your mental clit."

"I don't have one," she said.

"Wow, it's that bad."

She widened her eyes with comical shock. "Guy with such a little dick ought not to judge a girl he's lucky will tolerate such disappointing equipment."

She looked in his eyes, held back the smile as long as she could, let him believe she meant that, and watched tumbling pins of horror clatter and wobble behind those dark eyes of his. "That got you, didn't it?" she purred near his ear at last and Max almost swooned. He chuckled against her and squeezed her hard enough she huffed.

Next thing, he's got her fingers laced, hands pinned over her head again. "You better tell me," he almost growled.

"Tell you what?"

"Your mental clit."

"Oh, no way, Max. No."

"Yes."

She hesitated, for a second almost ready to tell him, then a wash of shame came up and forced a laugh from her instead. Max let her fingers go, gathered her wrists, but caressed them with his thumbs. She looked in his eyes.

"I don't think I'm ready to tell you," she said and hoped he would drop it. But instead his features sagged, and she saw real hurt there in his eyes.

He looked like he would say *please*, but he said nothing, just the muscles of his jaw flexing but no utterance coming.

She whispered, "It's so embarrassing."

He looked supportive, and it surprised her, she expected more selfishness. He smiled a little, said, "After what I just said to you?"

She sucked her teeth and made a grimace she hoped would look pretty in the dim light from the street. She exhaled completely like she used to before jumping in the Coololla Loch, she being the biggest chicken and the last to get in, Marly and Sara buffooning her from the frigid water. The deep exhale a thing she still did almost ten years on now when she prepared to do something she must, but knew she would hate. At least at first.

"Oi," she bailed, and drew a deep breath, turning her face away from him.

“Come on,” Max urged her.

She kept her eyes open but watched his face through the narrowest of slits. “Maybe you could...” her voice thinned to a soughing whisper: “Come on my feet?”

Now she watched his face struggle, his cheeks twitched and his lips practically trembled, and she felt a prickly heat come up her back and her upper lip took on an almost instant chill of sweat. He was trying not to laugh, and she wanted to die. *Why would she say that shit out loud?*

“That’s so fucking hot,” he breathed, and right there she fell more in love with this guy.

“I thought you would laugh at me,” she said.

“I might later but all I want to do right now is come on your feet.”

“With that tiny little dick?”

He dropped his weight against her and she felt his hardness press between her legs and boy did she need it right now.

“We’re going to have some night,” he said, and she agreed.

Then he asked her what she worried: “If you can’t ask for it, how do you know you like it?”

She pursed her lips to the tightest Kewpie crescent and shook her head no.

“Tell me,” he said. “Other guys do it to you?”

She still shook her head, but was comfortable enough to say, “One.”

“Just once?” he asked, and as he did, ground his hardness against her in the perfect spot and it made her gasp.

“One guy,” she whispered.

“You asked him to do it?”

She still shook her head no, feeling a compulsion to tell him though it was a story no woman should tell her current mate. She said, “He did it without asking.”

“What an asshole,” Max said and there he was grinding a bolt of steel into her again.

“Unh-unh,” she said, “he was the kind to get away with it.”

“Was he...? Was he big?”

He could be for the story. She fibbed. “He was, Max. Really big.”

“Was he?”

“Massive.”

“Were you sleeping?” Max asked her like a good pervert, figuring all the possible dirty angles.

“Sometimes,” she said.

Max groaned with delight at her answer and his hand moved between them, fiddled with his pants and she heard his zipper draw down. She went to work, too, pulling up on her skirt and tugging her panties aside.

“Put it in me quick,” she whispered so her breath touched his ear, but he needed no instruction, the tip of him finding her opening with one try and slipping fully inside. She groaned in his ear, the sound curling up to a loud and embarrassing squeak.

As he moved it in and out of her and she loosened for him, her sticky insides parting and lubricating, he wanted more details, asking, “What is it you like?”

The grip to keep her dark parts secret was strong, but the truth was wet and slippery—and something about Max Milton made her feel very safe, but very, very dirty. “I like how it’s hot, and wet. I like how it tickles. He’d...”

“Go on,” he urged when he heard her falter, and she could hear a desperation she liked in his voice.

“He’d get it between me toes...”

Max coughed a sound of breathy appreciation against the nape of her neck and he started to fuck her faster. Her arms went round him and she clutched her nails into him.

“Sometimes, Max, I’d wake up, ah, and he’d be down at the bottom of the bed... he was so hot, so bad, mm, and he’d be playing with his big dick...”

“Oh, ah, yeah,” he grunted in her ear and her brain flipped in the cavern of her skull; disbelief she would be able to share her dirtiest turn-on with someone. She’d never ever even told Marly this, and she was a bit of a perv, too.

She cried out loud and choked it back. The pleasure was intense, and it was wound with a strange emotion she couldn’t pinpoint. “He’d gripped me ankles together and I... I liked it. I’d put my feet together and watch him jerk his, mm, thing ah-over my shoulder laying on me front... ah... I’d wiggle my toes for ‘im, mm, and I couldn’t wait to feel his come on my skin, posing my feet...”

“Oh, fuck, Keely... oh, fuck,” he grunted and she could feel his stroke turn liquid with his own building excitement.

“Yeah?” she gasped looking for approval.

“You’re so fucking hot,” he babbled, and they both laughed as they rocked together.

“Couple of perverts, Max, we’re terrible,” she whispered, slipping her hands under the backside of his pants, squeezing past the tightness of his belt so she could clutch his ass cheeks and dig her nails into him.

“We’re not right in the head,” Max said and bit her ear and it made her cry out again, loud and high and sexual and it got them both laughing again.

Open Windows

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 14

WHILE HE FUCKED HER, he pictured her in some ratty apartment with high windows, not fancy, a poor young person's apartment, young and romantic, Europe, her and her lover's copies of Flaubert and Joyce littered the floor; they drank wine, they smoked, they fucked a lot. Their apartment smelled like Keely's pussy. Was it France? Was it Ireland? Maybe Saudi Arabia—but he couldn't picture what an apartment there would look like so he stuck with Dublin. She was in love with a bad young man with a big dick and she liked it when he woke her by jerking off on her feet. It was an unexpected gift; an enormous one. So wild and unexpected, it was like stumbling through the jungle only to whack your machete across a tangle of vines and discover the lost city of Opar. God, she was perfect and precious, a goddam treasure. How much more was there in her? How much dirty badness?

He took her knee, turned her over so she was face down on his couch. Semen boiled in his balls and he did not want this to be over, no way. His eager little girl got on her tummy in the beautiful dress he'd bought her and her delicate hands lifted the skirt and showed him her bare ass. The panties she'd worn for him were askew, her pussy bared, a glint of light winking in her nest of hot, sopping membranes. His cock drove home with ease, hard and spear-like, her sleeve a slick, inviting mouth hungry to receive. He buried himself deep and rolled his hips until he felt her rhythm against him; he matched it. Ginger hair gathered in his hand, like silk between his fingers, he fucked her, pulling up on her chin to arch her back. Her expression was one of pleasure; mouth agape, eyes closed; her beauty was

insane. He took her earlobe in his mouth, felt the tang of her earring on his tongue.

They fucked like that for minutes, both of them passionate and committed to the moment, doing it dirty, but a definite connection between them.

“Up,” he whispered in her ear as he felt the boil beginning to rise again. He withdrew, helped her to stand, her skirt falling above her knees. She was wild-eyed, sexed, fevered, eager to know what he wanted now, and he could be the one she’d remember because he wanted nothing more. “Go to the window...”

She nodded, and he took both her hands in his, walked her backward to the chrome and leather recliner near the window, keeping her eyes while they walked. He stopped her there, back to the glass, the East Village out the window, the bar across the street.

“Open the glass,” he said, undoing his tie and unbuttoning his shirt. Keely turned, put a knee on the chair’s seat and slid open his window next to the AC unit. The sounds of a bar band came up from the street, cold air and shouting voices, the smell of the city; its garbage, its greasy food, its filth.

Now with only his pants on, he guided her to stand at the edge of the chair, circled his arms around behind her, undid the dress’s zipper. She flicked her hair away as he stepped back and guided the dress down her body. She’d worn no bra, letting the dress’s bodice do the work for her and her heavy perfectly formed breasts fell and swayed, her pink nipples rising to meet him. She’d gathered her hands over her belly button, her panties were left askew, her furry pubic mound visible to one side.

He kissed her breasts, and she caressed his back, he went to his knees and pulled her panties with him, getting them to her knees before letting them fall to the floor. One hand on the inside of a knee he lifted so she set a foot on the seat, and he slipped underneath her, breathing her in, smelling her hot sex, its musk, its flower; her pubic hair tickled at his nose. Tongue flicking up, he got her moaning, then he suckled, caressed her inner thighs, cupped a buttock. When he had her legs shaking, he eased a finger into her anus and she made constricted sounds like she was choking, but slowly a sigh of pleasure escaped her and she relaxed against his intrusion.

Quarter of an hour he pleased her like that, got her singing her songs, and he hoped they all heard it out there in front of the bar, smoking their

cigarettes, the loud sounds of ecstasy from this beautiful Irish girl making them look up, making them hard even. At last she collapsed on the leather seat, panting, blushing from orgasm. Nothing more beautiful. In the blue moonlight her alabaster flesh looked like silver; she shone in the night, a perfect white shape against black leather. Eyes fluttering, she dazedly watched him undo his pants and let them down. His cock stuck out upright and hard and throbbing and she watched it, sighing in anticipation. Shimmied to the edge of the chair, she kissed his stomach, stroked his cock. He held up her hair, gathered it over her head, brought it to his nose. She sunk his cock in her mouth; cool and wet and perfect. Head bobbing, she sucked his dick lovingly. A dick she'd thought to call big. She'd seen a few, and he knew it.

He'd never felt more possessed by powerful dominating lust. The most he wanted right now was to rock her world, make himself the one she remembered; the one in future she may confess to some future law school prospect-boyfriend (if he failed to keep her) was the one who did the sexiest things. To establish within her a sexual milestone, maybe one she would remember forever.

But he stooped, gathered under her legs and encouraged her to turn over on the chair, get on her knees and hoop her arms around the chair back. Knees on the outside of her thighs, he smoothed his body against her and slid himself inside from behind, his hands going around front to cup her big breasts. She raised up, her palms curling over the chair's top corners, and they began to work together, humping and rolling, going slow and letting it build. He watched her head rock back and forth, listened in the quiet to the sound her long hair made sliding on the leather. Their breaths came fast, and their motions quicker and jerkier. When it was time, he pulled out, stepped back. She complained, but stopped when he gripped her ankles together. That made her head go over her shoulder to look down at her feet. Her expression was one of breathy awe, mouth hanging open, brows curled, an almost forlorn expression of lust, like she regretted how much this turned her on. And he didn't even need to stroke, he'd timed it right...

But the first flex of his cock sent a big stream up her backside. It missed, but she'd witnessed it, felt it slap over one bare buttock, and she made a soft appreciative sound. Now her toes curled, her feet flexed, she brought them together like she formed a bowl to collect his seed in. She had small feet, perfectly white, the soles bunched in fine feminine lines as she

arched them. He grunted at the second launch, and it went across her foot. She bucked, flexed her feet. More streamed from his tip and she watched it. Gushes of his excitement leapt from him in short, steep arcs, flopping onto her pretty feet. As it increased in volume over her skin, she wiggled her toes and it seeped down in the nooks. He slapped a palm on her ass, let his hand dip, sunk his thumb in her pussy. Keely arched her back now, gripped her toes tight like fingers in a fist, and his cum made a squelching sound in the tightening grip of her feet. Keely stiffened, made a funny chugging inhale that was barely audible. Her thighs began to shake and tremble, then her ass cheeks joined in. She was coming.

SHIELDED by a tent of her hair, face pressed against her folded forearm, she panted around teeth that had clenched a soft bite of her own arm-flesh. Saliva ran over her skin and her eyes fluttered. She moaned. Her stomach still did a light tremulous thing right now, still sensitive from the orgasm.

Max kissed her shoulder blade, stepped back. She was afraid to turn and face him; a weird mix of Catholic shame, embarrassment, and dirty gratitude. How do you put in words a thank you for such perversion? When she raised up finally, she looked down at the street. While she was coming, she'd seen men down at the bar, smoking cigarettes, sitting on the metal garbage receptacles outside the Sheffield Arms. Now if they were to look up, they might even see her bare tits. She watched to see if they would. The February air came in the open window and stung her naked nipples. One last chance for them to look up: she reached and slid the window closed. Now she chuckled, scooped her hair back. She turned, and she was alone.

“Max?...”

She wiggled her toes and chuckled again, looked down to the mess he'd left on her soles. It gave her another funny little tummy tickle.

Max emerged from the dark of the kitchen. In one hand he held a bottle of Jameson's, in the other he'd pinched two kitchen glasses. Over his still-hard cock, he'd draped a tea-towel, and it bobbed from side-to-side as he returned.

She watched him, eyes narrowing as she couldn't help a smile. Without saying a word, he came to the side of the chair and presented her the towel

folded over his dick. She plucked it from him, his dick nodding up and down. She said, “Most men can bring me two towels on their dick.”

He laughed as he walked to the table by the couch and put the bottle and glasses down. “Your words, Keely,” he said, returning to her, kissing her shoulder, “are powerless after what we just did.”

She scrunched her face up, feeling very self-conscious, looking up at him sheepishly.

“You’re the hottest fucking thing on the planet,” he said, and kissed her forehead.

A quip was called for here, but nothing came. He’d left her a little flabbergasted, and she wasn’t used to being speechless.

And he didn’t linger, didn’t loom and pressure her discomfort—no, he walked naked to the turntable looking to select a record. She watched that cute butt work, watched the way he cocked a casual hip, dark glistening dick sticking out straight.

She let his come seep longer, enjoying watching him while his seed grew cold. He wasn’t dark and dangerous like the first man who’d come on her feet, though he had his own mysteries she liked. He was a better version of that man; four years older rather than seven.

“What are you playing?” She wiggled her toes, felt the wet crackle.

He set the needle on the record, there was a brief hiss, then some chunky repetitive funk guitar and some revving engines. “Public Enemy, first album.”

She shrugged, “Never heard of it,” she said as he crossed to the couch and flopped on it, ran his hands through his slick hair and gave a satisfied exhale.

“Pour us a drink,” she said as a man began to rap now. He did, and she used the towel to clean her feet, getting between all her toes. Towel tossed aside, she crossed to the couch and joined him, her feet still feeling a little unclean—but she didn’t mind at all.

When she plopped down next to him, he pushed a drink in her hand and she cuddled against his side, kissed his nipple.

“Oh, fuck, Max,” she sighed, and he kissed the top of her head.

“You’re so, so awesome,” he laughed.

She laughed, said, “You think those men down at the bar heard me?”

“You’re safe,” he said, “safe with me.”

She sipped her whisky.

Both of them relaxed, fast breaths returning to normal, drinking and listening to an old rap record. Max rolled his head toward her, smiled.

“What is it?”

He shook his head like he’d wanted to say something but changed his mind. Then said it anyway, his eyes wincing as he spoke. “I keep saying to myself Don’t talk about it, don’t talk about it, but I want to...”

“You can talk to me.”

“Was it Cole?”

“What?...”

“Who came on your feet.”

She thumped him. “Gross, no. I wouldn’t tell you something about your mate.”

“You can. If it was.”

“It wasn’t,” she said, settling her cheek on his shoulder and frowning.

Early Saturday she’d arrived, and since then they’d turned his apartment into an animal den. Empty bottles, dirtied glasses, unclean dishes; on the floor were socks and underwear, her panties; the couch where they sat had a semen-stained blanket and pillows from the bedroom. And the bedroom looked just as bad—minus the two pillows. Max was a lot of fun. She didn’t want to go back to Cambridge tomorrow. It hurt to think about it.

He sighed in preparation again, and she knew what was coming.

He said, “What was it like?”

“With Cole?”

“Yeah.”

She snuggled a little closer, then leaned to the table set her glass down and topped it up. He handed her his for the same. But she left them on the table and returned to his side again.

“I don’t know, Max...”

“You can tell me. Believe me, you can tell me.”

She stroked her cheeks, considered what telling him would mean, but trusted that he wanted to know because he was afraid of the unknown. There were things with him and Maggie she’d like to ask, but she wasn’t ready. If Max was ready...

“It was good. Really good.”

He grunted. “You had a crush on him?”

“I did. Bad. Just for a few days, but Max, I was eighteen, just eighteen by a few weeks, yeah? And, look at him, you know what he looks like. But

I'm not dumb. After a few days I knew the score, as they say."

"Did he hurt you?"

"Yeah. But not really, Max. I was over it in a week and didn't think about him. I'm friends with him now and I don't think of him that way."

"Not even a little?"

"No, Max. Not even a little. He's hot, but I had my turn. He's with Maggie now. How desperate do you think I am?"

"Okay, okay," he laughed. "He was good in bed?"

"...Yeah."

"Did you guys do *everything*?"

"It was only a couple times, Max," she laughed.

"Did you go down on him?"

She nodded, watching his face.

"You had sex, of course."

"Of course."

"Anal?"

She couldn't actually remember. "I don't know."

"You don't know?" he said with restrained incredulity.

She looked around the room trying to recall but couldn't find an answer.

"I really don't remember."

"He's pretty... He's, you know, pretty big. You don't remember that?"

She said, "He was pretty big, but—"

"Pretty big?"

"No," she corrected herself, remembering her freaky boyfriend wanted the truth, not the sanitized pap she would normally feed a guy. "He was one of the biggest. Really thick, like, I guess the thickest. You know, I don't think we had anal. You're right, I would remember that."

"Yeah, I think you'd remember that."

She ran a finger over the curve of his ear and said, "Aw, I guess you're still stinging from the first time you had anal with him?"

He huffed soft laughter and batted her thigh. She kissed his shoulder. He fell to rest his cheek on her breast and she stroked his cheek.

"It was one-night-stand sex with Cole, Max. Hard, rough, fun. Then it was a *couple* nights' stand. We laughed a little, but he was cold to me. I think I saw warmth there because that's what I wanted to believe. Now later I see I was just some freshman bimbo to him. And I get it. I'm not mad at him. I like him. He didn't take advantage of me. Never made promises or

did anything bad. The sex was hot but mechanical, and in the grand scheme of things it amounted to nothing.”

Max was quiet a moment and then he said, “He showed me the pictures you sent him.”

The tips of her fingers tingled and her heart jumped a beat. “What?”

“I think he did. I think it was you. He showed me sometimes the stuff girls sent to him, and I remember a redhead he described as a screamer.”

“Are you fucking serious?” she said, partially sitting up and Max’s head sliding off her bosom.

“Depends how mad you are,” he laughed and sat up.

“He showed you me pics?”

“You know we do that...”

“Yeah, but I *know* you.”

“Not then, Keely,” he said, still laughing.

She couldn’t shake the angry feeling even though she knew guys showed it around. She didn’t even know Max then, but she felt embarrassed now. “What did I send?”

“It’s been killing me trying to remember. I wish I could. I want to ask Cole if he still has them—”

“You better not.”

“I’d love to see them.”

“I’m asking him, Max, and if he has them, I’ll make him delete them.”

“Don’t tell him I told you,” Max said.

“Oh fuck, I’m so mad,” she said, a mild but unshakeable anger clinging to her like a bad smell. “What was on his phone?”

Now he looked to her, face a little too mirthful for her liking, about to tell her something she didn’t want to hear. He said, “I want to say... you sent a picture of your pussy.”

“Did I?” she whined. She might have.

“I told you I don’t remember.”

“So he showed you so many pictures of conquered pussy you can’t remember which was which?”

“He got around.”

“And you just hung off him, slobbering over his phone.”

Max stiffened, and she knew she’d gone too far. She made a wincing face that Max couldn’t see and took a deep breath trying to quell that dumb anger that could grip her reins every once in a while.

“You didn’t show him any pics of *your* conquests?” she said now and stroked his chest.

“I was with Maggie,” he said timidly and it broke her heart suddenly. This great guy hanging off Cole, watching his string of naked whores on his phone, then later that guy walks off with his girlfriend. And he’s still friends with him? She felt her eyes swell with a sympathetic feeling of loss, knowing how Max must have hurt.

He said, “I didn’t share any pictures...”

Aye, you didn’t need to. Her brow furrowed with the mystery of how their trifecta came to be. How *did* Max, Maggie, and Cole come to be?

WELL, he’d played it pretty cool, but it didn’t take long for this kind of dirty honesty to pick at an old, uncomfortable scab. Best to drop it before it was too late, before this became something he regretted. Right now, digging into the ore of her Cole-vein had produced bounty. Surprising bounty that he hadn’t anticipated. Keely could handle his kink, it seemed, and more: her own was intriguing. So powerful, if he were honest, it dwarfed his own. But the difference was complementary, like two odd-shaped things that when brought together snuggled up to each other in a comfortable fit you hadn’t anticipated.

Arm curled around behind her back now, he held her closer. She melted to him, her hand moving up his thigh and closing around his cock, still hard and upright. “You want to fuck me with this little thing?” she said and gave it a wag.

He stroked her upper arm and chuckled. “It’s not little,” he groaned, watching her pale hand gripped on it.

“I’ll do whatever you want me to, Max, say anything you want,” she said, turned her face up to meet his. He kissed her.

“Not tonight,” he sighed.

“When you’re in the mood,” she agreed, making it sound like they’d arranged a deal as she settled her cheek on his chest. “You ought to be proud of how hard it is. You’re always hard.” She was stroking him again, and knowing she was studying it right now made him even harder. She

squeezed it. “Seriously, Max, you never offer me that rubbery eighty percent, you’re always at a hundred.”

“You can pat yourself on the back for that,” he said.

She laughed, stroked down, crawled her fingers over his hanging balls to gather them up and gave them a tender squeeze. He shook his head to clear away the thought she’d done this before, been playful and intimate with another man’s genitals—maybe many men’s—but couldn’t ignore that jealous swell up the black nighttime lagoon in the curiously sinister part of his mind.

She said, “You’ve got a great one, Max, I’m fond of it. It’s a good shape, touches my insides just the way I like.”

He groaned an appreciative laugh. “Where do I rank?”

She chuckled through her nose and hummed, contemplating. She was so open, so playful, that his heart began an ache for her.

“Umm,” she said, still considering, gripping him near the base and tilting his cock left then right, giving it a good assessment. The silly badness had his cock swelling even harder, the skin pulling tight, the head plumped to full volume. Now she was looking at his absolute best.

“Eighty...” she said with slow judgmental pausing, “eightieth percentile.” She started laughing.

“I’ll take it,” he said with a smile, caressing her arm again. “Are you padding my number up?”

She studied it again, moving it side to side. “Seventy-five,” she said.

“I love your honesty,” he said, and kissed the crown of her ginger head. He ventured: “What’s the sample size?”

She let his cock go, sat straighter so she could see his face, swiped her hair back from her face and tossed it over one shoulder, wafting the smell of sex and shampoo. “I’ve had boyfriends, Max.”

He said, “There’s no wrong answer.”

“Oh, do tell.”

“Would it surprise you if I said I prefer a high number?”

“Yes,” she said, eyeing him dubiously.

“You can tell me.”

“I don’t know, Max...”

“You can’t count that high?”

She batted him, rolling her eyes and smiling. “I don’t keep count. I honestly don’t know.”

“Just tell me that you’ve been happy.”

“Mostly.” The smile dipped.

“You’ve had fun?”

“I don’t know what to tell you.”

“Like I said, there’s no bad answer. As long as you’re happy...”

“I’m happy. And you’ll be pleased to know it’s a not a low number, as chagrined as I am to tell you.”

It settled him; she was a good girl who did bad things and if he played his cards right, he might have plenty more nights with her to learn her secrets. No need to flip through all the pages, best to take his time—greed could turn her off.

So he showed her a smile, took her hand and kissed the back of it, held it against his chest. “I just want to know you’ve figured out your mysteries.”

“I have,” she said, “You’re my mystery now.”

She sat forward, put her feet on the floor. He watched her sexy pale back move as she reached for her glass of whiskey and took a swig, breasts swaying. She set the glass down with a hard knock, wiped her mouth with the back of a hand, swiveled around to face him and straddled his hips. She shimmied so she sat on his lap, his cock poking the inside of her thigh.

He said, “You want it again?”

She ran her thumbs under his eyes, raked her fingers through his hair and cupped her fingers around the back of his neck. “I’m not letting this hard dick go to waste.”

“We can’t stop fucking.”

She nodded, kissed him, slow and gentle, sucking, biting on his lower lip. She drew back. “We’re really good at it.”

His hands went over her breasts, thumbs curling around the shape of her hard nipples. “I’m going to be limping in to work all week.”

“Any luck, yeah,” she said, reaching behind her, tilting her hips, grabbing his cock and pushing it inside her. She sat down on him, and he slid inside her hot body. “If I’m not sitting on a cushion all week, Max,” she said, looking in his eyes, “you’ve let me down...”

PART 2

Duo // 3

APRIL 8 - APRIL 9

Nocturnal Emissions

THURSDAY, APRIL 8

LAPTOP AND BOOKS back in their bag and sitting in the front hall, Keely helped Maggie make popcorn by microwaving the butter. Thursday nights were study nights the last half of the semester. Cole went to the gym and played basketball, so she'd gone the last five weeks in a row to hang out with Maggie, break books and bread, shoot the shit. Tonight they'd had a salad with leftover chicken breast and then they'd stayed silent at the kitchen table, both of them drinking green tea and writing their asses off, fingers blazing on keyboards and teeth gnawing on pens. Tonight she'd sleep over because they worked late. Cole had since cleaned out the guest room and Keely never told Maggie what their cluttered room had made her and her ex-boyfriend do (but wondered if Max had ever told her).

Now they were in her kitchen preparing snacks for an hour or two of Netflix before bedtime. When the popcorn was done, Maggie dumped the air popper into two bowls, saying, "Bet you wish it was Friday already," because Max was staying in Boston on the weekend. They hadn't been together in four weeks because of school and work pressures.

"I really do miss him," she said, slowly crushing a popped kernel between her front teeth, then grinding it down. This week had seen an interesting development in the relationship and she didn't know what to think about it yet, other than anxiousness.

"Wine?" Maggie asked, and she nodded. Keely folded her arms up with her butt leaning on the counter while Maggie squatted down on the other side, perusing their small sampling of wine. When she returned, she pretended to knock Keely on the head with the neck of the bottle, bringing

it to rest on her hairline like she was being knighted then gently tapping. She said, “You guys fighting?”

Keely said, “Fighting, us?—No, it’s not that at all.”

“That’s a relief,” Maggie said, winding the corkscrew down the bottle’s neck.

It wasn’t until they were through an episode of Forensic Files, watching on Maggie’s laptop placed on the coffee table, when Keely decided she’d like some advice. “I was on the phone with him last night...”

Maggie paused what she was doing, smirking almost. She sat with her feet on the couch, tucked in a corner with her forearms draped over her knees. She looked like she already knew what the problem was and Keely was preparing herself for whether it should make her angry or not.

“What...?” Keely said, “Do you know what it is?”

“No,” Maggie said, “no, I don’t. Go on.” She hugged her legs, rested her chin on her knees.

“It’s just,” she continued, gathering her ponytail over her shoulder and working the fingers of both hands through it, “we’ve been seeing each other for four months now...”

“That’s a good amount of time.”

“It is.”

“But what’s wrong?”

“It’s not wrong... It’s... He invited me home to meet his parents...”

“Aw,” Maggie said, crumpling and touching her chest, handling something she wore under there. “That’s so sweet, though.” Her eyebrows had tented in the middle, and she cocked her head.

“It’s not the first parents I’ve met or anything, but they don’t live down the street, you know. We have to get on a plane, maybe we’ll stay there—will his parents put us in the same bedroom?... It’s a trip *solely* to meet his parents. We’re not doing anything else...”

“It’s not a big deal, Keely, don’t make anything out of it.” Now she extended her hands, encouraging her closer. They’d each taken opposite ends of the couch, so she set her bowl of popcorn on the floor and crawled to Maggie’s end. It hadn’t occurred to her to look for a hug, but the closer she got to Maggie the more she wanted an embrace.

They hugged over Maggie’s knees and Maggie smoothed circles on her back. “It’s good news, Keely,” Maggie whispered.

“I know it is. It’s a lot, and it... seems early...”

"It's not," she said.

"Your Max plays for keeps."

"He's your Max now."

"He's not moving too fast?"

"No, Keely. You're going to love his family." She blew an exhalatory raspberry, eyes turned up contemplating something. "Don't think of it like he's introducing you to his family. It's more like he's got somebody great in his life that he wants *them* to meet. For their benefit. His mom and dad are absolutely going to adore you."

"You don't think he's moving too quick?"

"Not at all. When is it? When are you going?"

She rested her back against the couch, her front squished against Maggie's legs. Maybe she was making too much out of it. At first when Max had asked her she'd been overwhelmed and excited. It felt like such an honor, such a recognition of her in his life. Over the last twenty-four hours she let it get to her though. "Four weeks away. Middle of May. Just for a weekend."

Maggie did a funny head wobble, eyes turned up and mouth tweaked to one side.

Keely asked, "What is it?"

"Oh, nothing—I wondered about that..."

"About what?"

Maggie still couldn't meet her gaze and she'd resorted to talking with her hands to reinforce the contrition. "It's... I'm going to be there, too."

"*You* are?..."

"Yes. I'm... It's me that's going. I told Max I was going to visit them and he said he'd come along."

"Why are *you* going?"

"I see them every once in a while. Because, you know, June..."

"Has cancer," Keely said showing her she was up-to-date.

"Hodgkins," Maggie said. "I visited when she had chemo..."

"She's better now."

"In remission now, doing great. But I'm not going to get a chance to see them this summer, and once I start my Masters next year, I worry I'm going to get too busy. I want to see them before Christmas, too, for sure."

"You see them at Christmas?"

"Not this year, but last year I did."

They sat very close. Her side and one breast pressed Maggie's thigh and knee. Their faces were close and in sharp focus; Maggie's skin was flawless, her cheeks broad, amber-chestnut pupils set in beautiful Chinese eyes. This was the face her boyfriend had loved; those pouting lips were the ones he was kissing only six months ago.

When she pulled away, Maggie stopped her, squashing her against the couch with her knees and grabbing the hood of her sweatshirt. "Don't do it, don't do it," Maggie said.

"Don't do what?"

"Don't be hurt."

"Don't be hurt? You mean how I thought for the last day and a bit that my boyfriend wanted me to meet his parents..."

"He does, Keely. He wants you to meet them."

"You don't know that. You said it was *you* going. He's going with *you*, not me. I'm an afterthought because he knows he can't go *only* with you. So what does he do...?"

"What does he do...?"

"Invites me," she said trying to sit up but Maggie had a grip on her hood. "Invites me because he feels guilty."

"It's not like that..."

The front door opened and Cole came in the hall, his sneakers squeaking on the floor. She and Maggie sat like that on the couch, listening to him banging around, Maggie still holding her in place. Maggie's head rolled back on the rest of the couch seat in time to see Cole poke his head into the living room.

"So quiet in here, I wondered where you guys were."

Maggie said, "We're in here," Keely watching her elegant neck work forming the words.

"And, uh, what's going on in here...?" He was smirking, making a joke at the awkward and close position he'd found them on the couch in together.

Maggie leaned her head back again, practically looking at Cole upside down. "She's mad at Max."

A smile eased across his rugged, tanned face and showed his white and devious smile. Now he hopped down to the living room, coming to the couch. "What did he do...?" he said excitedly.

Maggie said, "He invited her to go to Michigan to see his parents."

Cole's glee faded. He said dryly, "Wow, what a fucking jerk."

"It's more than that," she said now, pulling the hood of her sweatshirt out of Maggie's hand and smoothing her hair. Cole came around to the front of the couch and took up the end spot where she'd been sitting. Now she was between them on the couch and he picked up her bowl of popcorn and helped himself.

Maggie scolded him. "You need to shower," she said, straightening her leg and pushing her toes against his thigh. He wore gray sweats and an open zip-up hoody. Under it he wore a white scoop neck T-shirt that showed off his chest. His blonde hair was tied back and tangled with sweat.

"Give me a break," he said, pulling the bowl out of the way so she wouldn't upend it, "I just got in the door. I came in here for some gossip not to get insulted."

Keely tried changing the subject: "Were you playing basketball?"

He nodded, "Outdoor courts, too, it's so nice out there..."

"It's cold," Maggie said and huddled into her sweatshirt.

"I worked up some heat," he said with confidence.

"Yeah, but go wash that heat off, please, before you ruin our couch."

"I'm not even sweating," he said.

Maggie said, "You worked up a heat...?"

"But it's breezy—I'm dry, feel me..." Now he leaned over her and gave Maggie his forearm. She patted him down, squeezed the cotton of his sweatshirt, gave him a suspicious look.

"See?" he said.

"I'd still prefer it if you had a shower."

"I'll do it if you come up with me..."

"I'm right here, guys," Keely said.

That just urged Cole. He pulled on Maggie's arm now, purposely getting him closer to her, both of them overtop of Keely's knees, saying, "What do you say, you're so worried about our couch, come up and give me a good scrubbing..."

"We have company..."

"Keely will understand, won't you, Keely?"

She shrugged, pushed her head back into the couch to keep distance. Maggie and Cole's faces were close together; Maggie could seem like a boss at times but when Cole put on the charm, she always fell for it.

In a low voice that didn't sound too convinced, Maggie looked in Cole's eyes, saying, "I'm not going to leave our guest here alone while we go upstairs..."

Cole let her go, backed away, smirking, holding Maggie's gaze with his. It was a humorous take; he was making a joke without saying a thing, doing it with the slow speed of his withdrawal, the rakish smirk on his face, then a single cocked eyebrow. The implication was enormous. *She doesn't have to be alone, there's plenty of room in our shower...*

A rising heat rolled up her back like a wave and she held her breath. She swore her heart had stopped; all sure signs from a ginger-lifetime that her cheeks just fired up a blazing red. Shit, she could feel it in her earlobes, too—and she had her hair up in a ponytail.

She murmured with a tight voice: "Don't let me... stop you guys..."

"Don't let him get to you," Maggie said softly, and as proof her cheeks were blazing, she studied her face then stroked her thumb up her jaw and pressed into the centre of what was probably a hot red saucer on her right cheek.

Cole plopped his hand over the curve of her knee, fingers pressing the inside of her thigh. "Tell me what Maxy did."

She sighed, said, "He asked me to come home with him to Michigan and meet his parents, but he didn't tell me Maggie was going."

Cole drummed his fingers around the end of her knee where his hand was cupped, and her scalp tingled. Maggie was right there, and while the act was innocent, the two of them had been intimate. And intimate in some dirty ways. The feel of his hand was nice, and she wished she could stop thinking about it, but more importantly she would hate for Maggie to feel the hurt of jealousy.

After he'd contemplated it, he said, "Doesn't sound like a big deal."

"It's not what I thought it was."

"It is what it is. And what it is isn't bad."

Maggie patted Cole's smiling cheek now, and he smiled for her and closed his eyes. Maggie said, "She can get *fiery*."

"Redheads," he said.

"It's in my blood," she said. Both of them were pressing against her; she was sandwiched between them. She could feel their bodies on the points of her elbows, and knees. They were both beautiful people and up close like this they seemed larger than life; Cole with his lean, handsome face and

dazzling eyes, Maggie with this sultry innocence and exotic features. This was with what Max partook sexually for years. He'd been in between them like this probably regularly, none of them with any clothes at all, though. The thought was at once arousing and frightening. She said, "You don't think it's a big deal?"

Cole said, "It's weird he didn't tell you, but that's Max sometimes. He fucks up. You think he only invited you so he could go with Maggie?"

"No..."

"Right, that's stupid. The guy wants you to go home and meet his family, he's ready for it whatever way you look at it, and, hey, he's making it easier for you because you'll have a friend there who'll also vouch for you." He nodded his chin to Maggie. "They love her."

That made her stomach flinch as if she'd been poked.

Maggie said, "I'll put in a good word for you."

Cole said to Maggie, "I'm gonna hit the shower, monkey."

They came together over her knees and kissed lips. She watched their mouths work together.

Then Cole was patting her knee, heaving himself off the couch and putting her bowl of half-finished popcorn on the coffee table next to the laptop. He clapped his hands once, went behind the couch, saying, "Don't be too late."

Maggie let her head fall back again saying, "I'll be up in a bit."

Cole's feet beat up the stairs to the second floor, and it was just the two of them alone again.

Keely said, "You don't have to stay up with me."

Maggie watched her for a long moment, smiling sleepily, said, "One more episode," and pressed play.

SLEEP WAS ELUSIVE. She had history class at 9 A.M., and now it was just after midnight. Forty-five minutes of laying here and drifting off then waking up again.

Being that close to Cole and Maggie while they kissed gave her inescapable thoughts of her boyfriend coming home tomorrow night. Made her think of the way his life had been before she came on the scene. All

three of them—Max and Maggie and Cole—rolling around in bed together. She'd been a good girl for so long not asking, but now her imagination was in hyper-drive. Probably because she hadn't been laid in a month now. Sex was a necessity, and this was a hard stretch for sure.

Max would be home tomorrow night—and in this very guest bedroom they would probably spend quite a lot of time. There was studying to do, and she had a paper to finish, but they would probably sleep in, have a lot of sex; he'd let her work at the dining room table while he puttered around the kitchen, probably making dinner for them all. Right now though, these invasive and awful thoughts were having their way with her.

"Fuck it," she sighed, sat up, collected her iPhone from the night table.

At first she'd thought to text Max and maybe get something dirty going, but it was late, he'd be sleeping and had to go to work in the morning. He'd need his rest, because they were going to be *busy* when he got here. Marly was back in Dublin as of last week, and it would be lunchtime yesterday right now, so she texted her instead.

Keely: getting serious with Max

She lay and looked at the ceiling for almost five full minutes, but at last Marly got back to her.

Marly: what's happening?

Keely: things moving fast

She could practically hear the dramatic, taunting tone of her friend:

Marly: but you're so young

Keely: and hot

Marly: smoking

Keely: ty

Marly: talking bout ur fanny 🔥

Keely: bless you

Marly: how fast?

Good question. Maggie seemed to think there was nothing of Max's request for her to come home and meet his parents, and maybe she was right. Just an opportunity that presented itself, and maybe not intended to bear such weight of importance—really just a 'come hang out with my folks', rather than the official: It's Time To Meet My Parents. It was the travel that made it seem so significant.

Keely: I'm too young to meet him now

Marly: that serious?

Keely: yes

Marly: really...

Keely: meeting his parents

Marly: shit

Keely: plane tickets and everything

Marly: serious serious

Keely: he's bringing his ex-fiance

Marly: wtf?

She explained it as best she could, doing it in chunks over three texts. Marly said:

Marly: wot u got urself into?

Keely: weird, right?

Marly: weird x10

They chatted for ten minutes, but Marly wasn't much help. On the other hand it sounded like she was having fun back in Ireland. Somehow, Derek must have seen she was awake, because he sent her a gif of a panda bear with its head stuck in a feed bucket. He knew she loved panda bears. She said bye to Marly, dismissed Derek's text, irritated he'd seen she was up and knew she'd seen his panda. The guy must have been out late and looking for a fuck, but he was on his own.

She closed her phone and tossed it to the cushiony chair in the corner where her clothes were laid out. The guest bedroom had been cleared of its junk. Max said it used to host a lot of Cole's sporting equipment because the house didn't have a garage or basement. It was clean and tidy now, and she and Max had put it to good use a few times before this last month's long dry spell.

Up and walking to the window, she parted the curtain. Springtime now, the beginnings of buds on the trees, but the branches sparse enough she could see down on the brick sidewalk and the pavement below lit up by a pale yellowy street light. Max's car would be in the driveway tomorrow. Max was used to coming up and spending the weekend here.

And what were the things he used to do here?...

IN THE HALLWAY on her way to the loo, she stopped. There was a soft breathy sound, and she knew what it was right away. In fact, her brain knew so immediately her first response was to quicken her step, however her feet chose to stay planted for a moment. Like her brain wasn't quite sure what it heard. But it was clear: the sound of a woman enjoying sex. Maggie's soft

moans as she and Cole did *something*. Again, her brain made fiery impulses for her to skedaddle. *Go on and tinkle in the bathroom, honey, you wouldn't want to get caught...*

But a curious part of her had her sidestepping a little closer to their door. It was open, only two fist breadths, but enough to let the clear sound escape. And as she got closer, and Maggie's sex sounds came a little louder, the badness of what seemed to be suggested earlier on the couch came back to her. Cole insinuating all three of them could get in the shower. Both girls could scrub him down after his workout. Surely it was a joke. It *was* the kind of thing he would say and would think funny. But given her recent welcome into their tight circle she couldn't help but feel that it might be something on the table. But that's not what she wanted. She just wanted Max.

Behind her eyes wavered a high-definition mental image flickering like a big budget romance, camera focusing on Maggie and Cole's pretty mouths coming together accompanied by the soft sounds their damp flesh made.

Now she stood right at the gap; she could see the foot of the bed but not the bodies on it. If they were even on the bed. *Remember those things you saw in their drawer?* What if that's the tip of the iceberg? What if he has her suspended from the ceiling in some kind of studded leather sling? *You ready for that?*

Still, her fingertips touched the door. She swore she could feel vibrations through the wood and into her fingertips. The vibrations from Maggie's sounds. But the sounds were too soft, and it was just her imagination. She pushed on the door—pushing back against the *feeling* Maggie's sounds gave her.

Now she could see feet, saw them on the bed and knew that she hadn't been noticed. She could see Cole's left foot, large and masculine, then on the outside of his calf, curled against it, Maggie's small pale foot. The left one as well. He must be curved on top of her, taking her from behind.

It was funny now, to think about it. Spying on them. It was almost okay. If she got caught maybe they could all laugh it off. She pushed the door a little farther. She saw Cole's thigh, the big muscle down the side flexing as he fucked Maggie face down on the bed. No faces yet, but she could see the curled square edges of Cole's muscular rump. Could see the hairy tangle in the split of his ass. Occasionally there was a flash down below she knew

would be his testicles. It was a lurid and lubricious sight. His ass bounced up and down in steady syncopation. He was plunging what he had in an out of Maggie's turned up bottom. She lay writhing underneath him. God, was he gorgeous. His body perfect, a face that could sell products.

She pushed the door a little further, watched Cole's narrow waist revealed, could see the squirming muscles of his naked back. He was built, broad-shouldered with wide lats, but lean still; practically graceful. Maggie made soft choking noises underneath him. Little *Oh Gods* and *Oh nos*.

Cole's bouncing rump quickened its pace. A slick wet sound came now, and it almost turned her stomach over. *That was the sound of a pussy*. She knew that sound from her own, but now she heard another girl's. Gross—and it was someone she knew. Someone she knew and liked and now she was watching that girl get fucked really good. It was a sickening feeling; she was embarrassed that she hadn't left yet.

Instead, now she was pushing the door a bit further. Not wanting to press her luck, she began to ease her shoulder and face into the opening. With one eye now she could peep her two friends getting it on. Cole indeed had Maggie tummy down in the bedding, face twisted in ecstasy. Her pretty mouth turned down and open, her eyes squinted shut and her brow furrowed. Little quips of her voice whisked along the endings of her gasps. Cole was really giving it good. And she knew what that was like. Knew what it was like to be pinned underneath him, his masculine beauty overtop of you. That really thick thing he had between his legs pushing in and out of your body. There was a certain possession by him when he took you. His lovemaking was overpowering. He had the looks that inspired deep desire, and he had skill under the bed sheets, too.

At the small of Maggie's back, her hand poked out between her and Cole's hard stomach. Both her arms were folded behind her back at awkward angles; the hand was loosely curled, palm up. A flash of winking light off a hard and curved shiny surface combined with the soft clink of metal links had Keely's eyes widening. Maggie's hands were handcuffed behind her back.

Her scalp crawled and her heart suddenly raced.

Now Cole grunted and bucked harder. The bed they had was such a solid monolith even his vigor couldn't get it rattling. She knew—she'd done it with Max in that bed and they thrashed around quite a bit and it hadn't made a knock. Talk about quality. She continued to watch, watched him

push and hold, push and hold, watched Maggie's loose hand gather into a hard shaking knot.

It suddenly hit her. She gasped and darted her head back.

She'd just watched Cole come. Watched him ejaculate inside Maggie.

She felt so dirty, so profoundly awful. She violated them. That was their intimate moment, and she'd made herself a part of it. For a moment while she'd been watching she thought there was something funny about doing it. Like if they turned and caught her she would give them a funny thumbs-up and make them laugh. Now she felt like she'd stolen something from them. She backed away, moving so carefully because she worried she would make a sound. The embarrassment would be too much to endure. And why was that?

Because you liked it...

No, I didn't. *Yeah, you did.*

She shook her head no, feet padding backward along the edge of the floor where it met the wall, the less likely spot to make a squeak. Going to the loo was out of the question now. Maggie and Cole would be embarrassed if they heard her in the bathroom, probably guessing she might've overheard them having sex—never guessing their sweet friend would actually be bold enough to take a peek at them.

She slipped back into her bedroom, closed the door behind her with both hands on the knob, taking a full ten seconds to let the mechanism go back in place without making its metallic click. She sat down heavily on the edge of her bed. She had to pee still, could feel the tingle.

That was wild. She was a bad person. Badder than she thought, at least.

She drew her knees up, slipped underneath the covers and lay on her back. There was no way she was going to get to sleep. The plain white drywall above the bed was a film screen for more projected images showing the dirty things she'd just seen. Cole's ass going up and down. The way it flexed, its perfect shape. The way Cole's muscles moved on his back. Knowing what he was doing to Maggie. Knowing that huge dick of his was going in and out of her and how that felt. Soon her hands moved between her legs and she found herself slick. She slipped her hands inside her panties, brought her knees up in points that tented the bedding. She beat over herself, using two fingers at times then giving quick dabs in circles, her hips mashing against the force of her hand. It began with thoughts of Cole, thoughts of what she'd witnessed tonight. Some dirty flashes of the

few nights she'd spent with him in his dorm room at Farm; *and they'd gotten pretty crazy*. Could picture him naked that first night, though she'd been blitzed. One of the best-looking guys she'd ever been in bed with. No, the *best* looking guy. But as she got closer and closer, and her motor was primed already, she coaxed thoughts of Max forward. Thoughts of his lips, the way he liked to joke around in bed. Thought of the way he made love like a lover. Like how you read in a book. Thought of his smile...

Hiatus

FRIDAY, APRIL 9

MAX SMILED as she rode him, head rocking on the pillow, their hands locked together with fingers intertwined. Third shag of the night and Max had stamina. So did she. Four weeks without him had left her hungry. And horny.

Cole and Maggie had gone to bed before he got in. He was in touch via text, driving his car for the weekend instead of taking a plane or train. When his texts showed traffic would hold him up and he might not arrive before midnight, they knocked off. She'd stayed up waiting.

They'd collided in the hallway. The minute he was in the door she latched herself on him, locking lips and choking her arms around his neck. It was funny—it got them both laughing—but it was funny because it was true. That's how she felt. As they fake ravaged one another in the front hall, laughing and giggling and banging things, they both began shushing each other, not wanting to wake up their hosts. Then it was into the kitchen for a glass of water, and she helped him with his luggage. They behaved like normal people, but ten minutes after he'd come in that door they were both naked and doing it on the guest bed.

The first coupling had been a rush to the goal line. Max plowed her until he'd done his deed inside her. Five minutes tops. Then they laughed and talked and cuddled with each other. The second time around was a good one. A lovemaking session. Taking their time and doing it right. Hands roaming and exploring. This third time was different. Their absence had made her lusty and doing it twice already didn't do anything to sate it. She

was dirtier this time around, too; something lurking in her shadowy corners. Something dirty.

So now she was riding over top of him and holding his hands like two reconnecting lovers should. But her engines were just getting warmed up. She bounced on him, feeling his perfect connection with her, his hardness mated with her eager canal. The first two times around she'd made her squeaks, but she did it around sheets clenched in her teeth, but now she was on top and the sheets wouldn't reach her mouth. But the excitement was coursing through her, and even though usually when she was warmed up her sounds weren't so bright, Max had her chirping again. She arched her back, bit her lower lip, made a soft whinnying sound that if she weren't so turned on would make her laugh. Max's hands cuddled her breasts, her hard nipples across his soft palms.

"Like that, yes, like that," she told him, "keep going..."

Max was grunting now too, and their bed wasn't like the one Maggie and Cole slept on; there was a brief rattling against the wall from their headboard. There were quivering moans, grunts, a rattling headboard... Max pulled her head down, stopped her bronco riding. They were face-to-face, and she squirmed her hips against his. They breathed heavily into each other's mouths, her hands went over his body. He panted near her neck, "I hope... hope we're not disturbing them..."

She gave a breathy laugh, ran her fingers through her hair. She said, "They... They kept me up last night, fair is fair."

Max did a funny snort, but she watched him; watched for his reaction. Was he jealous that his old friend was satisfying his ex-fiancée? Did it hurt him to hear about it?...

Max asked her, "Sex...?"

"Oh, yeah," she said in the most reassuring way. "It was sex."

"Fair's fair—did you want to give them a show tonight? Show them how the Miltons do it?" he said, bucking his rump on the bed, making his erection jab a blast into her.

She made a gasp, puffed out her cheeks then laughed and buried her face in his neck. "Let's be polite," she said. Then adding, "Within reason."

"Within reason," Max agreed, and his hands scooped down her waist and cupped her butt cheeks. She wiggled her bottom for him and he spanked her. He felt wonderful inside her. She moved her head away again so she could see his face when she said: "I was a bad girl, Max," she told

him, her dark secret wanting the taste of daylight as timid as it was and comfortable in the shadows.

“Wait, what happened?” Max was alive and electric fast—any chance at a story where she was bad seemed to excite her man. It gave her courage.

“Would you be mad at me if I did something naughty...?”

“Are you going to tell me something dirty...?”

If she weren’t so turned on there would be no way she could have told him about the bad thing she’d done. She whispered, “I might have spied on our friends while they were in bed together...”

Max chuckled with ribaldry, looked in her eyes to see her state of mind. “Did you...?”

“I watched them, Max,” she said.

“Did you *really*?” Max gasped, but he was already way into this. Bucking one side of his hip while cradling her back, he flipped her so she was on the mattress; he got over top of her. She made a moaning sound, and he reached down and slipped himself inside her again.

“Did you *really* do that?”

He rocked his hips against her, easing himself in and out. She gave him a quick and rapid nod. Let her mouth hang open, pouted like a vixen.

“You *spied* on them?”

She said, “They were making so much noise, I was on my way to the bathroom...” Her eyes monitored his; they darted back and forth over her own, and she could read in his expression lust and anger and bereavement. Her badness did things to Max, and she wanted to know what they were. Max liked bad things.

He said, “You heard the noises, and you had to see?”

She smiled, saying, “It was innocent... Poor little me had no idea what I might see if I opened that door...”

Max studied her now, biting on his lower lip as his smile grew wider. “Are you traumatized?”

“I definitely saw them in a different light.”

“What did you see?”

She was reluctant to tell him. It was the kind of thing that would make someone else mad. She would be mad at him if he spied and told her about it. Of course, the subjects she’d spotted he’d already been quite intimate with...

“I saw them on the bed together and they were doing... *things*...”

“How long did you watch them for?”

“Until they were done,” she said, purposely trying to sound lewd. Truth was she’d only seen a few moments of action, but she liked the tension she could feel in her boyfriend’s body. Liked to feel his response to her dirty words...

Max said, “Do you think we’re both perverts?”

She sighed, “We might need a support group... Keep going...” Now she bucked against him too, letting him know they were on good ground here.

Max said, “What were they doing? How were they doing it?”

She said, “He had her face down on the mattress.”

“Doggy-style?” Max asked, and hearing the dirty word come out of his mouth but meant regarding his ex-lover bothered her. But she pushed it away. It was a good chance most of her chagrin these days came from herself. Her interpretation.

She said, “Not doggy-style. Flat on her stomach...” Then an idea came to her, and she moved on it. “I want to show you,” she said and scratched his biceps with her fingernails.

“Show me,” he whispered.

She used her hand to guide him out of herself, kept his gaze as best she could as she turned her hips over and showed her ass to him while watching over her shoulder at the hungry face she was giving him.

Max said, “She was face down like that?”

“He was giving it to her good,” she said and wagged her bottom.

MAX WAS STUNNED FOR A SECOND, her words overwhelming him like a sturdy bong hit, immediately hypnotic and bewildering. But then he began to smile, and she knew it was because he couldn’t believe she was giving him what he wanted. But she couldn’t believe it *was* what he wanted.

Eyes cast over her shoulder, she reached down and grabbed one of her buttocks, exposed her seams, hoisted a little higher and arced her hips.

“Max, he was doing it to her good, giving it to her so good, you should’ve seen her face...”

She hadn’t even intended to say that. She’d just wanted Max to put it back inside her, but it got away from her. It was an awful thing to say, and it

made her stomach do a funny flip-flop—but yet at the same time as she formed the last words of the sentence, a trembling lust quivered through her.

Max lowered, walleyed and unseeing, finding her pussy and running himself inside her and the wet sounds of a sudden spate of lubrication between her legs surprised both of them. She moaned for him, wanted him to know how far she would go for him. If dirty talk got him off, he was with probably one of the top ten dirty talkers on the East Coast right now. Max started to pat his hips against her bottom, his hardness pushing in and out.

She made a funny laugh, told him honestly, “You hear that?... That’s what it sounded like. I heard another girl’s pussy noises...”

That one got him so bad he had to tighten himself against her back; he growled in her ear and held himself stiff and hard inside her.

“You like that?” she whispered.

“Keep going,” he said, and resumed a syncopated thrusting; steady, easy strokes that felt so good.

“Yeah, that’s how they were doing it, Max. I could see Cole’s ass...”

“You saw his bare ass?”

“I did, I watched it going up and down.”

“Can’t believe you did that... Are you serious?...”

“I saw a little more, too...”

Max gripped her arms hard, squeezed her. He said, “What did you see?”

She hesitated, always worried about stepping over a line. Couldn’t believe she was saying the things she was saying already... She said, “I saw his balls...”

Max exhaled in her ear and she felt him trembling. His cock was like an iron bar inside her.

“You like that,” she said—not as a question but as a statement.

“Yeah,” he said after a long quiet moment, their hips swaying with each other, him fully inside her.

She said, “Don’t stop. In and out, Max, you *know* how to do it...”

“I have to be careful...”

“You like it that much?”

“You’re so incredible...”

She laughed. “That’s what I like to hear...”

“You are, you’re amazing...”

“Because I watched your friends shagging?... In some countries I might go to jail for that...”

“You’re, so amazing...” He withdrew, obviously not quite ready but wanting to please her, pushing in slow and careful.

“You want me to tell you about their noises?...”

“Tell me.”

“Cole had her squawking, Max, totally squawking.”

“I still can’t believe you watched.”

“It was hot at first, then I felt so dirty.”

“You are dirty.”

“I didn’t mean to, Max, but...”

“What?...”

“I saw Cole... I saw him... *finish*...”

Max gasped and stiffened. His cock froze inside her. “You saw him come?”

“Yeah, I saw it happen.”

His voice was shaky, asking: “You... you watched him ejaculate?”

She winced. Too far, maybe. “Inside her, Max... I didn’t know it was happening until it was happening...”

Max’s hip-patting against her bottom came quicker and quicker, and they got the mattress squeaking. She balled up fistfuls of bedsheet, brought her elbows in tighter together, squashing her breasts against the bedding. Her nipples dragged up and down on the fabric like they were match heads ready to light as Max fucked her harder. She gritted her teeth, could feel how close he was, how *hard* he was.

She rolled the dice on his kink. She could put two-and-two together, but if you weren’t talented, the whole thing could blow up in your face. “Maggie can take it,” she whispered, even the tone of her voice curling higher at the end out of curiosity. “You like that, Max?...”

“Take what?”

“Take it... take his *big*...”

The word big had been barely a whisper, but Max burst air across the nape of her neck and it made her eyelashes flutter. She’d unlocked the secret code. Found out the password for his bank account. She could drain him till he was bankrupt. Max pounded and pounded, doing it perfect. His hot skin sticking to her hot skin, both of them bouncing on the bed, pinched in an exquisite moment of pure pleasure.

In time with her horny boyfriend's thrusting, she panted: "I saw her take it... Take all he had... Take that huge dick he's got... She's so little... He's so big..."

Then Max was snorting and roaring behind her. His cock pulsed and flexed inside her, and it felt like doubled in steely girth, pushing out against her walls. She could feel tapping and wetness as he propelled a pretty impressive load for a third round. He heaved breath against her back, collapsed, still snorting, making almost agonal sounds like he'd just woken after a concussive blast. Hands down, she knew that was the biggest orgasm he had with her.

She laughed and wiggled underneath him, feeling his weight jostle on her back. He breathed quick gasps into her hair. When he moved again finally, his hands were limp, his arms clumsy. He pushed himself off of her back, his dick slipping out of her with a wet sound. Flopped to his back, his glassy eyes stared up at the ceiling.

She turned her head on the pillow to regard him; watched his blinking eyes staring up at the ceiling, those pouting lips open and panting.

She whispered, "Mental clit?"

He laughed and exhaled struggled for new air. "Mental clit," he said.

"I could tell," she said, wagging her bottom again. He reached down and slapped it. She kicked her feet.

"Hey," she said, nudging his shoulder with hers.

"What?..."

"I didn't watch them that long."

"Don't worry, you weren't on the stand or anything."

She chuckled. "I don't want it to come up later to discredit me and you get me disbarred."

"Facts are important," he said.

"Everything else was true," she said and kissed his arm. "And I do feel bad. I feel really bad." She smoothed her hair back from her face. Max ran his hand through his hair, too, and she could hear the sweat against his skin.

He said, "That was so bad..."

"I don't really think you think that."

"Oh, I don't have a single problem with it, believe me. I have a rap sheet just like yours."

"You're a peeper?"

He put a hand over his heart and raised the other hand like he was swearing to God. "Reformed," he said.

"High school peeper?"

"No. Not in high school."

She said, "I don't *really* think of myself as a peeper. I was just in the hall and I heard them. I don't know what made me want to take a look."

"Just curious."

She shrugged, feeling good that it didn't bother him. It would bother her.

He said, "But you saw him... *Finish?*..."

She nodded.

"But you didn't see..." He let it hang.

"It *happen* happen?... No. He was, you know, *inside* her. I didn't see his dick or anything, I swear, Max." She winced, then added: "I *did* see his balls."

Max groaned, and there was a look that passed over his face before he draped a sweaty forearm over it, a look that read as anger, but she could see it wasn't directed her way, it was directed inward.

"Max...?" she ventured, pursing her lips to a tight rictus and baring her teeth.

From under his arm he grunted.

"I think he had her in handcuffs..."

THERE WAS a time when this whole thing began that Maggie's inexperience made him feel superior. Times when he sat on the bed with her and she looked at him in awe when he suggested she explore her sexuality. She'd been a little flower that barely knew *real* nourishment; pale petals looking to unfurl, timid and afraid, raised in a disciplined hot-house that shielded her from real sunlight from a distant burning star, real soil with the earthworms and the slugs and the detestable; she was watered with the finest imported mineral water, no rain water, not even town tap water for her, nor the bugs it might bear. He'd been her master in a way, until that role was taken from him.

But Keely was a desert rose. One that thrived despite the complexities of life. Flourished, really, and craved the brutalities of the environment because she liked the emotion of being tested. There had been times early on with her where he felt like he'd been her 'Maggie'. But through the course of their time together, there was push and pull; times where he lead, times where she intimidated him. It was a dance, a delightful one, and he hoped the song wouldn't ever end.

Any time he could be the one out front sexually gave him power, but he didn't want their relationship one dictated by imbalances.

She'd been watching him, waiting, tangled fire-hair spilling over a creamy shoulder, face down, chin propped in hand. She raised an eyebrow. "Well?..."

He smiled. "Sometimes I don't want to be the one who leads."

"This means you don't want me in handcuffs?"

He shook his head no.

Her comical expression softened to serious. She said, "You can lead me. I want you to."

He turned on his side and caressed the low dip of her back. "What if I take us places you don't like?"

"I can always kick the door open, bust out and roll away. Long as you're not driving too fast. I'm not in your passenger seat all tied up am I?"

"I'm not into that. But I can get into it."

"Tying me up?"

"That's not my bag."

"It's Cole's bag?"

He nodded. There was a renewed stirring between his legs, hearing this girl being made to consider another man's sexual power. He watched his hand on that milky back a while, then asked: "You ever been tied up by a man?"

She put her eyes up, considering her level of honesty, and slowly nodded.

It gave him a shudder to think of it. A good one, one that provoked images of her being made to submit to another man, one whom she craved.

But now it was her in the lead. She said, "Did you ever... you know..."

"What?"

She gave a little sly grin, sucked her lower lip, said, "Bump uglies with Cole."

His eyes widened, and his mouth dropped. In a clumsy brogue, he said, "Go on, get out of here."

She showed him an unimpressed face, squiggling her eyebrows. "That's a terrible imitation of me."

He said, "I'll get the accent right sometime," and stroked her cheek.

"I won't hold my breath."

Now he patted her cheek, and she winced.

But she still held his gaze when he returned to his pillow. "Well did you?"

"I don't know what you mean 'bump uglies'."

"I think it's pretty clear..."

"I don't want to tell you."

She frowned. "You don't have to, but you're telling me by not telling me. I just wonder sometimes how it worked."

"It's not maybe how you're thinking. Not if you think he and I had sex."

She showed a wounded face, like she was upset she'd bothered him. But she persisted. "You crossed your swords?"

He nodded. "Yeah, we did."

She shrugged, bit her lower lip.

"What—is that bad?"

Now she smiled, then whispered, "I think it's kind of hot."

He gave her a stern expression, feeling suddenly and strangely objectified and unsure what that could mean.

Seeing his expression, she laughed, hid her face a moment, returned, said, "What?—don't be mad at me..."

He came near her, pressed his lips to her hot shoulder. "I'm not mad at you at all."

She lay her forearms on her pillow and rested her cheek on them, eyes winking in the low light under a framed fringe of her hair. "Did you ever kiss him?"

He scoffed. "Do you want me to go home?"

"Oh, you homophobe," she chastised him, rolling to her side so they faced and scooting closer.

He said, "I'm not."

She cupped a hand over his neck. "So you never did?"

"Kiss Cole? I don't think you know how it was."

With comical disdain, she sang, “I don’t know if I *want* to know how it was...”

He stayed serious. “You know what you need to know?”

“What’s that?”

“We all loved each other. I loved her, I loved him.”

“Okay. I’ll leave you alone.” Her voice had gone timid.

He gripped her wrist before she tried to retract the hand she held on him. She was wounded. He said, “It wasn’t about sex. I don’t want you to think that. But Cole and I?—we never kissed or anything, you know...”

She smiled now, and he was glad to see her rebound. “You don’t have to hide your shame from me, Max.” Her smile tugged hard to one side.

“I’m serious,” he said.

“What one man does in his bedroom...”

“You’re very funny.”

She held her tight little smile, eyes dancing over his.

He sighed, said, “You’re still thinking about that thing...”

She looked puzzled. “What thing?”

He waited a beat. “Swords crossing.”

She guffawed, her breath batting his eyelashes, and he loved the sound of her. She tossed her head away so she could laugh, her soft hair stroking his bare skin.

She returned to him, eyes smile-sparkling. “Sorry. I can’t shake the image.”

He stroked her cheek. “Well I’m glad you’re not disgusted.”

“Max, if I was disgusted by that relationship you had, I wouldn’t be lying here in the first place. You said it was about love and I never didn’t think it was. Sometimes I want to know what it was like and sometimes I don’t. It was your business. And you know—I’m so *sorry* I asked that about Cole. I swear. I should keep my bleedin’—”

He pressed her lips closed with a finger. Her cool, damp pillows mushed under his touch and he started to laugh at the blurting sound it had made when he silenced her.

She laughed too, batted his hand away and reared back. “Gross, Max. I know where that finger’s been.”

He held the finger up now, curled it repeatedly like an inch worm, said, “My finger thinks your story’s boring.”

“Well your finger should consider that I was being serious there, heartfelt even.” She gripped his finger in a quick-moving grip and bent it, making a mean face and getting him laughing and complaining.

For a second he worried he’d offended her and actually had made her mad, but soon it became obvious what she intended with her rough grip of his finger—pushing it low and turning to her back. She was funny and insatiable and if he ever lost this one he would never, ever recover.

“You might even want to use two,” she whispered to him, and he did, looking in her eyes and pleasuring her.

Now she asked: “Did you like me dirty talk?”

“I love it. You have a sick mind.”

She made a slight gasp as his fingers did something she particularly liked, then said, “These stories are true, Max, it’s not my mind that’s dirty, it’s *me-me-me*... Like, I ever tell you when I was in Riyadh and I had that rich boyfriend?”

“Tell me,” he said, withdrawing, using the pads of two fingers to chase down the hard nub of her clit amidst all those hot, wet folds.

“He was a prince, Max, a Saudi prince, and he kept me as his concubine...”

“Hold on,” he said, getting over top of her. She widened her knees for him, caressed his shoulders.

“It was all right, I only worked on the weekends, and he gave me money to go shopping all week and I’d blow wads at Gucci, you know...?”

“Uh-huh,” he said, sliding into her.

“Oh, ha, you’re still hard...”

“Oh, yeah...”

“On Friday nights he’d bring his friends home from the club and I’d have to fuck all of them.”

“All of them?” he gasped, humping himself into her.

“They’d inspect me first, assess me, put fingers in me fanny to see if I was worth their time, but you know, come on, right?—they *all* fucked me, Max...”

“No one’s going to turn you down.”

She ran circles on his back with her nails while he fucked her. “If there was a big group—and there was, almost every weekend—I had a small scale, and I’d take each of them, lift their dicks and put their balls on me scale...”

“Oh God,” he grunted, his stomach tightening at the lewd thought.

She was getting into it, too, her voice getting light and breathy. “Whoever had the heaviest bollocks got to go first because they obviously had the highest need...”

“Ah, that’s wild,” he grunted, amazed at her mind, her wetness, her perversion... “Were they Arabs, Sheikhs...?”

“A lot of them, but Americans, too...”

“Yeah?”

She gave one muffled laugh, short and sharp, that bounced her stomach into his with a sticky slap. “Celebrities, some of ‘em... I didn’t want to say it earlier, because it would be weird, and I didn’t want to ruin the moment...”

Her voice tightened like she tried to hold back a joke. He was one step ahead of her. “Oh no, Matt Damon?...”

She laughed so hard, she crushed his dick in her vagina’s grip, and he joined in, both of them clutched together, trying to restrain the laughs though it was flowing out of them. Just as they stilled, both of them flinching as tickles of pleasure worked over their wet sex parts with the movement of their good humor, she said, “You might not think it lookin’ at him, Max...”

“Uh-huh?” he panted, stomach fluttering with impending cachinnation.

“Really heavy balls.”

It got them both going again, and they clamped hands over each other’s mouths so they wouldn’t wake their hosts in the next bedroom. It only made it worse.

PART 3

Trio

MAY 7 - MAY 9

Downtown Marriott

FRIDAY, MAY 7

IT WAS DRIVING him crazy because while he was almost positive she'd done it to tease him, that dark part of him woke its ugly head to fantasize she'd done it for other reasons. He wished he'd recorded the exchange so he could play it back; study it, check it for veracity. Also to enjoy it.

Last night he'd Skyped the trio from his apartment making last-minute travel plan updates. Keely and Maggie were flying from Logan and he was leaving Laguardia but they would meet at Ford Airport in Michigan.

He'd been talking to Cole and Maggie, them sitting on the couch in the living room and using her MacBook on Cole's lap. Maggie's chin rested on Cole's shoulder and that was bad enough. Keely had been moving around in the background, then disappeared and jumped playfully into the picture, pressing her cheek up against Cole's and beaming at Max. She was spending the night there she told him, something she'd been doing frequently.

With her head turning side-to-side, checking out her face in the corner display showing what Max was seeing, she was asking what was wrong with her face. It was cracking her up, her saying she hopes she doesn't look like that and him saying it's the lens distortion. Cole steadied Keely's face with his thumb and finger holding the point of her chin, angling her so she displayed her best, saying not to move now. She tried to keep her face steady, but was distracted seeing her image in the bottom and broke up again. Cole pushed the laptop a little farther down his lap and then Max could see how close all three of them were. Maggie draped over one shoulder, Keely pressed up against him on the other side. Even Cole noticed

it and he said he looked like a movie villain. Maggie asked if he meant a pimp. And he winked for Max.

Keely caught it. “High end, I hope,” she had said, “I’ll have you know I’ve worked in the Middle East.”

Cole said, “A real live harem girl...” and Max watched his friend ogle Keely without her knowing, his eyes studying her perfect profile while she still jabbered with her boyfriend two hundred miles away—sometimes feeling so close and other times, like last night, painfully, horrifyingly far.

Keely might have been aware she was being watched, or studied, more accurately—and maybe liked it, he worried—because this was where she did the thing he couldn’t stop thinking about: Keely’s expression settled into confidence, and she steadied her eyes on his through their monitors; her cheek pressed Cole’s again and now her pale hand came to rest on his chest. The fingers of that hand dented the cotton of Cole’s shirt, then curled as if caressing him. It was astoundingly intimate. As much as it startled him, made him hyper-aware of a stark jealousy within him, it also was so familiar he worried Maggie would see and be angry. Keely had, after all, slept with Cole back at Farm. Maggie had told him she just didn’t think of it, but if she saw a reminder in front of her...? His skin had prickled with electric fear, thinking Maggie’s eyes would drift down and catch that overt action and suffer a jealous rage.

But that was it. That was all it was. Cheek to cheek and hand on chest. Overnight, however, it went through his system like a delicious poison. He got almost no sleep and work had been shit today because of it. Around four this morning he’d suffered under frightful phantasmagoric images in a storytelling montage. Snapshots of horrific revelations: opening the door of the house on Hilliard to surprise them all on a Saturday night after telling them he wouldn’t be coming to Cambridge—finding them intertwined on the couch in naked tangles of erotic flesh. Or the discovery that Cole was cheating on Maggie, sneaking into the guest bedroom on nights when Keely was sleeping over. Both of them turned on and supercharged—knowing it was sex for sex’s sake, good sex, too, both of them taking the risk for some powerful lust connection. Crazy thoughts. Some crazier than that; some outright ludicrous.

It looked like the torture was back in full force. It had been forgotten for a while, or at least subdued while he engaged in a longtime threesome.

These days he had something shiny and new and redheaded to cherish and worry over.

Now he was grumpy and home in Grand Rapids, head hazy, exhausted, weaving through the disembarking crowd bypassing baggage because all he had was his carry-on, coming out of Delta and into the concourse. Maggie and Keely should arrive in about half an hour and he got his phone out of his jacket pocket to check for messages. Above the crowd ahead of him, someone held a single sheet of paper like a driver looking for a passenger. In his periphery, something about it drew his attention, and he darted his eyes back to read it. It was the name scrawled on the paper that had attracted him: MILTON, with a happy face in place of the O.

At once his mood lifted, and he felt his face ease its tense hold on his expression. He made his way in the direction of the name card, recognizing now the pale hand that held it up. The same one that had been on Cole's chest.

When he came around an embracing family of four, he met her eyes—or at least thought he did. Keely wore black and gold aviator sunglasses and pretended to look past him, only she wasn't able to keep her face straight for more than a moment. She burst out laughing and thrust her arms out to receive him, doing a brief running-in-place dance that got his own feet moving quicker.

They came together hard, and it was so good to have her in his arms right now—and it must have been mutual because she wrenched his neck hugging him too hard. It had been two weeks since they'd been together and physical absences from this girl were becoming almost unbearable. What began as fun and intriguing was becoming profound. It wasn't too long ago where his subconscious considered her like a crutch; someone who would help him learn to walk again after Maggie hobbled him.

Speak of the devil, she was there, joining them, standing behind Keely and reaching around to snag the hastily written sign out of her hand. "Wrong Milton, Keely, you should take your sunglasses off," she said and flapped the sheet over Keely's head, "I told you we were looking for a redhead."

Playful Maggie was like a ray of sunshine. A glimpse of the carefree artist he fell in love with bursting through the diligent woman she'd become. He said, "Connor, you mean?"

Maggie said, “The handsome Milton. She’s excited to meet a redheaded one,” and leaned in close so he could kiss her cheek and give her arm a squeeze. There was a lot more he ached to do but knew it was inappropriate and he was pinched by the fear his affection might be unwanted and that she would tell him so right in front of Keely. “You might be waiting a while, Connor comes in tomorrow morning. You guys bring pillows?”

Keely sighed, “Aw, you’re the right Milton,” and kissed his neck.

“I missed you so much,” he said, hoping Maggie would be hurt by it.

“We got a whole weekend together, Maxy,” she said, but he could hear the anxiousness in her voice, as much as she thought she might be good at hiding it. Meeting his family was a big step.

“I’ve been looking forward to it all week,” he said.

Keely took her sunglasses off, tucked them in the breast pocket of her jacket without stopping her hug. She said, “What do you want to do now?”

“Get the hell out of the airport,” he said.

“Tonight,” she said, and kissed his lips finally. He let it last because he knew he was being watched. She breathed him in and touched his chest, her fingers moving much like she’d done over his friend’s. “What do you want to do tonight?”

Maggie said, “You look exhausted, Max. Did you ride your bike here or something?”

“I am exhausted,” he said. “Room service and a movie? We’ve got brunch at my folks tomorrow morning at eleven.”

“That sounds perfect,” Keely said. Her hands had worked under his jacket and the feeling of them as they explored his waist intimately, hidden from Maggie’s eyes, got him surprisingly aroused for such a busy spot to be standing, especially after the week he’d had.

“Shit, I gotta get the rental,” he said now, squeezing his temple.

Keely said, “Maggie got it. We’re all done.”

“When did your plane get in?”

“Almost forty minutes ago, I think.”

“You guys had time to do the car and make me a sweet sign with my name on it?”

“Girls don’t fuck around, Max,” she said, then nuzzled her chin against his chest.

THEY'D BOOKED a suite at the downtown Marriot because the weekend visit to his parents had become a *thing*. Turns out his siblings *all* had the weekend free, and once his sister heard he was coming, then the other brothers were called and it became a weekend event; everyone coming home to see Mom and Dad before their summers got too busy. Now he had to book a hotel room because his sister, Franny, said they shouldn't overwhelm Mom. Mike was coming with his wife, Connor with his girlfriend, Franny and her hubby Dave, plus his niece and nephew.

Franny and her family came on Thursday and stayed—they were doing the cooking and cleaning and prep for all the visitors. Mike and Connor and their ladies were also staying at the Marriot, only about twenty minutes from the Milton Compound in Forest Hills. Franny said having everybody stay in the house would be too much for Mom. Max said that that's what Mom would want. Franny said Mom doesn't always want what's best for her, we're not going to exhaust her.

They drove the rental from the airport into downtown Grand Rapids, Max behind the wheel. Keely sat up front and it was an amazing feeling to have someone so happy to have you. It was something missing, and while he'd been in the relationship with Maggie and Cole for years, and it always felt loving, the excitement of having someone so happy to have your presence was striking. Not that Maggie didn't want him around, she was always excited to see him, but the newness of this thing he had going with Keely reminded him what it was like to be in love again. It was an awesome feeling.

All three of them would be staying in the same suite. He and Keely would take the main bedroom. Across the living area there was a guest room with a queen-size bed for Maggie. Maggie had said at first they should get separate rooms but he felt it was weird to have her alone in a room somewhere else in the hotel and asked Keely what she'd think if he got a suite. Keely said it would be more fun if the three of them were all together.

They checked in near midnight. The hotel restaurant was closed, but the concierge told them room service was twenty-four-hour. In the elevator on the way up to the suite, Maggie was begging off saying, "I'm not really even hungry, you guys can eat something, I might just go to bed, I've got a lot of studying to do..."

Keely said, "I thought we were going to get room service and watch a movie..."

Maggie said, "I don't want to intrude. Don't you guys want some alone time?"

Keely patted his chest, said to Maggie, "We'll get our alone time after the movie."

Maggie shrugged, said "Okay," but she couldn't hide unhappiness from her expression. There was something interesting about seeing her feeling excluded.

Coming in from the hallway, the suite showed them a view out over downtown Grand Rapids looking to the east. There were balloon shaped paper lanterns, about a half dozen of them, that hung over couches arranged in front of the floor-to-ceiling windows. On the left-hand side was the main bedroom with its king-size bed. Maggie walked to the other side, the guest room, to unpack her things. They arranged to meet in the common room in ten minutes to order a cocktail and some nachos and they'd watch a movie.

Closed together in the main bedroom, he was on Keely in an instant, taking her and kissing her passionately, holding her neck while they did. She fell against the door, breathing him in and rubbing his back.

He said, "I really have missed you so fucking bad."

"I know," she gasped, "I missed you, too."

"I liked my sign," he said, nibbling under her ear.

"We were early..."

His hands moved to drag her luggage strap off her shoulder, his other hand slipping under her jacket and trying to push it off as well. She laughed in his mouth saying, "Oh, we're going to do this now?"

"You're driving me crazy," he whispered.

"Do tell."

"I can't stand being so far apart from you."

"Want me to drop out of school?"

"Would you?"

Her fingers scratched at his scalp. "You'd love it if I was a delinquent, wouldn't you? You like a bad girl..."

"You know me so well." He locked eyes with her, held her in a confident embrace and she let her body slump into his grasp. She ran the inside of a thigh up his hip, stroked the heel of one shoe against the back of his knee.

He braced his hands underneath her thighs, she jumped up, locked her ankles behind him. With her arms cinched tight around his neck and their mouths connected, he turned, walked her to the bed and they collapsed on it together. He was fully hard by this time, and he got over top of her and let her know by pressing it between her legs.

She humped against it, said, “We really *are* going to do this right now, aren’t we?...”

“I can’t wait until later.”

“That’s good to hear, Maxy,” she whispered against his neck.

“You know how crazy you make me?”

“Tell me.”

“Are you doing it on purpose?”

“Driving you crazy? Am I just *so* sexy?”

“Do you know what I’m talking about?”

She shook her head no, but watched his eyes eagerly, desperate to hear what it was he might say. Seeing that distinct passion in her face, knowing it was directed his way, surged his heart in his chest. He caressed her shoulders, began unbuttoning her shirt. Now she watched his hands work and made no effort to stop him. She wanted it and there was something so wonderful about that. Halfway down the trail of buttons, he said, “Did you do something on purpose?...”

He was honestly afraid to ask, worried that it wasn’t on purpose, that it was a natural thing she’d done. Also worried whatever she told him he might not believe. If she said “Yes, it was to tease you,” that wouldn’t appease him. It would work in the back of his mind that was what she said because she’d been caught putting her hands on Cole the way she truly wanted.

She half-smiled, said, “No. Maybe. What is it...?”

“Last night when we were Skyping...”

Her smile tugged higher into her cheek, and then she couldn’t maintain the smirk any longer and her pretty lips burst into a full smile. She made a light giggling sound and closed her eyes, turned her chin up. He kissed her neck.

He said, “Why would you do that to me?”

She shrugged, her sparkling emeralds watching him.

He asked again: “Did you do it on purpose?”

“Maybe.”

Now he steadied his gaze on her, put his hands out over her shoulders and hovered over her on the mattress with her shirt half open. “Tell me what it is I’m talking about.”

She licked her lips, and her eyes darted over his. For a moment he feared she had just been playing along and actually had no idea what he was talking about. She said at last, “Was I getting maybe a little *too* friendly...?”

“Maybe you were. It certainly seems like it...”

“I hope it doesn’t bother you,” she said, giving him her coy face, with her pretty eyes petulant but blinking bashfully; a shocking visage that wound up something deep and dark in his psyche.

He said, “Tell me what it is we’re talking about...”

Now she got embarrassed, and her cheeks blossomed red right before his eyes. Her hands came up and covered her face but she was smiling the whole time. She said through her hands, “Did I look too friendly with Cole?”

“How would you know that would drive me so crazy?”

“I didn’t. I thought it would...”

“I couldn’t even sleep last night.”

“I couldn’t either. But it’s just because I’m so nervous...”

“You’re going to do fine. I told you a million times my parents are going to love you.” He wiggled his hips, pushed the belly of his hardness over the crotch of her jeans.

When her hands came away from her face, the humor was gone, and she looked at him more earnestly. She said, “You’re not mad at me or anything, are you?”

“Why, were you bad? Did you do something wrong?”

“No, seriously, I hope I didn’t make you mad...”

“I love that you would even think to do that,” he whispered in her neck, his hands worked between them, finishing her buttons.

Now her hands were off her face and tugging at his shirt, untucking it, pulling on his sweater. She said, “Can we get this quickie moving along, please?”

He laughed. “Am I moving too slow...?”

“You do like to take your time, don’t you? If you want to do this now, we have to be fast...”

He got to his knees over her, taking his shirt and sweater off, watching her between his thighs, unbuttoning her jeans and pulling down the zipper.

“You want it fast?”

“Fast and hard, Mr. Milton, it’s a race to the finish line,” and with that his freaky ginger minx flopped over onto her front and peeled her jeans and panties down, the fabric scrolling over her soft pale and perfect ass, slowly revealing it to him. She watched him over her shoulder, her mane of fiery hair framing her beautiful face, her eyes wide and innocent but also hungry for sex.

“God,” he laughed, “you’re so fucking beautiful.”

“Quickies are supposed to be fast, Max, come on now, you’ve got me going...”

Her fucking accent, her kooky, quirky aloofness even at a time of passion always drove him mad; there was something so amazing about her and these days it felt like he was peeking around the corner and getting a glimpse of what it was. There was much inside him that he kept hidden, much he was afraid to show another girl, but the last four weeks there was something between them like a comprehension, like Keely was *getting* him and not being turned off by his darkest thoughts. But he swore he’d keep it playful; swore he would protect her from his desires because he knew they were boundless and hard to control once they got some steam behind them.

His cock was unzipped, already leaking, running her ass crack, then sliding up inside her from behind in less than a second.

“Ah, ha, ah,” she laughed as he entered her, a sound of relief and desire and happiness. Her feet kicked at the backs of his legs. While he fucked her, he ran the hair away from her face and kissed her cheek.

“Oh God, that’s good, Max, oh yeah,” she grunted as his weight bucked on top of her back. “Mm, hurry, quick, before Maggie catches us...”

“Oh fuck,” he grunted, the scenario she was painting with dirty talk, he was sure done on purpose, and the fact she had that kind of mind thrilling him endlessly.

They were in the same pose again, doing it the way Keely had secretly spied Maggie and Cole doing it, and now he wondered if she’d rolled over under him and presented her bottom that way because she still fantasized about what she saw that night. It made him think how she noted the sounds Maggie had made, noted too that Cole’s size must have been pleasurable for her. He wanted to urge more from her, but was afraid to start something he couldn’t stop. “Think she’s a dirty peeper like you?”

It made her laugh, and he kissed her shoulder. She still wore her shirt though it was unbuttoned, and they'd only pulled down her pants; he was fully dressed, his dick sticking out of his fly. She said, "Let her peep if she wants..."

"You're not shy...?"

"Fair's fair, Max, I peeped on her..."

The impulse was too strong to fight and he couldn't help saying, "And Cole, too." His voice was pinched, his neck tight, part of his autonomous system wanting to withhold some of his secrets because it knew they were so dangerous.

But Keely didn't flinch. "No offense, Max, but that's who *I'd* be peeping on..."

An orgasm flashed on his dashboard like a warning light and his stomach muscles bounced and jumped as he fucked her harder. "You're so fucking bad..."

"Mm-Maggie's, ah, pretty and all, but I like boys, Maxy, and our friend Cole..."

"Fuck, Jesus," he grunted in chokes, "Say it, go, say it..."

"He's so hot, Max, I'd peep on him if I thought there's a, ah, chance I'd see him naked..."

"You're *evil*..."

"See that body, see that big hard dick..."

"Fuck," he grunted, withdrawing from her, Keely turning to see what went wrong. But he straddled one leg now, pulled up on the other. He plucked her shoe off her foot and tossed it away. When he began to tug on her sock, she laughed and tossed her head away, pointing her foot so he could remove it easily. Then he was folding her calf over her thigh, her bare foot close to her bare ass, and he was jerking his cock that was so close to exploding, tucking his other hand between her legs and slipping fingers inside her. Keely wiggled her toes in anticipation, arched her foot. She had such a pretty foot, too, as pretty as Maggie's at least, alabaster, with well-formed little toes that wore no polish but were pedicured. He pressed the wet tip of his penis between her big toe and her second, face scowling, jerks coming short and hard.

"Yes, yes, yes," Keely whispered, wiggling her toes again and tickling the head of his penis. He ejaculated against her toes, missing with one stream that tapped her ass, then got himself angled right and Keely

alternately stretched her foot out and scrunched it tight as he sent all his testicular contents onto her waiting foot sole. She mewled and laughed, tossed her hair again. Her pussy went slick against his touch but he wasn't sure she came—he was sure she liked it, though.

He stroked still, shaking from his tip the last few drops, getting it along the seam below her toes, then running his penis over her foot and drawing circles on her heel. Her shoulders shook with laughter and she rolled to see him. Her eyes were glassy and wet, her cheeks blushed and happy. He collapsed next to her on his back and she put a hand on his chest.

She said, “God, Max, I never knew you were so co-ordinated.”

“You're impressed?”

“Did you practice that?”

Now he was laughing. “No...”

“Very complicated maneuver, Mr. Milton. The one hand on your dick like that, the other where I like it, and you kept my foot in place, too...?”

“Am I the best at that?”

“No one's even close, Max, you're miles ahead of all the men who've come on my feet.”

“You said there was only one.”

“I say lots of things, Max, to keep myself out of trouble.”

He stared at her gleeful eyes shaded under a scrolling lock of hair that swooped over her temple, trying to discern if she was joking or not, knew she was but enjoyed the worry of possibilities.

Her eyes narrowed by a hidden smile. “Towel, please,” she whispered and her toes wiggled.

He zipped himself up, went to the en suite washroom and snagged a towel from the rack. When he returned, he took up the chore of cleaning, enfolding her tootsie in the clean towel.

Keely said, “Maggie seem alright to you?”

Foot scrubbed and dried, he used the tail end of the towel to do her bottom. He dropped down next to her on the bed again, saying, “Yeah. Why?”

Keely scrunched her face, then put her hands down and pulled up her panties. She snapped them in place, rolled to her back and pried off her other shoe and slid off her jeans. Now she just wore the open shirt and panties and one sock. While he watched her, he marveled at how his deepest black didn't seem to bother her, and she was on to new subjects after sex

was over, compartmentalizing their mutual badness, keeping it safe and separate, and thank God, not treating it like a big deal.

“She’s been kind of grumpy,” she said when he didn’t answer, looking up at the ceiling.

He said, “Why would she be grumpy?”

Keely said, “I don’t know. She’s been fine all week but since we got off the plane, it seems like she’s in a bad mood.”

Max’s head still thundered from the orgasm but he rubbed his cheeks now and blinked, trying to focus his thoughts. He said, “Maybe it’s because all my brothers are coming and my sister, too.”

“She just wanted to go alone...”

“Now it’s become a party.”

Keely sighed, her back rising and falling peacefully. She said, “That seems nice though.”

He grunted. It was nice, and he was looking forward to this impromptu family reunion. “Maggie likes, no, sorry, *loves* my parents, but she’s not as keen on my siblings.”

“Why?”

“They’re not mean to her, they’re not... They’re nothing, it’s just she thinks...”

The TV flicked on in the main room and they both looked at the door to their suite to make sure it was closed.

Keely said, “We should get out there.”

He sidled up to her and held her in one arm, pressing his body against hers and inhaling her deeply. He kissed her mouth again, kissed it while it was smiling. He said, “You’re not tired?”

“One movie,” she said, “then you’re going to show me more than a quickie.”

Rockwell Court

SATURDAY, MAY 8

NONE of them made it through the whole movie. They'd tried to watch Jaws 2 because Max said everyone needed to have a healthy fear of sharks. She'd never seen any of the Jaws movies. It was a little frightful but Maggie said they should have watched the first one instead. Max said you didn't need context in a shark movie, you just needed sharks, and Maggie said the first one was better, Steven Spielberg directed it. Room service brought them cocktails and nachos, none of which got finished. They all fell asleep on the couch, Maggie stretched out on the floor with pillows and a blanket and her dog-eared copy of the coincidentally titled: Swimming Lessons For Baby Sharks. Sometime around three they all retired to proper beds.

After they'd woken, Max went down to the concourse and returned with continental breakfast for the three of them and coffees from the Starbucks in the lobby. He was their hero, and they told him. They would've ordered room service, but they wanted to be hungry for the brunch.

Max served the coffee and pastries at the common room dining table looking out over the city of Grand Rapids. She'd never been to the middle of America, and looking out over top of the small city reminded her of an American sitcom she would watch the year she was in France. For a few months she'd become obsessed with '8 Simple Rules' which reran like crazy when she was there. It was a good sort of feeling looking out now over the sunny morning-time city, it was a cheery kind of place. The show took place in Detroit, which was in Michigan, but Max said Grand Rapids was nothing like Detroit and you wouldn't want to go to Detroit now anyway, it wasn't like it was on the show twenty years ago.

After she'd showered she checked with Maggie about a dozen times over what she wore. In the days before they came up here, she went over it with Maggie, and Cole showed her the L.L. Bean website and said dress like that. She trusted their advice, put on a collared shirt and wool sweater, skirt and leggings, all in black except for the shirt which was plaid.

There was tension in the concourse heading to get their car when Max was texting his brother Mike who was staying in the hotel as well. She got anxious that she would meet him out of the blue and ill-prepared, but Max said he'd already left and was at the family house now.

They headed northeast out of the city to the suburb where Max grew up. It was a peaceful, family kind of place and so different from how she knew her dark Manhattan boyfriend. And yet it made sense, too. The quiet streets, the swaths of mown lawns, basketball nets and nice houses; estates that were cared for with towering trees taking their leaves, some of them yellowy and still furled. Kids rode bikes, skateboards, and hung in groups; and you knew while they all looked happy and wholesome on the outside there was still a seedy underbelly even in this pastiche of upper-middle-class Americana; those kids would have phones overflowing with disgusting porn, they would be drinking on the weekends or at the homes of friends whose parents weren't mindful, they all probably smoked weed, some of them even had tried opioids. And one little bugger in this sweet painting of niceness was guaranteed to be murdering neighborhood cats, probably recording it on his phone and uploading it to the darknet. It was the law of statistics, and you could dress reality up as snazzy as you wanted, it was still reality. This was where her Max had grown up and it made absolute sense; truthfully, she thought it was pretty wonderful, and she loved that this had been his home.

"Did you used to play baseball there?" she asked him when she saw a grassy diamond behind chain-link, but he said no. When they came near a sprawling brick building with a steel roof and cantilevered awning over the entrance Max pointed a finger from the steering wheel and said that's where he went to high school. Maggie sat in the back, saying out the name of the high school, Northern Central, before she could read the sign, showing off how well she knew him.

Then the roadside became framed by woods instead of expansive lawns; they turned onto Rockwell Court and the homes were grander still, set back from the road and protected by copses of trees. Maggie undid her seatbelt

and scooted up to sit with her face framed between the front seats. Keely ventured a look her way, could see her friend with a truly happy expression; her golden eyes gleamed, her smile was honest and dozy.

“Up ahead,” she said to Keely.

“I can picture you growing up here,” she said to Max.

Maggie squeezed his shoulder.

Keely said, “Did you play hockey on the street?”

“In the summer, yeah. The winter we had a rink at the public park.”

“It’s just like you see on TV,” she laughed. It *was* very American; the house where Maggie pointed now flew the Stars and Stripes from a tall white pole set in the lawn. Max’s home looked like a Euro estate house; ground level in stone, upper levels in stucco and wood frame, Tudor Revival, with peaked slate roofs, and mullioned windows. The driveway was long, but four cars bunched up near the white-painted garages that looked like barn doors. As they pulled in behind the others, Maggie began to work on straightening her clothes and it came with a nervous energy that transferred to her, and she was flipping down the visor mirror and preening before she even realized she’d done it.

Out of the car and unsure of what to do, it was Maggie who saved her. She came to stand next to her and did an unexpected thing: presented her with the boxed cake they’d picked up at the bakery, hooked an arm around Keely’s and snugged her close together. Max adjusted his jacket, standing by the open driver’s side door and watching them wistfully. It made her profoundly aware that they were his two girls. That in the last six or seven years of her Max’s life he had only cared for the two of them. The look on his face, that certain satisfaction, or halcyon happiness, should have been heartwarming, but it reminded her how much her man loved the nice rich pretty girl who’d just put her arm through hers; it made Maggie’s magnanimous act seem suddenly malevolent.

Now that Irish redness was washing up from her feet and she pushed it down with great might. Still, as they walked the brick pathway to the Milton’s front door, she could feel a blaze warming up her cheeks.

MAGGIE'S SUPPORT of his Keely affected him. Keely was nervous, filled with a healthy anxiousness over meeting his parents. Maggie had done what *he* wanted to do. But if he hooked his arm through Keely's to introduce her there was the fear he would look too doting and that would make Keely look weak or fragile to his family; like she was his little possession. Keely was no possession. But her good friend and Milton family confidante hooking her arm through hers and walking her, ready to present this beautiful, smart and funny redhead...? It was perfect. Maggie was beloved, and if she presented Keely in this manner, it was a stamp of approval that wouldn't go unnoticed by his mother for sure, heck, maybe even his pop.

And it was Dad who answered the door, looking good in a sweater and slacks; Pop swung the door wide like he'd been waiting for them. The sounds of the Milton family banged from the inside: Connor's laugh, Mikey yelling something, his sister's nagging but wonderful voice calling after one of her kids or something. It washed over him like a blast from the past, put a smile on his face and tears in his eyes.

Dad was unreserved meeting his little gal pal, shouting out, "Scarecrow!" and throwing out his arms for her. The reaction was immediate: Maggie dropping Keely's arm and burrowing into his dad's chest for a hug.

Max moved behind Keely and braced her shoulders, brushed his cheek against her hair while Maggie soaked up the affection.

Still holding Maggie, his dad said, "Hey kiddo, who's this you brought?" He smiled, looked warmly at Keely.

Max said, "This is my friend, Keely, the one I told you about."

One arm around Maggie, his dad extended a hand, said, "Glad to meet you, Keely."

Keely moved stiffly, cake box in one hand, putting out the other and shaking his father's, saying, "Nice to meet you, too, Mr. Milton." It was amusing to hear her so timid; he rubbed her shoulders.

His dad smiled, amused by Keely's stiff formality. He said, "We hug around here. Max says you're from Ireland, they okay with hugging there?"

"They hug there," Keely laughed.

As his dad approached, he stopped, eyed the box. "Wait. Cake? Oh, you don't even..." He took the box from Keely, peeked in the top window and looked back to wink at Maggie. "Somebody knows my weakness," he said, and passed the box to her.

Now he turned and looked to Keely, holding his arms out for a hug, saying, “Thank you, but don’t tell June, I want that all for myself and she won’t likely let me...”

Keely looked bewildered but smiling, and she let his dad hug her, putting her arms around him as well.

Maggie said, “Keely’s my best friend from school.” She wiped an index finger under her eye.

“So Max tells me. Shoot, *two* smart girls... You want to eat around here you gotta pay your way...” His dad turned them around and led them up the short step into the house. “I got a list of people in this neighborhood I want to sue, so get out your pens, we’ve got a couple hours of paperwork before brunch, and I only want to hear your best ideas...” His dad closed the door behind them, leaving Max on the stoop.

Max laughed and looked at the familiar closed door, could hear Keely laugh brightly now on the other side. A crack formed in the wall of tension that had slowly grown around this weekend visit and he thought everyone might make it all right.

When he went to the door, he found it locked. Through the hazy glass inset, he could see his dad introducing Keely to Mike, Maggie still held in one arm.

He knocked on the door and when Mikey looked over, his dad held Mike’s arm saying, “Pretend we’re not home, I think it’s a Jehovah’s Witness.”

MAX’S DAD certainly liked Maggie; he couldn’t let go of her. She had a cool nickname and everything: Scarecrow.

In the front hall she met Max’s brother, Mike, a dark-haired, handsome guy a few years older than Max. He had his wife with him, a pretty, brown-haired girl named Tabitha. Not Tabby, but Tabitha. And she got the impression Tabitha wasn’t big on boisterous fun or on people calling her Tabby.

There was shouting then from the living room, and someone clapping their hands. A young woman with strawberry-blonde hair was after a dog who’d put up its forefeet onto a buffet table loaded with fruit and coffee and

cheeses and meats. Her clapping went low, the young woman stooped over, hands coming together near the dog's bottom. The dog whisked around, was shooed, then scarpered. The woman squeezed her forehead and said, "Why did he even get a dog?"

Maggie was next to her now, saying, "That's Max's sister, Fran, or Franny. She has two kids—"

"I know," she said. "His niece and nephew, Alan and Grace."

Max's dad had let go of Maggie to let Max in the house, chastising him for ringing the doorbell, saying "My house is your house, you don't need to ring the bell... Come on in, be my guest, take off your shoes..."

There was a man standing by the dining room table with a baby in his arms. Dark-skinned guy with black hair wearing a sweater vest. It had to be Franny's husband, Ronaldo, who'd immigrated from Portugal. Franny met him after university when she took a banking job in Spain. Running around Franny's feet was a three-year-old, and now Franny was trying to keep the dog away from the toddler's face.

Maggie said, "Come on down, let's go meet Max's mother."

The house smelled like meat and potatoes; whatever Franny was preparing for brunch was cooking in the kitchen and it smelled delicious. There were coasters out, and napkins with plates on the casual tables, bits of cheese and crackers and fruit on them. On the couch was a redheaded young man she knew from pictures was Max's brother Connor. He was sitting with a pretty black girl dressed right out of that L.L. Bean website. Looks like Cole had tipped her off as well.

Maggie gripped her hand now, and she could feel it was clammy. She stopped at the couch, saying, "Hi Connor. Nice to see you again."

Connor had a wine goblet with orange juice, and Keely knew there would also be added champagne. He held it up as if saluting, saying simply, "Maggie."

Maggie said, "This is Max's friend, Keely."

Now Connor was smiling, saying, "I forgot you were coming, that's right," and he stood up while setting his mimosa on the coffee table. He shook her hand, introduced his girlfriend as Abigail, then Max was there kissing Abigail's cheek and hugging his brother.

Maggie was tugging on her sweater sleeve while she hung off Max, listening to Connor. She said, "I want you to meet Max's mother..."

She nodded, pulled on Max's sweater just like Maggie had done to her, but Max was talking, half-turning to her and nodding. She went with Maggie.

At the end of the living room, sitting by the fireplace was the woman she assumed was Max's mother. She wore a black sweater and a turtleneck with a shawl around her shoulders and a woolen blanket on her lap. She had gold chunky earrings but wore a headscarf. Maggie squeezed Keely's hand and folded their arms together again, their intertwined fists up at their shoulders. With excitement constricting her voice, Maggie said in a whisper to Keely, "Oh wow, she looks so good."

The woman saw them coming, smiling warmly then holding out her hands. She said, "There's my angel, come here and let me hold you."

Maggie stayed hooked to Keely until they were a foot from Max's mother's chair, then Maggie went on her knees at the woman's feet, leaned on the arm and hugged her. The woman stooped over to hug her in return. Maggie said, "I can't believe how good you look."

The woman said, "I feel good, too."

Keely watched Maggie's hand as it squeezed Max's mother's upper arm, watched her stroke her thumb against the shawl.

At last, she stood up on her knees, gestured her hand out toward Keely and said, "June, this is my best friend. This is Keely." She wiped at her cheeks clumsily and strangely childlike.

Now she was frozen, not knowing what to do. Feeling like the appropriate response must be to also fall to her knees before this exalted figure. So she did, practically curtsying before her and taking her hand to shake it.

The woman rested her hand on Keely's back and pulled her in for a weak embrace. She said, "Max has told me so much about you."

"Thank you," she said. "And you, too."

Maggie was holding the woman's hand. She looked around at the kerfuffle, said, "Boy, I come for a visit and look what happens..."

Max's mother said, "Can you believe it?"

"You must be so happy."

"I am. You girls get some chairs," she said now, motioning around her that there was room for them to slide chairs and sit next to her.

Maggie hopped up, gripped Keely's forearm saying, "You stay. I'll get us some chairs."

She watched her scamper off and stop to say hello to the man holding the baby. It was Maggie out of her element, and it was very strange to see. But it all made sense; she had known them a long time, had almost married their son, and stayed on good terms. And when she was here, she was obviously welcomed. It made her think of the man she'd met who was Maggie's father at High Table at the beginning of the school year. And the rumors she'd heard about Maggie's mother. Max's parents had become surrogate emotional partners. A kind of familial relationship. Her hands worked nervously together, she got down on her knees again next to Max's mother. She didn't know what to say, looked around the room nervously. Max was talking to Connor still, but he caught her eye, saw that she was alone with his mother and excused himself. She said, "Here comes Max."

June said, "You're at school with Maggie..."

"I am. Not law school. Not yet. I start next year..."

Then Max was there, coming to bend over and hug his mother. She smoothed her hands up and down his back and groaned in his hug. She said, "Look at my baby, look how much you've grown." Keely smirked and pinched Max's calf.

He said, "Yes, mom. I'm still growing."

She said, "I like your hair," and she ruffled it, then squeezed his cheeks and put her thumbs into them.

Now Keely stroked Max's calf with sincere affection. Maggie returned, the crest rails of dining room chairs in each hand, dragging them behind her. Connor jumped up to help her, taking one of the chairs and bringing it over. He held it for Keely and patted the seat. He said, "You take this one, it was mine. It's the special redhead chair."

She twisted fingers through her own locks, saying, "Oh, you noticed?"

Connor said, "We stand out."

"We do," she said. She took the chair, scooted it to sit next to June. Maggie took the other side. Max asked if he could get them drinks. She said a glass of wine, Maggie said tea, Maggie's mother also said wine, and patted Keely's knee. Franny was there then, chasing after the dog again.

Max almost tripped over it, saying, "Whose is this fucking dog?"

June tutted, said, "Maxy, watch your language."

Franny said to Max, "Can you believe this? A dog..."

June patted her knees, said, "Bubbles, come here."

The dog, which looked like a springer spaniel with spotted ankles and long cinnamon and buff fur, came and jumped into her lap putting front feet up only. June ruffled his cheeks much like she'd done to Max.

Franny said, "She shouldn't even have a dog..."

June said, "Your father wanted one."

Franny said, "It's not hygienic. We're supposed to be careful with the ___"

"Give over, Franny," June said, ruffling the dog's head and sending it away with a spank on its bottom. The dog headed to the kitchen.

Max said, "You met Keely?"

"I did," June said, reached down and held Keely's hand. "We just started talking."

Max put his hands up in surrender said, "*Excuse* me. I'm off to get drinks, anyway."

Maggie watched June's face from the side, looked sad for a long moment before saying, "I'm going to go make tea," stood up biting her lip then turning and following Max to the kitchen.

June turned to her now and said, "I love your accent."

Keely could feel herself blushing again and said, "Does it give me away?"

June laughed, said, "It's a dead giveaway. You know Max's father's family is from Ireland. Mine, too, not my mother, but my mother's mother." Her head leaned back as if trying to recall something then she called out for her husband: "Keith, Keith..." Max's father excused himself, stepped closer.

June said, "Where was my mother's mother from?"

"Mars," he said.

"Very funny," she said. "No, really."

"Ireland."

She rolled her eyes and let her head fall back to bounce against the top of the chair's cushion. "Not Ireland. *Where* in Ireland?" There was a certain comical venom in her tone.

He said, "It's not a big country."

Keely laughed, said, "No, it's not."

June said, "What was the name of the town, though?"

Keith gave her a funny look, and it made Keely think that the name of the town was something that June should have remembered and it troubled Max's father that she had forgotten. "Galway," he said.

“Galway,” June said and squeezed Keely’s hand. “Do you know it?”

Maggie returned, scooping her skirt under her thighs to sit next to June again saying, “I put the kettle on.” No one noticed.

Keely said, “Well guess what?”

June said, “What?”

“It’s a very small world because that’s about a thirty minute drive from where I’m from.”

June lit up, saying, “Do you know any Connors?”

Keely said, “Connors? I know lots of Connors, the areas rich wi’ ‘em.”

“That’s my maiden name,” June said.

Maggie smiled, stood up and returned to the kitchen.

American Dream

SATURDAY, MAY 8

IT WAS near time to eat, so Franny sent her to retrieve Max.

He wasn't in the living room with his brothers, but she went upstairs because Mike pointed her that way.

She climbed the steps to the second floor, stood in the hallway not knowing where to go. She called out Max's name. There was no answer for a long moment, and she inhaled to call his name once more when she heard a muffled *In here*.

There was a bedroom door open two down from the top of the steps and she went there and poked her head around the corner. Max and Maggie were sitting on a bed very close together, their legs touching. Max was wiping his cheeks which had gone red and his eyes were swollen and wet. Maggie looked sheepishly over her shoulder.

She said, "Everything okay?" Her stomach hardened.

Max nodded, patted the bed next to him on the other side. Keely looked around the room, saw his things, his boy room with his boy things, baseball stuff, a snowboard, a skateboard... She strolled alongside the bed, saying, "Your parents kept it the way it was..."

"For now," he said.

Maggie rubbed Max's knee.

She stopped at his dresser, ran her finger along the top of it. There, where her boyfriend would've brushed his hair every morning before school, tucked into the edge where mirror met frame was a photograph of a young girl. She wore a private school uniform much like the ones she'd worn herself throughout many different schools. The girl looked shockingly

Chinese compared to how she looked now. Her hair darker, pulled back. But it was definitely Maggie. *How long had he known her?*

She acted as though she didn't see it, turning then and plopping herself to sit down next to Max. She pressed her body against his and rested her chin on his shoulder. Their sad and sullen energy dragged her down to their level and now she was sad too. "What's wrong?"

Maggie shook her head no. She said, "Nothing's wrong. It's just—"

"My mom looks really good," Max said as if that would settle the matter.

Maggie murmured, "She didn't for a while."

"Happy tears?" Keely asked.

"I guess," Max laughed. "Yeah, happy tears."

"This is where you grew up," she said, looking around his room.

"It is."

Maggie was still drying her cheeks. She said, "Can you picture him here? Can you picture high school Max?"

She scratched her nails through Max's hair at the back of his neck saying, "What was high school Max like?"

Someone from down the hall roared: "Nerd." Then burst out laughing.

Max shook his head, said, "I was *not* a nerd."

Closer to the door now, someone said, "Double nerd." Max's father was at the doorway, just passing by. He winked and pointed a finger pistol their way before heading to the stairs.

"Thanks, Dad," he yelled after him.

Maggie chuckled, squeezed his knee. She said, "He wasn't a nerd. Or at least not when I met him."

"Was that in high school?"

Maggie shook her head no. Now she was looking up at Max in almost the same way Keely was. She patted Max's cheek. She said, "He was the cutest guy I ever saw. First year at Farm. Imagine this face but more boyish, a little scruffy." She squeezed and shook his cheek.

Keely took his cheek now too, saying, "I can see it. I can totally see it."

Maggie's eyes teared up again, and she said, "I couldn't believe he would even talk to me."

She said, "Doesn't sound like a nerd to me."

"I wasn't a nerd," Max said. "Don't listen to anything my dad says." He leaned forward and put his elbows on his knees and hid his face from them.

He rubbed at his cheeks. Maggie rubbed a circle on his back.

Keely folded her hands together in her lap, then changed the subject. “Your mother looks fantastic, Max. I love her.”

Max said, “I love her, too,” into his hands.

Maggie rose now, squeezed Max’s neck. She went to the dresser and rested her arms on it, hid her own face like she might cry as well.

Keely said, “I’m supposed to tell you it’s almost time to eat. Your sister sent me...”

Max laughed into his hands and said, “That means we got about twenty minutes.” Maggie laughed as well, and it was clear she was also crying.

It felt strange to be on the outside. To be part of this strange trifecta and to have him mean so much, but have someone in their life whose meaning went deep, whose roots worked through your history and your past until they were entrenched and couldn’t be removed.

But then Maggie stood upright again, checked her expression in the mirror tidied her hair. She sniffed, said, “Okay, I’m going to go down.” She sniffed again then laughed at the snort it made. She said, “I’m going to go down and tell them you’re coming.”

She held onto Max while his ex-fiancé left the room, pausing once at the door to look over her shoulder then darting away as if she hadn’t really wanted to do that—or at least not get caught doing it. Now they were alone.

She hugged herself to him, saying, “Don’t be sad, Max. This is a great visit.” But then what did she know? Maybe this *was* terrible. She had nothing to compare it to, while Max and Maggie had a much broader experience. She said, “I love your parents.” She twirled her index finger through his hair.

“They like you too,” he said. “I can tell they do.”

She wanted to say not as much as Maggie to test the waters with sarcasm, but it seemed like a really sour note right now so she bit her tongue. “Why are you sad?” she asked him. Might as well dig a little deeper.

He said, “I’m not sad at all. I mean obviously it doesn’t seem that way, there’s just a lot of memories here.”

She said, “Like that picture that would sum up the best four years of your life you’d like to put on your desk.”

He put his hand over hers. “Exactly. That window’s gone. Sometimes when I see them now, I realize we’re only getting farther and farther away

from it.”

“They’re doing so good. Your mom looks great.”

He said, “I know she does. I’m so happy that she does.”

Maggie was at the bottom of the stairs yelling up at them. “Keely, Max...”

She said, “We should go.”

She helped him to stand up, and they both went to the mirror and made themselves look more presentable. Max dried his eyes, strained his shirt and smiled for her. He turned and led the way, stopping at the door and holding out his hand to wait for her.

Keely looked at the mirror again. The picture of Maggie that had been tucked into it was gone.

OUT BACK OF the pool cabana where they couldn’t be seen from the house, Keely took a drag off Connor’s impressively rolled joint. If he hadn’t seen his brother roll it, he would’ve accused him of buying it that way. Keely held it in and passed it to Abigail who took her turn. The five of them, him and his brothers, Keely and Abigail, were all outside taking a break from the house activities. The space behind the cabana was private; a circular brick patch with enough space for all five of them to stand without having the pine trees scratch at their hair.

Keely exhaled, bounced in place because she was cold, huddled into her jacket. When Abigail was done, she blew to the side then linked an arm with Keely, saying, “We should get back before someone comes look for us.”

Keely got gum from her pocket and shared with Abigail. Abigail said they should leave them for some brother-time, and Keely came and kissed his cheek, smelling like wintergreen. Abigail matched her, coming in for a peck on Connor, then they linked arms again, and trotted off, giggling.

All three brothers leaned to the side to watch them, two hot girls all dressed up and looking adorable.

Mike sighed, “Jesus Christ, you two,” envying his unmarried younger brothers.

Connor nudged his elbow, said, “Fucking Keely, bro...”

He said, "Tell me about it," and took his turn with the dwindling joint.

Mike said to Connor: "How'd he meet this one?"

Connor said, "Friend of Maggie's at Harvard."

Mike shook his head like he was irritated—*profoundly* bothered—then took the joint passed from Max. He and Connor watched their oldest brother take a puff, still grumbling. When he was done, he said, "Just how much money do you make, you piece of shit?"

Connor laughed till he bent over, holding the joint to the side.

He said, "I do fine."

Connor stood again, paused with the joint up, said, "He's three years in at buy-side and he lives in Manhattan—he's lucky to squirrel away an extra five-hunny a month. I *guarantee* you got more in the bank, Mike."

It satisfied Mike, who folded his arms and studied the youngest Milton. "Then how does this loser do it?"

"Guy brings *two* girls home for his visit. Fucking grandstander," Connor said, smirking, puffing.

Mike said, "And that fucking *Maggie*... You're lucky you brought a new one, because I would taunt you till you locked yourself in your old bedroom and cried on your bed. Holy fuck is that girl growing up. You see her, Connor? That's a *woman*, she's not a little girl anymore. That family of rich weirdos, you married her you'd never have to work—and you'd bang *that* every night...?"

Connor said, "Max chalked up a big L on that one."

"We're still friends. We still love each other."

"Aw, go write a poem about it, Yeats," Mike laughed.

"An Ode To Love," Connor said wistfully and looking skyward, and they both laughed at him.

Connor passed him the joint, and he waved it off. "I'm not going to be able to walk back to the house."

Connor showed it around, but they were all done. He pinched it off and sealed it away in a tin he tucked back in his pocket. Gum and hand sanitizer was passed around.

Mike said, "You going to bang both of those girls?"

He pondered, considering it, playing it up as if it were a possibility. He said, "Maybe."

"Bull-*shit*, Max," Connor said.

He chuckled. "You mean at the same time?"

Mike gave him a look like he wanted to strangle him. “Yeah, at the same *time*, you fucking shithead.”

“You’re a turd, I mean it,” he said. “Such a savage. Tabitha’s got your dick locked up, and now you’ve got the fucking sex-brain of a Super-Max con. How much you jerk off? Is Tabitha worried?”

“I get plenty with Tabitha, don’t you worry about me, Maxy-poo. I lay it down.”

Connor was looking at him, studying him. “I thought you were hanging on to nothing with Maggie, man, I mean it, I was worried for you.”

Mike said, “You can’t down shift from engaged to dating again and think it’s going to work out.”

Connor nodded, averted his eyes. “I’m so fucking happy about this Keely situation.”

He said, “Me too.”

“Two fucking hot Harvard girls—*two!*—I don’t even get it, I shit you not,” Mike said, shaking his head and grumbling for a moment. “Sometimes I wonder what the hell’s going on. Little brother bedwetter with his comic books and his feelings pulling girls like that.”

Connor said, “Maybe he’s a grower.”

“You a grower, Max? That bean turn into a peppermill when the moon’s out?”

He rolled his eyes, said to Mike: “You’re such an idiot.”

Connor said, “Max has a gorilla cock he never told us about.”

He said, “Gorillas have small penises.”

Mike said, “You’d know, you fucking beast-master, Jesus, Connor, keep an eye out for Dad’s dog, don’t let Max sneak it upstairs.”

“Maybe Harvard girls like guys with feelings,” Connor said, and tried to stick his finger in Max’s ear.

Mike said, “We’ll make him cry like we used to, those girls will come running taking their bras off as they go. Remember when we rolled him up in the rug?”

“Oh my God, he fucking screamed.”

“You guys were such fucking assholes.”

Connor laughed. “Mom lost her shit with that one.”

“I couldn’t breathe.”

Mike made a mean face, said, “Then how were you fucking screaming?”

JUNE and the dog napped in the afternoon and Keely hung out with Connor and Abigail and Max. Maggie was around but mostly stayed near Max’s dad and helped Franny in the kitchen. It was odd to see her friend that way; domesticated. But Maggie did it eagerly, like she enjoyed it. At school Maggie was casual but sophisticated; at her home in Cambridge she did some cooking and cleaning but Keely knew there was a weekly maid service. Max said Maggie had an active trust fund since she went to Harvard and her Dad was wealthy. She’d looked up Martin Becker: he was indeed loaded.

They hung around the house, sometimes slipping out the back to sit by the pool and share a joint. Mike and his wife watched a movie in the basement and Connor and Abigail joined them. Max took her for a walk since it was a nice day and they visited the neighborhood park where he used to hang out with his friends when he was a little guy. He put her on a swing and pushed her, then they sat on adjacent swings and bashed into each other while they chatted. She told him how much she liked his family, told him how good and healthy his mother looked. He told her he could tell how much they liked her.

She asked him, “You weren’t the local nutter who liked to make the neighborhood cats disappear, were you?”

After he stopped laughing he said, “Why on earth would you even ask me that?”

“There’s something dark in you.”

“Not that dark, you crackpot.”

She’d looked around the burgeoning branches scrawling above and around them, the pale grassy field damp still from winter snow, the brightly colored metal fort and slides and gymnastic apparatus. She said, “I like where you grew up, Max. I like it, I like America. Even at its finest, at the apex of the American Dream there’s a seedy underbelly.” She banged her knees into his and he grabbed the chains of her swing to hold her in place.

He smiled and looked into her eyes for a long time and there were invisible tendrils reaching out from each of their minds trying to tether to one another, exploring and seeking understanding. She touched his bottom lip with her weed-stinking finger and said, "You're my kinky man."

They came together for a long-lasting kiss, both of them holding onto the lapels of the other's jacket.

When they returned to the house, June was awake and refreshed, back in her chair by the fire with Maggie sitting at her side, shoes off, legs curled under her, the two of them enjoying cups of tea and chatting close and quiet. In Max's mother's lap, her hands curled the edge of a large leather-bound tome, and by the index of plastic-looking pages, she could tell it was a photo album. June saw Keely with Max and then urged her to join them. She took a seat at her other side. Max came as well, moving around the opposite side, squeezing Maggie's stocking toes as he passed, then standing behind his mother and kissing the top of her scarf-wrapped head.

June showed them pictures from twenty-five years ago. Maggie curled right up next to her, and Keely imitated, getting close till their shoulders touched. Max squeezed and stroked her neck. He asked if he could get anyone drinks and she asked for a glass of wine. While he was gone, they continued to tour her boyfriend's babyhood. There were pictures of baby Max in his crib, with his teddy bear, watching TV with Connor at Christmas time with their PJs on. She turned the page and there was a 5x7 of her Maxy boy at maybe three-years old. He had on a felt cowboy hat and nothing else but a plastic holster around his waist with fake bullets in fake leather loops. The pistol, a silvery cap gun, was pointed up and away, her young Max knowing you only pointed cap guns at things you wanted to kill. He smiled a beaming smile, his little boy penis sticking out, no sign of his testicles.

Maggie went wide-eyed and her hand moved very surreptitiously to cover a smile she had trouble controlling. Her cheeks ballooned out with the effort, and Keely could tell she was close to bursting.

Keely smirked, eyes darting up to see Maggie's face going red above the hand she'd clamped over her mouth, eyes turned down to the picture. She said, "That's my gunslinger."

June stopped and made a sighing *oh* sound, touching the frame of the picture behind an acrylic sheet with her finger. She said, "His father dressed him like that."

Keely said, "That's a familiar outfit. He wore that to my dorm last Halloween."

June gasped a shocked inhale and for a second she thought she'd made a mistake joking about their sex life, but then June guffawed and covered her mouth with both hands. She laughed till she shook, then brought the pads of her fingers down to cover the image of her little boy's privates. Max returned with her wine, face beaming brightly to see his mother laughing so hard, not knowing his nudity was the source of the humor.

He said, "What is going on here?"

His mother still covered the naughty part of the picture and reached around behind her to swat at his leg, saying, "Oh Maxy, you're bad..."

Max laughed, said, "What the heck...?" Then he saw the picture she'd showed his girls. "Mom, what the hell are you showing them?" He put his hands up and shook his head in disbelief, then caught her watching him and laughing, too. Now he scowled, said, "And what the heck are you telling her?"

June snorted again and pinched Keely's knee and it made her jump. She'd expected Maggie to be joining in on the laughter since she'd tried so hard to conceal it, but when she glanced her way, she found her expression grim and humorless, her eyes averted down.

They didn't do dinner together but Franny had more hors d'oeuvres and finger foods, meat and cheese for sandwiches, baked breaded things from the oven and more veggies and dip. By seven o'clock Max's mother was knackered again and Franny was going around giving the brothers the sign to wrap the show up while it was still good.

Max's mother looked in seventh heaven with her children and their mates, and when they were gathering to leave, Maggie took her in a long embrace. June squeezed her and whispered in her ear and that little thing made her very jealous. Then June and Maggie were laughing and wiping their eyes and Keely stood in the hall imagining June had whispered for Maggie to hang in there, that this red-head wasn't a keeper. But then June gave her a big hug too, and told her how nice it was to meet her and how she loved her accent and told her to keep her head in her schoolwork which on the ride home became another secret hidden message, at least in her imagination, that she shouldn't take this thing with Max too seriously. Max's dad walked them to the car and had a hug for both the girls. He shook Max's hand and hugged him, then they were off. Mike and Connor

were leaving soon, too, but Mike's wife was having a nap as well, and Abigail was in the washroom. They'd talked about hooking up at the hotel later tonight, they were all at the Marriott.

But now she wasn't sure she was in the mood. She had her arms crossed, feeling surly and hurt and she wasn't sure why. She loved Max's family and loved meeting them, but it still hadn't been so easy with Maggie there, and it certainly bothered her that Max had swiped up his old picture of young private school Maggie. A look over her shoulder showed Maggie sullen in the back seat, too, not saying anything and watching out the window.

Growing

SATURDAY, MAY 8

BACK AT THE hotel they quickly changed into more comfortable clothes. In the bedroom Keely lamented to him how she'd eaten too much, and he chuckled, came to embrace her from behind and watch their reflection in the mirror. It was a full-length one set in a stand, and she wore only her underthings. His hands roamed, cupping first her ass then coming around to cradle her bosom.

He said, "You did so good today, Keely, you made an impression on my parents."

She said, "You can dirty talk and handle my boobs..."

"But not while I'm talking about my family?" He gave her ladies a gentle honking, bit her earlobe and stepped back to sit at the foot of the bed.

Maggie was changing in the guest room and they said they'd watch TV or something, maybe even look into going out to do something, maybe with his brothers. Keely asked if he had old friends in Grand Rapids he'd want to call, and while he did, it just seemed too cumbersome with everything going on, plus he'd wanted to make this weekend about family and not get it all confused. They were leaving tomorrow afternoon and they would drop in on his folks one more time, so hangovers weren't a good idea.

While he sat and watched, Keely moved around the bed, unsnapping her bra and coddling her breasts, then slipping on a clean T-shirt and a sweatshirt. Panties were next, her fine things working down her pale legs, feet stepping out of them. Before she put sweatpants on, he stood and hugged her from behind again. He said, "What did you think of my family?"

“Your dad’s funny,” she told him. “Your mom is so sweet. Your brothers are funny too, especially Connor, and I really like your sister’s energy. There are a lot of males in the Miltons and she keeps you in line.”

“She does.”

There was more to say, but she stayed silent, feeling a little stiff in his arms. He swayed with her, refrained from letting his hands drop between her thighs and touch her bare pussy right now because it didn’t seem like the time. He asked her if everything was alright.

“Uh-huh,” she said, betraying the fact that not everything was alright.

He let her out of his clutch and she turned and sat on the bed with her legs pressed together; a gingery tuft sprouted above the hem of her sweatshirt gathering below her waist.

When she was silent too long, he said, “What’s wrong?”

Her eyes came up to meet his, and her mouth worked around. He waited. She said, “It’s okay if you wanted that picture of Maggie. You don’t have to hide it.”

He watched her face, his brain scrambling to make sense of her words. He said, “What picture of Maggie?”

“The one on the mirror in your bedroom.”

“What about it?”

“You took it with you.”

He shook his head, said, “No, I didn’t.”

She frowned. “It was gone.”

He shrugged. “You sure?”

She waved her hands back and forth and closed her eyes, signaling to him she didn’t want to pursue it.

He said, “The picture of Maggie when she was in high school? Why would I want that?”

“I don’t know,” she said, “melancholy?”

Now he stepped to stand by the side of the bed, his thighs on either side of hers. He held her neck, stroked her jaw with his thumbs, looked in her dazzling green eyes. “I did not take that picture.”

She hooked her hands over his wrists, her eyes showing she believed him. She said, “I know you still have feelings for her.”

“Not in any way you need to think about.”

“You were together a long time.”

“Didn’t you say you can’t help your past,” he said with a smile.

Her head slumped to the side. She said, “My past was three days, yours was seven years.”

“Cole wasn’t the only guy you slept with in that time.”

“You know what I’m saying though.”

“I don’t know what to tell you, Keely. Maggie is part of my life, I—”

“I don’t want her *not* to be, Max. She’s part of mine, too, you know.”

“Then what’s wrong?”

She made an exasperated growling sound, hugged his hips and let her head swing forward till her forehead thunked against his belt buckle. He stroked her hair.

She said, “It was hard seeing her with your family.”

“Why?”

“Because they love her so much, your mother was hanging off her.”

“She wasn’t hanging off her.”

“Well, Maggie was hanging off her, then, and your mother liked it.”

“Maggie loves my mom and dad, I told you.”

“She’s not even with you anymore.”

“She still loves them.”

“Ah, I’m such a bitch,” she sighed. “Do you hate me?”

“No,” he laughed, pried her head back so he could look down into her eyes again.

“Forget I said anything, Max,” she said, “I don’t know what’s wrong with me.”

He smiled, stroked his thumb on her cheek. “There’s not a single thing wrong with you.”

She liked it, appreciated it. Then she smiled, added: “That you know of.”

He laughed. “That I know if.”

Now she stood, some measure of tension relieved from her, and she grabbed her sweatpants. He flicked her bare ass and watched that taut globe ripple.

She jumped and yelped, flashed him a dirty look and trotted into the bathroom, bare legs hopping.

His phone buzzed with a text as he sat on the edge of the bed to get himself changed into comfortable things.

Connor: come out with us tonight

He replied.

Max: you and Mike?

Connor: maybe. Mike's whipped

Max: Tabitha won't let him

Connor: u come out

Max: maybe. where?

Connor: don't know yet

Max: let me know

He set his phone aside and unbuttoned his shirt. Truth was as much as he missed his brother, the last thing he wanted was to go out tonight. Not when he had everything he wanted here in his hotel room.

OUT IN THE main room she and Max sat on the same couch, her flipping channels on the television and Max reading the Times on his iPad.

"Is she coming out?"

Max said, "Huh?"

"Maggie. She's been in her room for half an hour."

"I don't know," he said. "Go check on her."

"Fine," she said. She set the controller down, used his legs to get herself up off the couch, purposely digging her fingertips deep into the inside of his thighs until he jumped and hollered. "Sorry," she said dryly. He slapped her bottom as she headed to the guest room.

She knocked lightly on Maggie's door and waited. A thin and quiet *Yeah?* came back.

"You coming out?"

There was a long pause then she said *In a bit.*

“Can I come in?”

Another long pause followed by that same quiet *Yeah.*

She found Maggie in bed on top of the covers. She had her laptop out and open but the screen was dark. There was a textbook as well, but it was unopened.

“You studying?”

“I was going to.”

She was lying on the bed, changed into her comfortable things: a T-shirt and cotton Capri pants; her feet were bare. She lay on her side with her knees drawn up, her back to the doorway.

“You feeling all right?”

Maggie rolled her shoulder over, kept her knees pointed away. She looked up at the ceiling and said, “I’m okay.”

There was something else that had been bothering her and she didn’t know if it might be a thing or not. It was definitely not something she would broach but now she worried that maybe Maggie had noticed her putting her hand on Cole’s chest. It was just an innocent thing meant entirely for Max, she was only using Maggie’s boyfriend as a play toy—but Maggie wouldn’t know that, only would have seen this girl that once slept with her boyfriend getting way too familiar with him again. She sat down at the foot of the bed, her back to Maggie. She said, “Come out and watch TV with us.”

“I think I just want to have a nap.”

“You can’t do that,” she said. “Let’s have fun. Come out and sit with us.” For some reason now she was feeling guilty.

Maggie said, “The next two weeks are brutal, Keely, for you too—”

“We knew we were taking this weekend off, you telling me you let your work fall behind?”

“No,” she said.

“You can’t have a nap, Maggie, it’s just after eight o’clock. Come out and watch a movie. You can go to bed early if you want.”

“I guess,” she sighed, and rubbed temples then smoothed her hair. She sat up and Keely pivoted where she sat so they faced each other.

Maggie bit her lip for a moment then said, “What did you think of Max’s family?”

“They’re just what I pictured. A bunch of dolls.”

“They really are,” she said, worrying a canine tooth over her lower lip. She began to wring her hands and massage her palms with her thumbs.

“You sure you’re okay?” She reached out and grabbed Maggie’s ankle.

“I’m fine. You did good today, you know?”

“Thank you. I think they liked me.”

Maggie nodded then said, “They liked you.”

“So what do you say, come out and sit with us...” She held Maggie’s ankle and pulled it toward the bottom of the bed.

Maggie sat back again, making herself heavy. But she chuckled into her gathered hands and rubbed her face.

Keely tugged on her ankle still. “Come on, come out with us...”

KEELY CAME out with Maggie walking a step behind. She was sad and sullen, her shoulders slumped, and her face weary looking. Keely plopped herself down next to him and Maggie took the captain’s chair that faced out over the city. She said, “What are we watching?”

Keely said, “Somebody said something about Jaws one.”

He said, “It’s just Jaws.”

“*Jaws*, then,” Keely said, rolling her eyes and making quotation marks in the air.

He said, “I don’t figure anybody’s hungry...”

Both girl shook their head no. Keely said, “What’s in the minibar?”

Maggie said, “You guys can go out.”

Keely said, “No, I thought we were all going to stay in...”

Max said, “Yeah, we’re just going to stay in.”

Maggie said, “Are Connor and Mike going to come by?”

“Maybe,” he said. “They said so, but these things usually never happen. Mike’ll probably be asleep by ten, and I think Connor said he was going to meet up with some of the guys from the neighborhood.”

Maggie said, “You don’t want to do that?”

“I got my two best friends here,” he said, still studying Maggie, still noting her sad demeanor. Keely was watching from the side and he flicked his eyes to her. She gave a worried face.

He said to Maggie, “I hope you’re okay.”

Maggie tried to brighten herself, sat more upright; she rubbed her face again and gave a lazy, unconvincing smile. “I told you I’m fine. I am.”

Keely said, “Why don’t you come sit with us?”

Maggie made an exasperated sound and let her head fall back. She said, “Guys, seriously, I’m fine.”

Unconvinced—he’d known her a long time—he exhaled long and slow. It was best to drop it, you couldn’t chip away at her from the front.

Now his phone vibrated against his thigh, and he withdrew it from the pocket of his sweatpants.

Connor: out at hopcat with Scotty and Corduroy you gotta come out with us

Max: Got something happening here

He looked up at Maggie, watching the screen as Keely figured out the TV remote.

Connor sent him a gif of two hot girls making out, their mouths locked, bare shoulders moving up and down. He chuckled.

Max: See u at the house tomorrow

A moment later, Connor got back to him.

Connor: Are you shitting me?

He hadn’t intended it to sound dirty but he wouldn’t back away from it now. He sent a gif of a mean-looking cowboy from an old movie slowly shaking his head from side-to-side, pretending he wasn’t kidding.

Connor sent back a mind-blown gif. He laughed and tossed his phone to the table.

Keely said, “What’s so funny?”

“Connor’s out with some friends from high school.”

“Did you want to go out?”

He shook his head no, just like that cowboy. He had everything he wanted right here and Corduroy would brag his ear off all night. Who

wanted that?

He sat back, faced Maggie who looked like she was trying to ignore them. “What was my mother saying?”

Maggie shrugged. She said, “She’s happy. We just talked about how her recovery’s doing. Talked about her friends...”

“Did she say something that bothered you?”

Maggie shook her head no. “She seems a little forgetful, but I think that’s okay.”

Max said, “They said it’s normal.”

“She really does look good,” Maggie said and her smile flickered a little more honestly.

Keely was the one who made the move, muting the TV, tossing the remote to the seat cushion and getting up to cross over and sit on the arm of Maggie’s chair. She looked unsure of what to do, made eye contact with Max, then put her hand on Maggie’s collar. She said, “She really loves you.” Then she looked at Max and shrugged.

Maggie patted the back of Keely’s hand. She said, “She likes you too.”

Keely stroked along Maggie’s collar, massaged her neck. Maggie’s knees came up, and her chin curled forward. He saw her profile scrunch and knew she was about to cry. She began to sob and her shoulders shook. Keely scooted down into the cup of the chair seat, squeezed herself against Maggie’s back and put her arms around her. “Oh no, what’s wrong?”

“Nothing’s wrong,” Maggie moaned, but feeling Keely’s arms around her brought more emotion. She sobbed harder.

Max came over and sat across from them, putting his butt down on the end of the coffee table. “Hey,” he said. “Tell me... what is it?”

Maggie shook her head and sniffed, rubbed at her eyes. She said, “Nothing.”

“It’s not nothing, Maggie.”

“It’s stupid,” she said. Keely hugged her tighter.

Maggie made a laughing sound, like she was laughing at herself. Keely said, “What is it?”

“I just... I just wanted to see them by myself. When everybody’s there...”

When she paused, Keely said, “It was nice though, wasn’t it? You got to see everybody...”

“I’m selfish,” Maggie said, laughing, then wiping her eyes again. “No. It’s not that. Seeing everybody together, seeing Connor’s new girlfriend...” She motioned with her chin but couldn’t say the name Keely.

“You feel what?” Keely said.

“Like I’m losing them.”

He felt his own brows curl with sadness. “Losing them?”

Maggie cried into her hands again, laughing at the same time. Keely popped out from behind her, trotted to the table-side box of tissues underneath a painting of a lake and sailboats. She brought the box over and squeezed herself behind Maggie again. Maggie plucked off three tissues and rubbed at her eyes. She said, “I’m so lame.”

“No, you’re not,” Keely said.

“I just don’t want to lose them.”

He said, “You’re not going to lose them.”

“I’m not with you anymore, you’re with someone else, and I’m just going to grow away from them...”

He scooted close to the edge of the coffee table so he could reach out and hold her ankle. Keely’s eyes watched his hand, and he felt self-conscious now. He said, “Maggie, they love you. That’s not going to change.”

“It will,” she moaned, “It will change...”

“It didn’t look like anything changed—I saw you sitting with my mom all day.”

“I know,” she said and blew her nose. “I just felt like such an outsider. I miss them. I miss being a Milton...”

Max saw Keely’s face make a sour turn, but she was still concerned for her friend. She put one arm around her and rubbed her shoulder. “You’re not an outsider, Maggie. I was the outsider.”

“They loved you,” Maggie said.

“They laughed at my jokes. They were polite. But it was you that June wanted to talk to.”

Maggie’s face was still for a second and then her features scrunched up again, her mouth turning into a curved and trembling bow, her skin blushing red. She cried into her hands: “Did you ever tell them?...”

Max said, “Tell them what?”

“Do they know what happened?”

Keely said, “What happened?”

That made Maggie cry harder.

Max said, "No."

Maggie said, "Tell me the truth, *please*... You told your brothers..."

"Told them what?" Keely said.

"I didn't tell them," Max said. "I didn't. I think Connor maybe knows..."

"He'd probably tell them," Maggie said.

"I don't think he did."

"He'd tell your sister and your sister would tell them..."

"What happened?" Keely said again.

Maggie sighed, plucked more tissues off and wiped at her face. She said, "What I did to him."

Keely's face pinched closed, puzzled. She whispered, "What?"

Max said, "They don't know what happened," and squeezed her ankle.

Maggie said, "I just don't want to be alone. I don't want them to turn their back on me."

At that, Keely started to tear up as well. She said, "Nobody's going to turn their back on you."

"I deserve it," she said.

"No, you don't," he said, laughing. Keely put her arms fully around Maggie and pulled her back into the chair. She rubbed a circle on Maggie's shoulder, Maggie curled up against Keely's chest. Keely watched his eyes, and he tried not to give anything away. Just showed concern.

After a long while, Keely whispered to Maggie, "Did you swipe that picture of yourself from Max's mirror?"

Maggie didn't answer, but she nodded.

Keely said, "You didn't want me to see it..."

Maggie shook her head no again, this time whimpering, "I didn't want you to think about us."

"I see you together all the time."

"I didn't want you to think that he left that there. He doesn't even live there, it was just left from a long time ago..."

Keely met his gaze again. She grimaced, recognizing the bad that she'd thought earlier but it now turning out to be something sweet. Maggie tried to gather herself, blinking her eyes, wiping her cheeks and squeezing her nose with a tissue. She tossed it to the floor, eased herself up to sit and

rested a hand on Keely's chest above her breasts. She patted Keely's collar. "I don't want you to think there's anything between Max and me."

Hearing the words, even knowing it was to make Keely feel better, stabbed his heart. *It really was over, wasn't it?*

Now she patted Keely's cheek, touched her chin with her thumb. She said, "I love you. I love you, and I love you with Max." She turned to look at him now. "I love you both. I don't want to be a problem between you, but I don't want to leave..."

Keely had to wipe her eyes too; she looked like she was melting into the chair, her head slumping back on her neck, her fiery hair framing her sad face. Her sweatpants knees poked up on either side of Maggie's slim body.

Suite

SATURDAY, MAY 8

SUCH A SELFISH BITCH she'd been. The whole day it had been *Me, me, me*. How is this affecting *me*...? Is Max paying more attention to Maggie...? Does June like Maggie more than me...? *Maggie's an interloper, why is she even here*...? Truth was today was Maggie's time. It was her visit to the Milton's that everyone else ganged on. Truth was Maggie had been respectful to her all day; had even looked out for her. Sometimes it felt so good to be mad, felt so good to taste the heat of a good mad-on, especially when you were convinced of your righteousness. Of course, when the light shines on the dark you're left with the ugliness of your own guilt; the ugliness of your own desire to enjoy the awful human pleasure of feeling offended. Maggie had bought a cake and let her present it, Maggie had hooked arms, Maggie had introduced her as her Best Friend. Maggie had receded to allow her to talk with Max's mother, his father, his siblings... It was easy to overlook those things, easy to disregard them because in doing them Maggie showed weakness and that dark mean Irish part of her loved to capitalize on weakness for her own rewards.

"Aw, Maggie, come on now, don't be sad," she said, and stroked the back of her head. Maggie's cheek fell against her collar and it made Keely smile. A vulnerable Maggie was a strange thing to see. She'd always respected her; she was older, smart and accomplished, a kind helper who'd spent a few evenings helping her align her application for the JD. She was beautiful, had her own house, dressed so cool, had a hot-ass boyfriend who she herself once had a painful crush on. There was an infatuation for this older girl who had *everything*. But since the arrival of said girl's ex-

boyfriend on the scene and their burgeoning relationship, she'd let herself be poisoned by the worst of her own character. That infatuation had obverted to resentment: Entitled Maggie who had it all. Consumed by the idea that this beautiful girl had two amazing guys in her bed for three years. What a bitch. Or what a queen. Anger and envy had set in. Lucky bitch, she'd thought. Or mastermind: stringing along two smart, handsome, college guys and having them eating out of her hand, doing anything to please her. Queen Maggie. Queen Maggie of the Becker Empire, reigning from her throne atop a hundred million dollar fortune.

That had just been the temperature in the vessel from where she peered out a viewport, watching reality like it was an outside world. Maggie had been her friend the whole time, but it was that rational—yet unwelcome—resentment that had twisted her perception.

Maggie said, "I don't want to be a problem, but I don't..." Her voice broke away.

"It's okay," she soothed her, hand stroking her hair still.

"Don't shut me out. Don't leave me behind... I'll die..."

"Leave you behind?" she laughed, letting her know it was ludicrous.

"I know," Maggie said, voice still thick with sadness. "It could happen, but I want you to know how it would hurt me..."

"We're not going anywhere," she whispered and hugged her head. Across Maggie's shoulder, Max watched with tight and dark expression, hunched forward on the coffee table with his hands together. She gave him a worried face, twisting her mouth up for comical effect. Max pursed his lips and didn't smile. His eyes were red and glistening.

Now she nudged her head for him to come over and join them. Her Max was worried about being involved and she knew it was her that was like a cross to a vampire; her chagrin and the threat of anger warding him off. It was time for togetherness and support.

Max shook his head no, gave a warm smile that told her this was her responsibility and now it made her grin wide at him over their friend's head; her heart swelled in her chest at a rising feel of goodness. Her clutch on Maggie tightened and Maggie made a happy, submissive whimper. It made her feel like a team member; not an extra in their movie. She had a role in this feature, and she mattered to them all.

Maggie nuzzled her neck, wiped her eyes against her. She could feel a growing coldness there; she'd wiped tears on her.

“Maggie, Maggie, Maggie,” she whispered, “We’re all good, we’re not going to leave you.”

It was nice being supportive. It was nice to hold somebody you cared about in their time of need. Maggie’s body was light and thin between her legs, warm against her chest where she was cradled. Maggie wormed her face against her collar again, and Keely rubbed her jaw against the side of her head. There was a soft damp sucking against the side of her neck and she knew that Maggie had just kissed her. It made her eyes brim with tears, gave her a feeling of love and being needed. She rubbed Maggie’s arm, gave Max a sad yet happy face, kissed Maggie’s hair in return. The hand that cradled the back of Maggie’s head smoothed her hair again, traced it off her cheek and she ran the tip of an index finger around Maggie’s small and well-formed little ear. The urge to lighten things, that constant driving force inside her, was forming the words to compliment her earrings; obviously Cartier, tri-gold, formed in the shape of a cat. Maggie kissed her again. Her soft lips plucking at the skin of her neck this time making a soft smacking noise.

“You’re so loved, Maggie. You’re so loved...”

Maggie’s hand on her chest spread open, and she clutched Keely’s shoulder. Maggie sniffed, wiped her cheek on Keely’s sweatshirt. She came up for air, looking directly in Keely’s eyes now. Keely smiled for her, showed her tenderness. Maggie didn’t smile, but her eyes were wide and expressive. The sun was going down, the sky outside a hazy faded indigo; lights on the buildings in downtown Grand Rapids were beginning their nighttime glow. There was a table lamp on, the room had gone dim and warm. A soft quivering under-reflection on the underside of Maggie’s eye was lit, picking up the gold in her hazel eyes.

There was a determined look on Maggie’s face, a longing, too.

Keely said, “We’re never going to leave you.”

Maggie blinked once, and her face came close. It was tender and Keely knew what was happening. She’d been kissed a million times. Someone looking in your eyes and bringing their face close meant only one thing. In response, she tilted her chin up to receive the kiss before she could even contemplate three important things: this was a girl; this was her friend; this was her boyfriend’s ex-fiancée.

She took the kiss, held it a long time.

Maggie's mouth was as soft as it looked, her lips feeling larger than she would've thought, pliable and pressing against her own. They kept their mouths closed and in a moment that stretched forever where she contemplated the meaning behind this kiss—was this affection? was this lust?—she'd forgotten to breathe.

Now she was inhaling deep, air whisking across Maggie's cheek and into her lungs. Her pulse thundered up her neck and her heartbeat pounded in her eardrums.

Then the kiss was over, Maggie pulled back and bit her lower lip. Their eyes stayed connected. There was a hazy, blurry image of her boyfriend still sitting on the coffee table and watching. A cavalcade of images flashed around her while she held steady on Maggie's eyes. Threesomes, three-way love, free love, all the things that her boyfriend had done with this girl, all the times three of them had been in bed together, what had it been like...

Maggie still didn't smile, but that longing look was still there. Whatever it was she sought, wasn't found. She held Keely's neck now, thumbs coming up to stroke her cheeks, soft pads running feathery traces on her. Maggie said, "You are so beautiful, Keely."

"You're beautiful, too," Keely said, and that was when she realized she was dumbstruck.

And now Maggie's mouth was coming at her again, sealing over hers, elegant hands cupping her neck. Maggie kissed her passionately. This was more than affection, way more than affection now. It was confirmed. But instead of shoving her away, instead of revulsion, she breathed deep, making room for her heart which seemed to swell gargantuan inside her rib cage; crystals of fine ground pleasure raced through her system, and the drumbeat grew louder and quicker in her ears...

IT WAS UNEXPECTED. A moment of tenderness and care stepping over a line into dark yet strangely familiar province. Right in front of him, an arm's length away—he could reach out and tweak any one of twenty pretty toes—the love of his life, the former love of his life, held Keely in a passionate kiss.

Maggie's cotton pants had ridden up and exposed her calf from knee to bare foot, the soft, pretty soles scrunched and tucked under her rump. Soles he knew intimately. Feet he'd kissed, toes he'd sucked. And his wonderful Keely slumped back in the chair her two knees poking up on either side of Maggie's slim waist, her arms embraced around her, the cuffs of her sweatshirt coming to the first knuckle, the tips of her pale fingers pressing into Maggie's sides. Maggie held Keely's neck, face over top of hers, their mouths combined passionately.

All day he'd worried about collision between the two. Worried about the overlap, worried where their two circles of relationship with him would overlap and what friction it would cause.

This was unexpected.

Instead of being aroused, instead of being the lusty male he'd always assumed he was, the sight brought him happiness. Brought him feelings of love. His own heart beat strongly, not with lust, but with love. These were the only two women he'd cared about. And they were together.

But now Maggie let the kiss come apart. She sat upright, sucked on her own lips while watching Keely. Keely looked up, dumb and awestruck, her eyes quivering and wet, pouted and engorged lips open. A hard nipple had poked a dot in her sweatshirt. She looked breathless.

Maggie wiped at her eyes, touched Keely's lip. She looked to say something more, closed her mouth, stroked Keely's cheek again. She said, "I should go," and moved to get off the chair. But Keely held her, hands gripping Maggie's shirt at her waist. Maggie said again, "I should go."

Keely said, "Go where?"

Maggie shook her head, squeezed her eyes tight. Max found his voice. "Don't go."

Maggie looked over her shoulder at him, and it was the first glimmer of something positive he'd seen in her face tonight. She said, "I should go to my room."

Keely said, "Stay with us."

Max said, "Stay with us, Maggie. I don't want you to be alone."

"I'm not alone. I've got my textbooks."

Keely smiled, Max watched her hands loosen the grip on her shirt then stroke Maggie's sides, moving up and down the narrow of her waist and then her slender rib cage. Keely said, "There's no studying tonight. We're just gonna hang out."

Maggie held her forehead, said, “I think I just want to lie down.”

Keely’s hands closed around her shirt again in case she wanted to try to get away.

Max said, “You can lay with us.”

It was meant as compassionate, but the lurid meaning of the words hung in the air. As soon as he said it he felt like he’d made a mistake. Keely’s eyes moved to his, and he expected her to be angry. But she was expressionless.

“Where?” Maggie said.

Max said nothing, watched Keely instead. Keely was watching the side of Maggie’s face, her mouth working around. She said, “You can come and lay in our bed.”

Max’s eyebrows began to rise, but he forced them back down. Maggie’s tongue worked around the inside of her cheek, she looked to Keely, then to him, then back to Keely. Keely said, “We could all do with a lie down.”

Maggie was the first to rise, but she needed Keely to show the way. Keely held her hand, and they padded across the suite to the bedroom. he followed behind, watching their thin legs, their bare feet, their long hair swinging.

All three of them got onto the bed. Maggie climbed up first, on her hands and knees crawling to the far side. Max guided Keely to get up ahead of him and she ended up in the middle. Keely lay on her back, looking up at the ceiling. Maggie rolled over so they faced and folded her arm over top of Keely so her hand rested just under her breasts. Max curled himself against Keely, on his side, watching her pretty blinking profile. He reached down and took her hand, wove his fingers between hers and brought them up to rest over his heart. Maggie nuzzled herself closer, worked her face under Keely’s hair and kissed her neck again. There was a steady tap-tap-tap—Keely’s racing pulse giving away a rapid heartbeat showing across the long tendon of her pale, slender neck.

It was incredible. Something he never thought could ever happen happening right before him. And it wasn’t dirty, it wasn’t sex, it was feelings and care.

Maggie kissed Keely’s neck until she encouraged her to turn her face. When she did Maggie kissed Keely’s mouth.

ALL THE CURIOUS uncertainty she'd felt about Max's past was being revealed to her right now, and she'd kept it well-hidden from even herself. All the times she'd wondered what it was like to be in bed with Cole and Maggie but then abruptly pushed the thought away was being revealed to her. It amplified the curiosity she had sought to quell. She'd always wondered. And here it was. She didn't want it. At least the *foremost* part of her brain rejected the idea. But her pounding pulse and her racing heart was telling her different. *You wanted to know, now here it is...* What was she going to do, reject it? Not experience it?

Now she was fully kissing Maggie on the mouth. Their lips worked together, and she breathed her friend in. Never in her life had she kissed a girl—not passionately, at least. One didn't go to boarding school without a peck or two on your friends' lips, of course, there were always dares, but this was for real, and the more she explored it the more intense it became. Excitement was racing through her. Maggie smelled heavenly. As her body warmed up from their action, it activated whatever it was she wore; sage and jasmine and vanilla and talc. She was warm and light and slender; extravagant. She had a beautiful, lithe body, and her broad Asian features with her golden eyes and her tawny-black hair made her strikingly leonine. She was smart, amazing, funny, driven; everything a woman could want to be. She had it all. The fact she would press her lips to Keely's was so close to that feeling of being kissed by David Sloane—the hottest guy in Aughrim putting his lips on hers at a house party in front of *all* her fourteen-year-old friends and marking her as a girl of the highest caliber. But this was also *different*. This was a girl; this was a girl she knew and cared about. It was an intense feeling that she never had before. So she committed to it. Brought her hands into action.

She cupped Maggie's neck now, and Maggie cupped hers. Their lips locked and moved against each other more passionately. She opened her mouth. *She couldn't believe she opened her mouth!* Maggie was waiting for it because her tongue darted past her lips. It was small and slender and slippery. Not like *any* guy's tongue she'd ever felt. Her own tongue lashed out, slithered across hers; before she knew it a soft moaning escaped her. She choked it off.

Hands were on her then, and she knew it was Max; behind her, the hands larger than Maggie's, squeezing at her collar, rubbing her shoulders. It was really getting to her, and she began to writhe. The three of them on

top of the bed, nighttime blue spread out around them in their corner suite. Two people ready to please her...

The hand that cupped her neck—Maggie's thin hand—swept down her collar then over her shoulder. Her neck grew cool in its absence. They kissed more, explored with tongues more. Max rubbed her shoulders and her waist. Maggie's hand swept down there as well, passing over Max's, then finding the front hem of her sweatshirt. Her stomach fluttered.

Maggie's closed hand slipped under the sweatshirt, knuckles touching the bare flesh of her tummy. She gasped. Her hand left Maggie's neck, covered over Maggie's hand inside her sweatshirt. She wasn't sure she was ready for more. But then when would this ever happen again? She squeezed Maggie's hand once, let it go, returned it to Maggie's neck. She lifted her elbow so Maggie could raise her hand higher under her sweatshirt, finding a breast. She'd not worn a bra, and could feel her nipple drag across Maggie's warm palm. Maggie cuddled her, ran her thumb over the hard bud. She broke her kiss for a moment to tell her, "You have the most beautiful breasts." A ridiculous thing to say, and a ridiculous thing to hear. But somehow, laying on this bed in such a wild predicament, it was the *perfect* thing to say. It made her think that Maggie had admired them. Maggie had seen them through her clothing a few times and thought they were pretty great.

Max's hand slipped under her shirt as well now, too, coming up her side. He dragged the sweatshirt with it, and any sort of reluctance she had felt suddenly washed away. Now she rolled her shoulders so her back was on the bed, her hands came down to grab the front of her sweatshirt. She lifted it up to her neck, exposing her chest.

Maggie made a sighing sound, and Keely watched her friend's eyes linger on her bare breasts. Watched her friend admire them. She felt profoundly exposed and simultaneously accepted and appreciated. Maggie's hand came out carefully, open and horizontal, hovering over her left breast, then lowering, the underpads of her four fingers moving in steady metronomic lines across the hard raised bolt of her aroused nipple. Max's mouth was there, on her right breast, kissing the side then taking the nipple in his mouth. She held the back of his head and gripped his hair. Maggie saw and did the same; edged close enough to put her own mouth onto Keely's other nipple. The two of them suckled, and she caressed their hair, looking at the ceiling and wondering how this was even happening...

Still caressing both of their heads, she frowned and grimaced, whispered, “No kissing, okay...? I don’t want you to kiss...”

Both of them nodded together, not looking at each other, one of her nipples in each of their mouths. The feeling made the arches of her feet curve to bows.

Together

SATURDAY, MAY 8

MAX WATCHED MAGGIE NOW, Keely's nipple in his mouth and pulled taut. Maggie suckled as well. Pretty pouting mouth sealed around the glistening tip of his girlfriend's breast. Maggie had been the biggest part of his life for the last seven years; they'd done everything together. Shared and explored, loved and lost, the connection was profound. No words communicated between them, they both worked in automatic action to please Keely. Both of them knowing that she would be the weak link tonight. Both of them knowing, though it was Maggie whose heart needed repairing tonight, who could have done with two companions to lay with her in bed and make her feel better, it was Keely that would be getting all the attention. Keely was the one who would be reluctant.

Now his hand felt her familiar soft tummy, working in circles around her navel, moving over the waist of her panties to test her reaction. No hands came down to slow him, instead his Keely's breath fluttered, and she made a groaning sound. Her pelvis even tipped forward eager for touch.

He reached across, moved his hand around until he found Maggie's wrist. He urged her to touch Keely between her legs. Her hand came down tentatively, pausing on Keely's hip, the bone of her wrist resting against the knob of her hipbone. Maggie's hand was curled in a tentative soft ball. He could see her fingers twitching. Then Maggie made up her mind, and her hand slowly lowered, fingers stretching out, the tips brushing across the pale cotton of Keely's panties.

Keely's heels stroked up and down on the bed, and he saw that her knees opened.

There had been a time when Cole and he had done everything for Maggie. She was innocent and timid and inexperienced. They sought to expose her to some pleasures, sought to provide her experience. They'd always toyed with the idea of her being with another woman, but it had never worked out. Whenever it was broached, Maggie acted like they were being lustful boys, but she never scolded them too far to make them think she didn't want it. It just took time and the right partner to come along. Maggie had chosen Keely for Max because they were an excellent fit. But Maggie knew that she also needed to have her edges match up to Keely's. It was a pairing meant for her as well as for him, and now he wondered if Maggie had ever fantasized about this before. And if she did, for how long had it been brewing?

Now he hooked his thumb in the front of Keely's panties, tented them outward and pulled them down. Maggie looked inside Keely's underwear and in the pale light they could see that scruff of hair. Maggie's elegant hand formed a bow below Keely's navel and spread out like a yoga pose until the pads of her fingers scored through Keely's pubic hair and over her mound. Keely let out a quivering moan and hoisted her butt off the mattress to meet Maggie's touch. Maggie drew in a long inhale at the feel of another woman under her fingertips. Keely was damp and Maggie's fingers brought a sticky sound. Keely primed and hungry for this lubricious act.

"Can we take them off?" he whispered to her. Keely nodded, and he was already pushing them down. She dug her heels in and lifted her romp, swayed her hips so he could push them with her cotton pants down to her knees. Then she spread her legs wide pushing her heels together, knees bowing out and scrolling her panties down to her ankles.

And then the dark fantasies hit him. Hit him hard below his stomach. He flexed, his thighs tightened. He didn't know everything about Keely. She was forthcoming, but she still held a lot of mystery. Now he could picture her in a boarding school in France, the lights out, the dorm advisor fast asleep and Keely and some other pretty girl from a foreign place in the same bed with their hands roaming over each other. Two bad girls, two rich girls from good families but with dark dirty minds. It was true. Keely did have a darkness to her too. It was coated in a soft cottony armor of humor, but underneath it all there was something in her that liked what it saw in his own shadows. Two dark and kinky ghouls who were fast becoming great pen-pals. Now he had to stifle a smile. She was incredibly beautiful. There

was no one else like her. And he was starting to think she might be his. And holy fuck did he want her. Way more than a crutch, this girl, not something he would use to walk again, but something he might be excited to walk *for...*

As Maggie rolled her two middle fingers in the apex of her mound, probably squeezing and mashing her clit, he kissed his way down her body, nibbling on her hip bone, kissing the front of her thigh and then inside her thigh. When he bit the flesh there, she let out a passionate cry. Maggie kissed her, climbed over her body so that the two of them were eclipsed. Maggie clothed, Keely with her sweatshirt around her neck and naked from there down. Her legs writhed on the mattress, his ex-fiancee's hand doing amazing things between her legs. He watched them as he continued to nibble and suckle on the inside of Keely's thigh, going right down to the insides of her knee.

Keely's hands clutched and squeezed Maggie's clothes. She wanted them off, but her movements were clumsy because of what they were doing to her. He hoped that what they were doing would be good for them both. Keely responded, but Maggie needed healing tonight, and he hoped this would do it.

Keely pulled Maggie's top overhead, Maggie moved her arms up so she could pull it off. Then she took Keely's sweatshirt, pulled it up over her face, two of them close together now, both of them lusty but chuckling. She squeezed it over Keely's head and up her arms, creamy breasts jostling on her chest, her strawberry nipples hard and upright. Then they were kissing again, Maggie and Keely locking their mouths and touching each other's faces.

He stroked Maggie's calf which had tucked itself against the inside of Keely's opposite knee where he was kissing. Stroked her calf to let her know he was here, and they were in this together. She looked down Keely's body and their eyes met but they were blank. She arched her back and presented one of her tea cup breasts to Keely who took it in her mouth, suckled on her hard brown nipple. Both of them were gyrating and writhing together now, their breaths coming faster...

SHE'D NEVER NEVER FELT a nipple in her mouth before, at least not a woman's. She'd thought about it; wondered what it might be like, but had never been led down a path where it happened. Maggie was warm and soft, her breasts not too big; small, but perfect for her body. A perfect handful, much like what she had when she first entered puberty. The nipple was tight and engorged. She knew what it would feel like to have her nipple suckled; it had been done many times to her. She knew what was pleasing. She lapped with the deep center of her tongue, going in steady strokes, then teasing with the tip. Maggie presented her the other one; she did the same. She wore a long necklace, and its ring pendant dragged near her nipple, making her scalp squirm delightfully.

Now she was wide-eyed and electric, the hazy glaze of initial lust clarifying. "What are we doing?" she asked.

Maggie smiled, stroked her cheek, said, "What I've wanted to do for a long time."

"Really?"

Maggie nodded, looked down at Max. She said to him, "Is this okay?"

Max's face was expressionless, but his cheeks were red and his lips were full. He nodded. She closed her right leg, pressed the inside of her knee against his ear. She reached down, and he took her hand.

Maggie said, "You too, Max. Take your things off..." Then she looked to Keely and bit her lower lip. "If that's all right," she added.

She wasn't sure. She wasn't sure, but she knew she wanted to explore. This was the darkness that was part of her Max. This was the secret part of him that she was attracted to. She'd never craved this kind of activity, but it was alluring, and she couldn't deny it. "Okay," she said.

Max nodded, pulled his shirt over his head. Then he sat up between her legs, untied his sweatpants and pushed them down. He was erect and ready, his thing bouncing stiffly between his legs.

Keely said, "Do we have rules? Is that how you do it?"

Max and Maggie looked at each other and chuckled quietly. And that hurt her, suddenly and quickly, and she hadn't expected it. "What?" she said, eyes welling, on the verge of surprising tears.

Maggie picked up on her hurt—her expression had fallen—and gripped her arm. She said earnestly: "You're right. You're absolutely right."

Max said, "We're laughing because you're right. There has to be rules."

She sighed, wavering, bit her lower lip while the two of them, ex-lovers, watched her patiently and expectantly. She said, “No kissing. And no laughing without me.”

Maggie said, “Anything else?”

She shrugged. “How about you?”

Maggie said, “I have no rules.”

“Me neither,” Max said.

She looked at both of them, the two of them confident and calm in the face of something so wild. She said to Maggie, “Not your mouth.”

“On you?”

“On him,” she said in a low voice and nodding her chin toward Max.

“Okay,” Maggie said.

Max said, “What about Cole?”

Keely said, “Will he be mad?”

“He won’t,” Maggie said. That gave her a chill to consider that maybe Maggie and Cole had discussed it beforehand. That the whole time they’d been planning this trip, Maggie had anticipated trying something on her. There was something frightening about it but also provocative.

Maggie held up her hand and wiggled her fingers. “Hands?” she said.

It took her a moment to realize what she meant. She shrugged her shoulders, looked at Max, looked down at his erection (*her* erection!) sticking straight up from his lap. She didn’t like it, wanted to say no to Maggie, but instead she said, “Okay.”

MAX’S GIRLFRIEND had a beautiful body, even more so on her back with her legs open. She was soft and very quintessentially feminine. Beautiful fiery hair, sparkling eyes and a gorgeous face. She had a full figure; large, soft breasts, wide hips and a narrow waist. The kind of body she’d wanted when she was younger. While it wasn’t meant to be, she sure did enjoy admiring what Keely had.

Being with a woman was the one experience that had eluded them. The thing that was promised but had never happened. She had two good-looking guys seeking to expand her horizons, as it were, but all they ever ended up doing was tumbling into bed together.

This was impromptu, unplanned. It was completely a function of emotion. And now she was committed, wanting to explore because Keely was receptive. So now she lay down across her friend again, felt Keely's arms circle her back as they kissed. Keely had soft lips. Soft like Max's. The two of them kissing together must be the pillowiest osculation. She bet they were soundless. Her heart filled with affection and joy for Keely, and she couldn't stop herself from expressing it. She whispered, "Your lips are so soft," and traced hair out of Keely's face.

"So are yours," Keely laughed.

"Have you ever done this before?"

Keely shook her head no and bit her lower lip. She wanted to bite it too. She said, "Never away at boarding school?"

Keely shook her head no again, said, "You?"

She told her no.

Now she held Keely's gaze, their eyes just inches apart, her face hovering over Keely's. Her breasts hung down, her nipples hard, and she lined them up with one of Keely's, made them drag across each other, first the left and then the right. Keely grabbed her own breasts, pushed them together, and they mushed their breasts and kissed again.

Max certainly had a wonderful plaything in his bedroom. She was just like she'd imagined. Playful and sweet with the potential to get dirty. Beautiful, too, an amazing thing to feel against your body and under your hands.

That joy abounded again, and she said to Max, "She's so wonderful."

Max was biting at the inside of Keely's thigh, and he smiled with a wad of her creamy flesh between his teeth. He said, "She is, she's amazing."

Keely liked compliments and squirmed underneath her. She slipped her thigh over, careful not to whack Max in the neck with her shin, and pushed the front of her thigh between Keely's legs. There was a slick heat there, and she squirmed her hips to make the flesh of her thigh drag up and down Keely sex.

Now she whispered, "I want to do something..." Dragging out the tension brought Keely's arousal. Even though she was sure she knew what it was, Keely arched her back in anticipatory ecstasy, and in a hissing whisper said, "What is it?"

"I want to go down on you..."

Dots

SATURDAY, MAY 8

AS MAGGIE RECEDED from their kiss—moving down Keely’s body in a crouch, Max slipping out of the way—she and her friend kept ragged eye contact. Her heartbeat jostled her vision, the excitement of what was happening was astounding. She opened her knees wider and made room as Maggie curled now between her thighs. Maggie’s thin hands swept up and down the inside of her legs, and each upstroke got her tummy quivering enough she could see the tremble. Maggie was excited too, overwhelmed by the prospect of what she would do, looking directly now between Keely’s thighs at that woman part of her. It would be engorged and slick, receptive.

Max sat to the side with his hands behind him, eyes wide and bewildered but also deadly focused. Maggie lowered herself and kissed the inside of her knee, worked herself higher, the closer she got darting out her tongue until it stayed out and ran a wet trail up to her mound. She kissed her on her pubic hair and she was dying for it now. She reached down and held the sides of Maggie’s head and for the first time in her life she felt a woman’s mouth between her legs. It was incredible. The first thought she had was that Maggie knew what to do because Maggie knew what felt good. She was getting a tour of what her friend liked. Maggie would be imitating what worked for her. While she enjoyed it, she took note, because she was sure that she would be doing this as well.

Her thighs gently closed around Maggie’s ears as the pleasure came—part of her wanting to reject this, push away the wrongness. But for so long curiosity had festered in her mental creases that the slick feel of Maggie’s small feminine and careful tongue working through her most intimate flesh

made it easy for her to accept that she was in bed with two people. Her legs parted, and she looked down her body to see that russet head of hair rolling between her legs, Maggie's hands curled around the outside of her thighs.

"That's good," she whispered.

Maggie's ministrations were light and teasing—not hungry like a man. Maggie knew that sensitive flesh well, knew how to treat it. Soon, her breaths came faster, and she began to bite and suck on the inside of her lips.

Max kept himself apart, watching from a safe distance near the bottom of the bed, cheeks drawn like his mouth had gone dry. After a long blissful time gyrating her hips against Maggie's tongue, her kisses worked over her mound, then the soft flesh below her navel. Maggie's cheeks were wet but also shining red and when their eyes met, she looked away bashfully.

"Come up here," she laughed and reached for her.

Maggie climbed her body and dropped at her side, covering her face with one hand and Keely turned on her side so they faced and put an arm around her.

"Was that okay?" Maggie said in a soft voice hidden by her hand.

"Yeah," she reassured her, taking hold of her waist and moving her hand away. Maggie's pretty lips shone with wet.

Maggie said, "I've never done that before."

She asked her, "Do you feel loved?"

Maggie nodded and her smile faded. "Is that okay?... Okay that I want that?"

"Yeah, of course," she said, stroking her hair. "We all want to feel loved..." Their eyes were connected, their faces very close.

Maggie smiled and said, "It's okay that I did that? Tell me..."

"Yes, Maggie."

"And it was good?"

"It was."

Maggie did a funny, embarrassed eye roll, then, to pass off what she'd done, she said, "Max is really good at it."

Max snorted, and Maggie looked down at him still watching from the foot of the bed. It was meant to be funny or nice, or to divert attention away from her abilities to please a woman orally, but it just reminded her that Max had gone down on this girl many, many times.

Max eased himself up, came on hands and knees behind Maggie and lay on his side, smiling at her over Maggie's neck. He didn't touch her or put

his mouth on her, but he was naked, and he was aroused. His body was close enough to touch, his erection must be touching Maggie...

For whatever reason, no anger came. She braced herself for it, flexed her neck in anticipation of a hot vicious flood working up her back... But nothing...

Instead, the arm she hugged her with retracted, her hand caressing over Maggie's rubbery brown nipple. She said, "You have such a beautiful body," and kept her eyes on Maggie's as her hand slid lower, turning around so her fingers led the way. Maggie's eyes widened, knowing what she intended.

THE SIGHT before him on the bed provoked the most profound and overwhelming feeling of joyous lust and love. Two friends, his lovers, two sweet, smart girls with big hearts and who meant everything to him explored each other's bodies. Both of them on their sides, face-to-face, in a hotel room in his old hometown. It was perfect composition—their two faces close together but far enough back their eyes could focus on one another. On the left, a tangle of fiery red hair spread out of over white hotel linen. On the right, a silky swash of russet-black. Their two faces were perfectly feminine. Both of them beautiful girls with thin necks and sharp jaws, flawless skin, and bright, dazzling eyes.

Both those sets of eyes were narrowed right now by lust, their long lashes fluttering—but a sparkle of light winking from underneath their lashes' shade. Both their mouths were open; lips glossy and puffy from kissing, Maggie's was hanging open in an O of shock. Keely's was widened like Maggie's but the corners of her lips tugged in the upward curve of a smile. It was hard to tell with Keely what provoked that angle to her mouth; she was complicated and funny and perverse—she was like him. Was the smile at the expression on Maggie's face, knowing she did that to her, or was it the soft, wet, warm feel against her fingertips right now...? He watched her arm, couldn't see her hand between Maggie's legs, but could see the muscle of her forearm work as she wiggled her hand. Maggie's sex made slick, eager sounds. She was wetted by Keely.

The thought that Keely could do this raced his heart and lungs; his chest swelled as his stomach tightened with the badness of what they were doing. But on the grand scale of the sexual bad he'd done, this was the most heartwarming. This was a picture of love and friendship—but he knew he had to be careful because Keely had a temper. She could be jealous and she could be hurt, and try as he did, he could never fully hide from her the fact that he still loved Maggie.

Now he hovered over them, two girls pleasuring each other, two friends in their strangest intimate moment. He whispered, “You’ve never done this before?”

Keely kept her eyes on Maggie’s face but said, “Me?”

“Yeah, you.” He kissed her shoulder.

“I’ve never done this before,” she said.

Maggie closed her eyes and laughed. She arched her back and pushed her pelvis forward. “You’re so good at it,” she said.

Keely bit her lower lip, her hand still working eagerly.

Max touched Maggie’s knee, doing it in the least intimate way possible. Curling his two fingers to the inside, he gently lifted so that Maggie could show them what was happening.

Now he watched his girlfriend’s fingers as they worked through the glistening pleats of his former fiancée’s most intimate place. He studied how she worked. Keely had long fingers like Maggie; she didn’t wear colored polish today, just a gloss. Her two shining fingers pushed and stroked, pressed and worked circles, darting up to tease Maggie’s clit. He couldn’t stop a smile spreading his cheeks, thinking that was what Keely liked. All she knew was how she would pleasure herself and applied it now for the first time to another woman.

Maggie groaned and then was embarrassed at expressing too much pleasure. Her hands came to cover her mouth, and her eyes fluttered open wide. Keely and her stared at each other until Maggie finally brought her hands away and said, “I love her, Max. She’s perfect for you...”

Keely laughed now too, and her hand slowed but stayed between Maggie’s legs. He moved his body over Keely’s, then collapsed behind her, he pressed himself to her back, watched Maggie over Keely’s shoulder.

He missed her so much.

He missed being in bed with her, missed her touch, her smell. They were supposed to never be together again, and yet here they were in bed

once more. It was like they were meant to be. His hand went up and down Keely's waist. Maggie met his eye, and they shared a long connection, not saying a word. Maggie took Keely's face between her hands and kissed her forehead. Keely's hand detached from Maggie's pussy and rubbed her arm. When the kiss broke, Maggie raised up on an elbow, making eye contact with Keely. She nudged her chin almost imperceptibly toward him.

Now both girls were looking at him, and his stomach jumped while a flutter of butterflies let loose inside him so abruptly he squeezed at his hip bone.

Both of them smiling, both of them getting up now...

MAXY LAY back on the bed protectively as if he was afraid of them though she knew he must want this more than anything on earth right now. Whatever damage had happened to her heart today it had been repaired. Seeing his family moving on, introducing his family to the girl that would replace her, had broken her in two. She'd been strong, strong for Max and strong for Keely, but inside she was torn ragged. All she needed was a little human touch and reassuring words.

"Open your legs, Max," she said, and Keely joined in, rolling onto her side to face him and scooting to lay pressed to his side. Her fingers worked over his chest and then down his stomach. Max brought his legs down so they could see his erection. Keely took it in one hand and kissed him on the mouth.

Now it was the two of them, Max and Keely, her worst nightmare imagined: what they looked like in bed when they were alone. For the longest time Max had been her everything. In many ways he still was, but she had to let him go. It hurt—it had been awful, to be honest. And this visage here was what she pushed out of her mind whenever it tried to creep in. Max with another girl.

Now she was an outsider again, but she was okay with it for now. If she were in bed with Max and Cole, she would go down on him right now. Take his balls in her mouth. Cole would be taking her from behind; she really missed those days but knew they were meant to be over. At least officially.

She watched his familiar penis in another girl's grip. Watched how that girl moved her hand on it. Keely knew what he liked already, knew how to please him. Knew to circle the thumb and finger close around the end of him, squeeze and stroke. Of course, it wasn't rocket science. Keely had more experience, from what she understood, and held a lot of them in her hand. Even Cole's. She had trouble swallowing suddenly, pressed her fingers to her throat.

Keely kissed Max's shoulder, her eyes tilted upward to look at him with the sweetest affection that stabbed her heart again. They really *were* a couple. They really *were* close.

The sadness returned, and she reflexively put a knuckle up to press underneath her right eye.

But now Keely was looking at her...

The expression was timid and tentative. Keely was unsure, but she was trying to communicate *something*. Couldn't rouse the courage to do it properly, so was flashing this frightened sort of look.

Her heart bounced in her chest, and once again she'd been returned to the fold. She lowered herself, getting onto Max's other side. He put his legs down, and Keely's unsure face moved lower down his belly, touched her tongue to the tip of his erection. Max made that sound he made when she used to do that. She winced. She wanted to touch him so bad, wanted to feel the warmth of his skin against her palm, wanted to tickle through the scruff of chest hair and poke at his chin. He was a good kisser, and she missed him.

Keely's eyes were blinking, staring at her.

She flashed the tiniest curl of a brow, indicating she didn't know what she wanted. Keely didn't know either, her eyes looking down at Max's erection in her hand. Maggie scooted down the bed till her cheek was on Max's hipbone. She mouthed *What?*...

HIS HEARTBEAT HAD COMPLETELY STOPPED. The thundering wash that had flooded his head went still for the longest moment.

On either side of his hips, two beautiful girls debated what they would do with his penis. Keely gripped it in one hand and stroked it lightly, and

both girls looked at each other and looked at his penis. The moment stretched long until it felt explosive. He couldn't even look at them anymore; they were too beautiful, and he loved both of them far too much. His head dropped back to the pillow, and he looked at the Marriott's ceiling.

His heartbeat resumed, and now he was gasping and panting as he tucked his chin down to see Keely put her mouth over his cock. Maggie watched and inched closer. He could see his own knees jump, could see an electric flexing seize his thighs. Maggie's mouth moved closer, she touched her to cheek to Keely's.

While Keely's head bobbed up and down his shaft, Maggie nuzzled the side of her face against her friends'. She whispered something to Keely, Keely hummed a sound.

Now he was up on his elbows, legs spread wide, two girls working their mouths on him. Keely bobbed up and down, and Maggie kissed at his scrotum. Her hand went up and down his thigh, and his eyes flooded with tears for how much he missed her. He wanted to touch her, and run his hands over her, but that would be awful for all of them, so he turned—trying to watch still—and shoved pillows behind his back.

Two girls breathing and moaning, doing incredible things to his penis and testicles. Pillows behind his back now, he put his hands on both of them. From Keely he felt love and warmth, and when his hand touched Maggie, it was with a black shock of the forbidden. He wasn't supposed to touch her anymore, they'd agreed to end it. They'd agreed to move on.

Now his heart twisted with what it meant.

Was it over? Was there something still there?...

As if she'd sensed his thoughts of her, Maggie kissed his testicles one more time, ran her hair behind an ear, sat up on an elbow. She smiled at him, the table lamp's glow putting soft strokes on her wide cheekbones and narrow eyes. That one instant, across two feet of space, that warm expression communicated their lifetime together.

It *was* over. It was over *and* it wasn't—but the way it had been would never be again.

His smile faltered, Maggie tilted her head in understanding. She stroked his thigh, her hand moving then to caress the back of Keely's head as it went up and down. She took Max's hand, guided him forward and eased Keely back. Now all three of them were sitting on their heels in the center of the big bed. Maggie wasted no time, still guiding Max forward to be with

his girl. And Keely received him, closing her eyes, touching his shoulders, falling back as he got over top of her...

MAX SLID inside her fully in one easy stroke. He was wet from her mouth, wet from Maggie's mouth, she wasn't exactly dry either...

Her lungs drew their fullest extent, feeling him inside her, expanding with love till her ribs could stretch no more. She arched her back, pumped her hips forward. She ran her nails up and down his sides, and for the first time in their life together she didn't feel intimidated by Maggie. She felt a sense of place. Like there were three dots on a piece of paper and she could triangulate them and know where she was, know where Maggie was, and most important: know where her man was.

She ran her hands up his back and grabbed his glossy black hair. His hips rolled and heaved against her, doing it gentle the way he was good, knowing he wasn't a thruster, that he was a lover. She loved the way he did it...

SHE SMILED through tears watching Max like he moved away from her forever. Watched his familiar cute little rump roll up and down and knew what Keely was feeling. She sniffed and brushed tears from her eyes.

Now she really *was* an outsider.

Keely's sounds grew. Feminine moans building and rising till they took the glassy, brittle texture of a wail. Keely's sounds drove Max. *And it hurt her that it drove Max.* It hurt to know how he was roused by another woman—but this was the way it was supposed to be, and the way *she* wanted it.

Now she was backing off the bed, gathering up her things from the floor, bundling them against her waist. She walked backward, watching the two of them hump on the bed, watching the way their hands locked together. Max held Keely down and kissed her while he made love to her.

Keely made her noises around their kisses, cried out, encouraged him for more.

SHE'D NEVER MADE love while someone watched—at least that she knew of. The thought they had an audience twirled up a high-pitched excitement within her, prompting all sorts of wonderment. What did she look like when she was under a man? Was she as sexy as she thought she might be? Or would a nonparticipating member not caught up in the tidal lust see all her flaws?

All the worry was dashed away by the intense pleasure Max delivered and the heightened feeling of taboo; of doing something *wrong*. Max fucked her squeaks out of her and now she was only gasping for air, chugging with each of his thrusts, hooking heels and ankles behind him to ease his thrusting, to hold his fleshy pike deep so she could roll the point against her front wall. When she came, it was accompanied by a sense of triumph—like a performer worried about a solo and yet when the time came they nailed it.

She couldn't help laughing—and the laugh became a moan as she hugged Max's head with both arms. Max had stilled as he often did when he knew she was ready to blast off. Both of them panted and rocked lovingly from side to side. Max kissed and groaned into her neck while she stroked her calves against the back of his thighs.

A strange urge came over her out of the joy Max provided, and she reached a hand over his shoulder, seeking Maggie's hand (she was the one who'd blessed her with this man in her life, after all). No grasp came, and her smile faltered.

Clutched to Max, holding him in an embrace, she darted her eyes around his shoulders but didn't see Maggie.

"Max...?"

He groaned, pushing deep, and while he chased down what he needed, she put one hand on the back of his head, gripped one of his cute butt cheeks, and peered over his back. Maggie was gone.

Max came then, and she stroked his hair as he grunted and bucked and made her insides slippery. He stabbed and groaned, withdrew, plunged deep

and shook, the muscles of his ass squirming under her fingers as she clawed him, loving the feel of his seed inside her.

He supported himself over her, panting, sweating, his hair hanging over his forehead like a comma.

“What’s, ha... what’s wrong?” he asked her.

She didn’t know what to tell him.

Confessional

SATURDAY, MAY 8

MAX CAME out of the bathroom, naked, with his hard shiny dick wagging. If she wasn't so upset, she would be encouraging him for round two.

"She's not in there?"

Max shook his head. "No, but it's alright, Keely."

"Did I do something wrong?"

He shook his head as he returned to bed.

"What do you mean no?"

He shrugged and climbed up to join her. "She'll be okay."

"How do you know?"

"I don't," he admitted.

"I can't believe we did that..."

"Keely, it was awesome, it was amazing. You're amazing," he said, and embraced her while she struggled mildly against his clutching.

"Is she mad, yeh think?"

"No, Keely, she just wants to be alone."

Now she covered her face with her hands and listened to her breaths score against her palms. "Did I do anything wrong, Max? Tell me for real..."

"You did everything right," he said and kissed her collarbone.

She lightly beat her fists against her forehead. "Aw, Max, with a girl, Max, I did it with a girl..."

"Not any girl..."

"Aye, just your old girlfriend and my good friend..."

“You’re my girlfriend,” he said and kissed her again. “It wasn’t any girl. It was Maggie. She needed us and now she left us alone.”

“She got what she needed?”

“She did, Keely. She wanted that. She loved it. She let us be.”

“Are you sure?”

“I’m sure. She wants us to be alone, and she wants to be alone, too.”

“Max, I did terrible things,” she laughed.

“We all did *wonderful* things,” he said reassuringly.

He wasn’t wrong. It was just her resistance telling her they were awful things that were done. But what was so awful? Most of it was pretty amazing if you could get past the jealousy.

“Oh God,” she moaned now, burying her face in her hands again.

“What?”

“Cole. What about Cole?”

“Maggie’ll talk to him.”

“He’s gonna hate me.”

“No, he won’t at all. I mean it.”

“What did we do?”

“Hey,” he said, getting her attention. “We supported her when she was feeling lousy. Made her feel good. Didn’t you feel good?”

She hesitated, but admitted: “I did feel good.”

“Maggie’s fine,” he said now, getting closer, “talk to her in the morning, you’ll see...”

They looked at each other a long moment until she felt at ease. But then she asked: “What did she do?”

“What do you mean?”

“She was worried your family knew what she did to you...?”

“Oh.”

“Can’t you tell me...?”

“It’s... major.”

She groaned, rubbed her forehead, wanted to forget it, but couldn’t. “It’s killing me, Max. I try so hard to stay out of your business, but I need to know sometimes, too.”

“It’s Maggie’s story, though.”

“It’s yours, Max. You know it’s yours. She said it right in front of me.”

Max tongued the corner of his mouth as he thought about it, looking across the room.

“Max...?”

He said, “I’ll tell you.”

“You will?”

“I *should* tell you.”

“I didn’t nag it out of you, did I? I don’t want that...”

“No, you’re right. She brought it up, and you were there.”

“And we *shared* tonight. We *really* shared.”

“It’s not a good story.”

“Okay...”

“Promise me you won’t be mad at her, or think bad of her...”

“Just tell me.”

“It was the beginning of our end.”

“It’s not going to upset you, is it?”

He slow nodded, said, “I’ll still tell you. It was the end of our engagement.”

“You were engaged at the time...”

“Yeah,” he said, wiped at the corners of his mouth. His eyes got glassy and far away and he looked to the side. “I dropped by her dorm—”

“At Farm?”

“At Farm. I dropped by and she was acting strange—”

“She wasn’t expecting you?”

He shook his head no. “She wore this shirt, a Wrestling shirt from state, and she was trying to, I don’t know, I guess later I figured she was trying to get rid of me. But I was... I was flipping through her sketchbook and I see all these drawings of this guy, the same guy, like figure class drawings?...”

“Uh-huh?” she said, stroked a finger on his chest.

“This guy was naked and, like, muscular... Maggie said she wanted to get rid of me because she needed to draw. I, uh, when she wasn’t in the room... I hid in her closet.”

“Yeh did not,” she blurted.

“I did,” he said, looking in her eyes with raised brows.

“Oh, Max, are you for real, like?”

He nodded, kept her gaze.

She couldn’t believe it, tried to picture this handsome guy hiding in a dark closet like a little weirdo, peeping out at Maggie. She said, “Oh, fuck, Max, was this guy a Wrestler, like?”

He nodded.

It was horrible. There was no denying where the story would go and she felt bottomless empathy. Like a shelf that supported her insides had been pulled away, and they all fell to the darkness below. Max watched Maggie fuck some wrestler. “You got to be kidding me.”

“No. Is that terrible?”

“I just can’t believe she did that. She seems so nice...”

“No, that I hid. Is *that* terrible?”

“No, Max,” she said, ran her finger along his cheekbone. “You were scared. You’re human...”

“Well...”

“She’d been expecting him? You watched her?”

“Yeah.”

“How could you stand it?”

“That’s what was weird.”

“You watched her have sex?”

He shook his head no again, eyes open but staring at the ceiling. He ran his hand through his hair, blinking.

“You couldn’t?”

“She didn’t have sex with him.”

“She didn’t? What did she do?”

His face turned to hers. “Don’t tell Maggie I told you this.”

“I won’t, Max.”

“She would not want you to know this.”

“You don’t have to tell me.” He watched Maggie give this wrestler a blow job. How awful.

“She drew him,” Max said, turning to look at the ceiling again.

“Drew him?”

“He was naked.” Now Max paused, nodded, sucked his teeth. “I don’t know how to explain it... Well, geez, the guy’s naked and Maggie’s sitting there wearing the guy’s Wrestling shirt and some panties—that’s all—and he starts to get a hard-on.”

“I just can’t believe this,” she said.

“Anyway the guy gets hard, and the two of them are acting, you know, fucking cute with each other, Maggie’s all bashful, and he’s playing the stud, telling her if she wants to keep drawing she should make him come so it’ll go down.”

“That’s fucking gross.”

“Right? But it wasn’t. They were playing, Maggie’s not dumb, not by a long shot, she knows what’s up. So she tells the guy to jerk off again and she’ll watch.”

“Again?”

“Yeah. This had happened before.”

Her eyes lost focus, and she reeled, had to put her fingers to her forehead. She felt lightheaded. “Max, that’s so awful. So painful, I’m so sorry. I can *feel* it.” She had to blink away wet, and she rubbed her hand on his chest. He played with her fingers.

“This guy gets her to spit in his hand and he jerks off while she stands and watches.”

“This is unreal. And you’re stuck in the closet?”

“This is where it gets weird.”

“Oh, this is where it gets weird?” she laughed but Max didn’t. She scratched her nails on his chest.

“I’m not mad when I’m watching. I mean I *am*, I’m mad, but I have all these other feelings, too. I love her. I mean, I really loved her.”

Max’s eyes went teary in an instant and he rubbed them.

“It’s okay,” she whispered.

“I liked it, too.”

She nodded, pursed her lips, let her cheek press his side and watched him still.

He said, “Is that crazy? I liked it.”

“I don’t judge, Max.”

“I know you don’t,” he said.

“That’s all she did? Watch?”

“No, he got her to hold his balls while he came.”

She kissed his side to prevent herself from laughing. It was a ridiculous image to picture but now would not be the time to bust out about it; she hoped she could make him laugh about it soon.

Max sighed and rubbed her arm, not looking at her. The urge to laugh dissipated, and she said, “She didn’t sleep with him?”

He shook his head. “So the guy—I don’t know how to say it, he’s like a good-looking guy, he’s really muscular—”

“Oh…”

“Oh, what?”

“Nothing,” she said, not wanting to finish his thought and be wrong.

“No, say it.”

“You go.”

“He’s about as hot as a guy can be, as far as a girl would consider...”

She went for it. “He was big.”

It stopped him; he cocked his head. “Really big,” he said, and she sighed with relief. The story was coming into focus, Max’s kink crystallizing before her like she spun the fine adjustment on a microscope. “I get it,” she breathed. Max exhaled a chortle and squeezed her.

As if to frame this point more comparatively, Max added, “Bigger than Cole.”

She nodded.

“A black guy. Half black.”

“Okay.”

“Well, then Maggie sits there, confessing to this guy, like, how she has no sexual experience except with me practically, and how she’s missing out on all... And this guy is naked and hugging her. He’s jacked, and his dick is half-hard still, and I’m not kidding, it’s like the size of Maggie’s forearm, and I don’t know, it was tender... And I loved her, and I saw this lust in her, and I could see why she wanted that guy, could see all he offered and I didn’t hate it, I didn’t... I, like, wanted it for her, but I wanted to watch. I didn’t want to be separate.”

“It’s not crazy, Max.”

“No?”

“Not when you say it like that.”

“It seemed crazy, but...”

“You have a good heart, Max.”

“Doesn’t mean it wasn’t crazy. I made some big mistakes along the way.”

That was obvious. But he better not think it was a dick that took his Maggie away. “Kinks are beautiful, Max. Kinks are those slippery, electric parts of your soul, and if you’ve got it, it makes life worth living.”

He chuckled.

“You don’t want that high-wire tension of your kink anymore?”

He winced, bit the inside of his cheek. “You see that’s my kink?”

“Is it?”

“I don’t know. After a while I didn’t know anything anymore. Maggie and I got turned upside down.”

“You guys broke the engagement, then she started dating Cole, too?”

“Something like that,” he murmured, put his hand over hers and looked blankly up at the ceiling like there was a night sky full of stars. She sat with him for a long while, just being with him, not pushing him, just letting him think about whatever made him feel better. Then it hit her.

She clapped her hands so loud and suddenly she startled even herself. Max jumped. “Jay Carmichael,” she shouted.

Max blanched and gaped at her wide-eyed.

“That’s your fella, right?” She could tell by his face she should have kept her mouth shut.

His mouth opened and closed, his eyes stared with horror.

She put up her hands and said, “Oh, I don’t know him. Never met him.” Max worried she’d been with this demon from his nightmares.

Max exhaled, rolled his eyes to look up at the headboard.

“I’m sorry, Max, I’m sorry. He was a wrestler at Vermont State, right?—half-black. People used to talk about him.”

“What did they say?” he said, his mouth moving stiffly.

She shrugged. “Just he’s hot.”

He met her gaze for a few beats. “Well, fuck, anyway, that’s how it started and all, and that’s how it unraveled,” Max said and rolled to face her.

She touched his lower lip, watched how her finger sunk in its curl. Timid, she said, “What about me? Do you think that with me?”

“Think what?”

“Me with other people?”

His mouth shifted to one side; he shook his head no. “I put it out of my head.”

Now she poked at his top lip, studying her finger on him. “That why you get so turned on when I dirty talk about Cole?”

He nodded.

“Let’s keep it there, Max.”

“Let’s keep it there,” he agreed. His hand moved to her hip, the tip of his hard-on inserted in the cup of her navel. She reached down and gripped it. It was like iron. He was good for another go, as usual. She said, “Big dicks aren’t what you think.”

He scoffed then chuckled. “They’re not?”

“I’ll look at pictures of big dicks all day long, but they’re not that great, like.”

“But you’d look at pictures? All day long...”

“With me mates,” she laughed. When Max gawped at her, she said, “Well, they’re funny, big dicks. They’re weird. And some are sexy, yeah. But sometimes when a guy pulls out a real hammer you’re like, oh, not tonight, yeah?”

“Not tonight?”

“It’s a chore, Max.”

“You don’t like them?”

“Aye, Jesus, Max. I don’t know. Sometimes, yeah. Sometimes no.” A thought clarified: “If a guy whips out a big dick I’m not dropping my purse and falling on my knees to worship it.”

“I don’t think that.”

“You do a little.”

He rolled his eyes.

“Truth is, I’ll take a look at it, and, yeah, I’m paying attention, but it’s not what you think it is.”

They both looked down as she slowly jerked him, choking his extra skin up around the rim of his cock head.

He said, “You don’t think it’s a sign of, I don’t know... power?”

“Male power? Are you serious? That’s exactly what it’s not. I see a guy with a big dick and dumb empty eyes giving me a shit-eating grin I’m like Oh, sweetheart, you think that’s all there is, what’s between your legs?... Then I honestly feel a little sad for them.”

“You’re such a fucking lawyer,” he laughed.

“Hey,” she said, and tugged his face to meet hers with one finger on his chin. “I like to have fun in bed. That’s why I like you. If a guy has a big dick, it’s like, I guess I’m supposed to talk about how big his dick is, he’s sure going to. Then what? It’s hard to use your mouth, and if you’re not feelin’ up to it between your hips, it’s a nightmare, believe me. So I’ll use me hand? Hot, sure, sometimes. Depends. You’re a sure thing, Max. A *sure thing* every time. One of the best lovers I have ever had, and I put my hand to God and the church of St. Brigid, and swear on me beautiful face, strike me dead if I’m lyin’.”

He smirked. “One of?”

Something hit her so hard she gasped. A truth. “There’s no first place, Max. It’s not like that. There’re guys that are adequate, guys that are all right, some good, guys that shite the bed, and there’re guys like you. Guys

who fucking get it, yeah? Guys who get in me head.” She actually teared up. It made her smile. “You get in my head so fuckin’ bad, Max. I think about sex with you when we’re apart.”

His smirk faded, the dimple in his cheek easing away. His deep soulful eyes softened. For a moment there was perfect beauty in their connection and she held her breath. Max sighed, quietly said, “I’m telling you the saddest story of my life and you got me so hard it hurts.”

That suppressed laugh from earlier bolted out of her and she cackled into his armpit. She grabbed his cock again and gave it a few good hard pumps. She said, “I love this dick. This is a perfect dick.” She bit his chest. Her hand moved up to touch between his eyes. “I love this brain. I love it.” Now she squeezed his cheeks. “I love this face. I could stare at this face forever.” She puckered his lips, and squirmed up to kiss them. She did, sucked them, too, then smiled. “And this heart?...” she said and lay her hand on his chest.

What was to be said next was obvious, but did she say it now? Did you say it at such a tender time when he shared how another girl who he loved and loved him back ran a steely but somehow loving blade through this heart?

It was time.

“I love you, Max. Love you like I’ve never loved anyone before.”

Those plump lips pulled in and his eyes swelled. Then he smiled. He exhaled, “Whoah.”

For a second she thought she’d made a mistake, but he took her hand. “I love you, Keely. I’ve known a while, but I was afraid to say it.”

“Why?”

“Scare you off, I guess.”

“You can’t scare me, Max.”

He bounced his eyebrows as if to say you ain’t seen nothing yet, and they both laughed. He kissed her, and they held each other, thighs pressing. “I love you, Keely. Love you in a way that I never knew I could. You’re just everything...”

They rolled around together in the warm bed, totally naked, totally in love and happy. Max got over her. As he slid inside her she whispered, “Tell me more about Jay’s huge dick, I wouldn’t mind hearing about it,” and smiled at the way it made her lover’s eyelashes flutter like a hummingbird.

Patch

SUNDAY, MAY 9

TO GO in to Maggie's room, she decided to stay in her pajamas. That's what she'd told Max after he refused to be the one to come in and see how she was doing. *Don't you think you should do it?...*

She could have argued her way out of it—she was good at arguing—but he was right. The awkwardness would be between her and her friend. And since he was right, and this was about friendship, she let him win. So now she was standing outside Maggie's door, wearing her Capri length flannel PJ bottoms and a white hoodie with her hands tucked up in the sleeves. If she dressed, she thought, and Maggie *wasn't* dressed, it might make her feel ill at ease. She took a deep breath, held it, prepared herself. With two knuckles, she rapped on the door and said Maggie's name softly.

Maggie responded with a quiet *Yeah?*

"I'm coming in," she said, flicked the door lever over and held it unlatched and waited for an objection. There was none, so she eased the door open. Maggie was in bed, laptop open. She lay with her back to the door and was looking over her shoulder.

Nothing was said, and she shuffled in, came to the side of the bed and sat down, her tucked-away hands folded in her lap. Maggie closed the laptop, sat upright pushing two pillows up higher and rested her back against them.

"So how's it going?" she asked her.

Maggie's eyebrows raised, and there was a sheepish smirk, but she didn't commit to a full smile. "I don't know. How's it going with you?"

"I dunno, I got a confession to make."

“What’s that?”

“I think I got a little crazy last night.”

“What a coincidence. So did I.”

It felt okay to smile. It didn’t look like there would be awful tears of regret this morning. Her shoulders relaxed. “How are you feeling this fine A.M.?”

“How are *you* feeling?”

She shrugged. “I don’t know.”

Maggie’s smile faded, and she bit her upper lip while their eyes darted over each other’s. She quietly asked: “Was it a mistake?”

She shook her head. “No, definitely not. Not a mistake.”

Maggie melted and gave a warm smile. “I don’t think it was a mistake either.”

She lowered her eyes. “I just don’t know what to think about it.”

“I don’t either.”

She leaned a little closer, put a hand out to support her weight. She said, “I liked it. But...”

“I liked it too,” Maggie said softly, made a sort of sad face and dipped her chin downward.

“It should probably be a one-time thing.”

Maggie nodded, gathered her hands together and put her fingers in scissors. “If that’s what you want.”

“Did you want more?”

Maggie’s eyes went up as if she were contemplating. She said, “I don’t want to talk about it. Whatever you want, I’ll respect it.”

Neither of them said anything for a long while, just sitting there looking down, her looking at the bedcover and Maggie looking at her hands.

She said, “You left us.”

Maggie nodded.

She sighed, worried about how to say this. “I wasn’t... you know... doing *that* on purpose.”

“Doing what?”

“Sometimes I make noise. But that’s what I do. I wasn’t doing it, you know, to be, I don’t know... *theatrical*. You know, like I’m just going crazy, like I’m mad at you and I want you to know how great Max is and you must be missing him...”

“I know what I’m missing.”

She held Maggie's gaze, tried to picture her when they were the same age and Maggie cheated on Max with Jay Carmichael. Still couldn't believe it....

"I wasn't doing that on purpose, to make a point or whatever. It's embarrassing, but that's just what I do."

"I know that's what you do." Maggie looked at her blankly.

"Do you?"

"We've heard you before," she said and smirked. "In our guest room."

"That's embarrassing," she mumbled, wondering if Cole recognized those sounds and if Maggie wondered if she'd made them when Cole fucked her. Did the two of them sit in bed awkwardly? Did Maggie hate hearing them, knowing she was with her beloved Max, and knowing she'd probably made the same sounds with her boyfriend sitting next to her?

Maggie said, "Don't be embarrassed."

"I try to be quiet."

Maggie scratched her head, still looking down, she said, "We don't have to have sex. I want to. But we don't have to. But you need to know you mean so much to me. I really care about you. I think about you all the time."

It surprised her, and she didn't know what to say, looking at this girl she'd admired so long and hearing that she wanted intimacy. "I'm glad we did that last night. It hurt me so bad to hear how you felt..."

"Thank you for being there for me. I was. I was really sad."

"I don't want that."

"You guys made me feel better."

She brightened at the thought of being there for her, and for getting past a certain jealous shield she'd had up between them. A manufactured and apparently unnecessary thing. After last night, their friendship could grow.

She said, "Hey, guess what?" trying to sound bright and hopeful.

Maggie looked up.

"Max told me he loves me last night."

Maggie's eyes widened, but her mouth didn't smile. "Wow," she said. She snorted, looked away and now her smile did come, though it was lopsided. "I knew it. I could see it in his eyes, the way he looks at you..."

"I told him I love him too. I love him. I do."

"I'm really happy," she said, and though her words sounded honest, there was a heaviness to them. "When I'm right, I'm right."

"You were right."

Now Maggie's smile lightened, her eyes narrowing warmly.

She said, "Are we okay?"

"Yeah, of course we're okay. It's up to you. I know I'm *totally* okay. I hope I didn't freak you out."

"I wanted to."

"I know, but I wanted to *first*. I kissed *you*..."

"I liked it." She lifted both her legs so she was fully on the bed now, and as soon as Maggie saw her coming near the middle, she scooted down on her butt to get closer. It was definite that they were going to hug, but when their eyes met they stopped. Maggie looked troubled.

She said, "Are we going to hug?"

Maggie nodded and threw her arms around her.

She rubbed her back. "We're totally okay. We're totally more than okay."

"That's all I want," Maggie said, squeezing her. They stayed like that for a while, not saying anything, just hugging.

When they finally parted, Keely said, "Now we gotta go have brunch and try to keep our faces straight."

Maggie giggled and blurted a wet bubble from her mouth which she covered quickly with both hands. "Oh my God, I know, it's going to be so weird."

"Don't make any faces at me and don't try to make me laugh."

"We'll be on our best behavior," Maggie said smiling broad.

They were very close, and it looked for a moment that Maggie might try to kiss her again. Her mouth slackened. She would receive it. But Maggie merely smiled happy and wide and hugged her tight again.

"Alright," she said, laughing, breaking them up. "Get yourself showered, we can head over to the Miltons'. I'm sending Max to Starbucks, what can he get you?"

"Maxy knows my order," she said, and it didn't worry her one bit that Max and Maggie were still close.

SHE WATCHED KEELY LEAVE, looking so adorable and effortless in sweats and PJs. The hug could have gone all morning; her heart swelled and

pounded when she hugged that girl. Keely turned and waved at the door, that silky red hair swaying, giving that goofy but beautiful Keely-smile—then she backed out while they both waved like dummies, trying to outdo each other with smiling showmanship.

When the door closed, she groaned and collapsed face-first on the bedding. She wrecked it. That kiss last night had been on her own lips for the longest time, aching to be planted on Keely. And how did she do it? Leverage. By crying. By being so sad that beautiful girl would never turn down a kiss because she wouldn't want to hurt feelings.

But it had been awesome. She didn't regret it. It wasn't how she thought it might happen if she'd ever built the nerve, but now it was done.

At least she knew where she stood.

Cole said it was a phase. And it was. It had to be. An infatuation with a pretty girl who said all the right things even when they were wrong because she had this charm that could get her out of any trouble and she acted like she didn't even know she had it. Keely was like all those girls in private school who'd intimidated her so much, only this one had a heart and a beautiful soul.

She groaned again, writhing her hands up under her to wipe at her cheeks. Yup, tears. She sat up, groaned again because groaning seemed to push away some of the heartache. When she'd booked this trip to come out and see June she could never have anticipated it would have been so hard on her.

She exhaled shakily, eyes turned up to the ceiling.

Now she sobbed lightly. She'd have to tell Cole what she did. He'd be okay. He was always okay. But she'd been with Maxy and she told him she was done with that. He didn't believe her, and it turns out he was right. It would be fine with him. He might be mad that he wasn't here, but he wouldn't be mad at the things she'd done. But in the re-telling she'd have to confront her feeling of rejection, how she felt stupid. It would break her down, but at least she would have him there to hold her.

When Keely had come in, she'd honestly hoped it would be to invite her in for a shower. The three of them. Or even just the two. In the fantasies she'd had with her and Keely, they were alone. It went smooth, and Keely would make her laugh, take the lead because she was so experienced. She'd hoped Keely had been with a girl before in boarding school. She wanted to

take her time, wanted to explore her. Most: she wanted to make her make those noises. To be the one that could mean something like that to her.

She collapsed on her back with her legs still crossed, arm slashing around trying to find her phone up near her computer.

She whimpered as more tears came and made her vision go blurry. She texted Cole.

Maggie: I miss u so so so much baby I wish I was home right now 💕

Family

SUNDAY, MAY 9

ALL DRESSED up again in her L.L. Bean wear, they sat at the Milton dining room table for brunch before they had to drive to the airport.

Max's dad took the head of the table, June sat to his side and they held hands. June looked bright today. Franny said she got a good rest last night. Happy her kids were home, she'd said, and Franny agreed, adding the damn dog also tired her out.

She sat with Max on her left, Maggie on her right, Mike and Tabitha further down. Franny and Ronaldo sat opposite, and Abigail and Connor were next to them. Connor wore his sunglasses and a sour expression, his arms folded as he sunk into the stiff high-back chair.

Franny did up the breakfast, and she'd helped by making a soda bread. Maggie joined in. Eggs and bacon and sausages were self-serve from silver trays in the table's center, and everyone helped themselves. Her mood was so much lighter than yesterday. It was like all the tension was gone and she finally felt right at home.

Then June said to her, "What did you girls get up to last night?"

She was extended across the table, holding a platter of bacon being passed by Abigail. "How do you mean?" she asked.

Maggie batted her knee against her thigh under the table, and she jolted.

"Did Max take care of you two?"

Maggie hit her harder with her knee and she made an embarrassing donkey sound that got everyone looking her way.

June said, "What were you up to? Look at their faces, Keith. Look at the color on those cheeks. Did you go for a swim?"

Now her cheeks were blazing, and her breath came in a flutter, knowing everyone was watching. When she spoke her voice was timid and close to breaking. “Just a good night’s sleep...”

She forked bacon onto Maggie’s plate and Maggie pinched her leg.

June said, “Your cheeks are just glowing...”

She ventured a glance at Maggie’s eyes which could have been the worst thing to do but Maggie saw it coming and looked straight ahead, lifting to drink from a tea cup to shield her smile.

Now it wasn’t funny, though, and it was getting weird, so she laser-beamed the side of Maggie’s face with her eyes, and curled her expression down to her most serious mean-mugging she could manage—one of abject destruction should Maggie not knock it off.

Maggie turned to face her—sensing probably the intense heat from the stare—at the exact moment Keith agreed with June, saying, “Yeah, they must have some beds in the Marriott.”

They both heard it, knew it was trouble. Maggie’s eyes went over her face and she’d forgotten that awful expression she’d worked her face into as warning. She snorted in her throat. Maggie flinched, smirked, and it got her smirking in return.

It was the tiniest blip of time, but something happened in that moment that she would later analyze because it was so profound. An intimacy, a closeness, a feeling of being together and supported and, wow, wait, loved? And she felt the same way. Love. Not romantic love but something huge and fuzzy and cuddly.

The whole thing was ruined though because Maggie blurted, choked, laughed, did a spit-take of tea into her scrambled eggs.

It had her collapsing on her friend, hugging her back and so glad to hear her laughing, too, because it had been an embarrassing sight. But she’d support her...

SHE STRUGGLED FOR AIR, drew it in and it felt like fire. Sugary tea was in her nose and she’d never felt like such an idiot. The whole time trying to make Keely laugh and it blew up in her face in the grandest of fashion. She buried her face in a napkin and cleared her throat. Keely hugged her while

she shook with laughter despite the shame and the terrible table manners. Mother would have punished her gravely for this.

When she finally felt brave enough, she looked up at the man she cherished; Keith, amused but trying not to look it, poised with a forkful of scrambled eggs and a raised eyebrow. It got her laughing again, and she had to hide her face.

She heard Keith say, “Did I say something funny, scarecrow? Are the beds good there?”

Keely laughed, said, “They don’t allow dogs,” and that brought Franny in on the joke to make it cloudier and safer for two girls who did naughty things with each other last night.

She waved her hands back and forth, clearing her throat, said to everyone, “Sorry, I’m sorry, the tea was hotter than I thought,” her voice a phlegmy wheeze. Keely rubbed a circle on her back.

Keith held her under comical surveillance for another beat, then turned his attention to the other side of the table. He said, “Didn’t you sleep at the Marriott, too, Connor?”

Connor’s mouth was surly and pouted. He looked like he ached all over. From under his black sunglasses he grunted an affirmation.

Keith said, “Yeah? How come you don’t look like they do? Look how refreshed they are.”

“I don’t know,” he grumbled, lips sticking together.

“You don’t know? Did you *find* the bed? It looks like you slept on a park bench.”

Abigail smiled then rattled out her boyfriend: “He was out late with some boys from high school.”

“Ah,” Keith said. “Up to your old shenanigans.”

That made Keely chuckle.

Keith looked at her. “Is it funny when I say shenanigans?” He stared at her, eyes blinking, trying to be funny by being stern and serious. She sat straighter like a good girl, smirking. “It’s funny,” she said. Maggie held her hand under the table and Keely didn’t withdraw. In fact, she *squeezed*.

He returned to Connor. “I hope you weren’t out with Corduroy, that guy has serious legal trouble already and he’s only twenty-five.”

Max said, “Yeah, Dad, he was out with Corduroy...”

CONNOR FLICKED his chin his way and mouthed: *Fuck you, Max.*

He grinned and scratched his eyebrow with his middle finger while Dad continued to grill him, and Connor suffered through a nasty-looking hangover.

Elbow up on the chair's crest rail, his hand ventured over to his girl, caressed her woolen upper back, her soft hair like silk on the back of his hand. She made a comical shiver and smiled over her shoulder at him, batting her eyelashes. She wiggled her hand, wanting it to be held, and he obliged.

Across the table, Connor did his best to defend against Dad, but there was no winning, and he and Keely enjoyed the show. Maggie, too, looked quite happy on Keely's other side, though she'd been a little morose on the car ride over.

He watched Keely as she looked back and forth between Dad and Connor, mouth ready to smile, halfway there. Her words were stuck in him like an ear-worm. The names she'd called men's big cocks. A hammer. *If he has a real hammer... If you're not up to it between your hips... It's hard to use your mouth on a big one, you have to use your hand and that can be hot...* Proof of her past right before his ears, and proof she was blunt. Bluntness was one of the things he cherished about her. When they got home, he was going to ask her all about the things she'd done, and he felt pretty good about his chances she would tell him bluntly. Maybe even play it up for his pleasure. His darkness didn't frighten her, didn't turn her off. It made her curious. *And goddammit she looked right in his eyes and said she loved him.* She said it fucking first.

She laughed now, threw her head back, showed off those teeth and that graceful neck; her ginger mane tossed over one shoulder and he was delighted to have that ache in his heart again. Blood pulsed through him like it hadn't in years. He squeezed her hand, brought it up and kissed it.

Now there was a hissing sound—short, sharp. He looked past Keely's back, past Maggie and Tabitha, to see Mike leaning back and giving him that look that usually meant he was going to get a beating.

What? he mouthed.

Mike darted a look to Connor, like Connor had been telling him things, but Connor was still stuck with Dad's jabs. He mouthed *Did you?*

What?

Mike put it straight: *Fuck those two girls*. His expression was one of rage.

Of course, he mouthed and shrugged, making like Mike was an idiot for even asking.

Mike said aloud now, “Hey, fuck you, Max,” and took a piece of soda bread to wing it at him. He leaned his chair back, holding the bread sidearm like he was skipping a stone at the lake, making sure he’d get all Max and no Keely—when Dad’s dog Bubbles snatched it from his hand out of nowhere like she’d been laying in wait under the table for just such an opportunity.

Mike yowled and recoiled, his hand snapping up to his shoulder. He almost pitched backward in his teetering chair but was able to grab the table to save himself. The table shook and everyone’s juice glasses wobbled, a mimosa toppled and everyone laughed at the eldest and most jackass Milton because they loved him

Max looked around the table. Mom and Dad laughing, Mom knowing how much Dad needed the dog right now, his recovery during her recovery, and Franny chasing Bubbles around the far side, cursing whoever let the dog back in. Connor laughed and grimaced at the stabbing pain laughing provoked; Abigail rubbed his neck. Next to him the girl he’d wanted them to meet saw the Miltons at their best which was also sometimes their worst. And she got it. She laughed honestly. She held hands with Maggie. He saw their hands together now. His girl supporting their friend through this difficult time when she needed someone who understood her.

He’d told Keely about that window of time when it seemed like his family was complete and the way it should be. But maybe it wasn’t like a window. Because this right here could go on forever and he would soak in every golden second. Maybe it was like riding a wave. You had crests and valleys, and sometimes you rode the crest a long while. But if your boat was steady, you could survive the lows of rough water, and if you had a good navigator, say a redhead with a dirty mouth, well, maybe you could go where the water was always warm and the sky perfect.

To be continued in Book Three...

www.licoricebooks.com

Afterword

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two down the road!

Visit my website!

ktmorrison.com

hotwifebooks.com